

1 Peter: A Translation and Commentary

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Dedicated to Stevie and Kimmy Parris, inquisitive and supportive friends

Preface

This document contains a literal translation of the book of 1 Peter, followed by a verse-by-verse commentary. Brackets indicate words not found in the original but added for clarity.

In the interest of brevity, I have opted to exclude discussions on textual variants. This may lead to a few surprises, since I take a minority position in that I prefer Byzantine readings over alternatives, whereas most modern translations tend to prefer Alexandrian readings. That is to say—greatly simplifying a complicated field of study—I tend to prefer the testimony of the majority of manuscripts, while modern scholarship generally gravitates to old manuscripts, especially certain ones deemed particularly reliable. Yet in the New Testament a difference of reading only rarely causes an appreciable difference in thrust of a sentence or paragraph; and rarely, if ever, does a textual variant make an appreciable difference in questions of doctrine.

Also in the interest of brevity, I have interacted with other commentaries in only a limited way.

Within the commentary section, italics indicate quotations from the passage of Scripture at hand. Multiple comments on a single verse are differentiated by a period followed by a number.

May God preserve his people in their pilgrimage.

Translation

1:1 Peter, an apostle of Jesus Christ. To the elect sojourners of the dispersion across Pontus, Galatia, Cappadocia, Asia, and Bithynia, **2** according to the foreknowledge of God the Father in the sanctification of the Spirit for obedience and sprinkling by the blood of Jesus Christ. Grace to you, and peace be multiplied!

1:3 Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, who in accordance with his abundant mercy caused us to be born again to a living hope through the resurrection of Jesus Christ from the dead, **4** resulting in an undying, uncontaminable, and unfading inheritance reserved in the heavens for you **5** who by God's power are being protected through faith for a salvation ready to be revealed in the last time, **6** in which [final day] you rejoice, even if now, if necessary, for a short time you have been made sorrowful by diverse trials, **7** in order that the genuineness of your faith—[something] much more valuable than perishable gold—tested by fire, might be found worthy of praise, and honor, and of glory at the revelation of Jesus Christ, **8** whom—though you have not known him personally—you love, [and] in whom—though not presently seeing him, but believing—you rejoice with a joy that is inexpressible and glorious, **9** receiving as the final result of your your faith, the salvation of [your] souls, **10** concerning which salvation the prophets who prophesied concerning the grace that would obtain in your cases

made diligent search and inquiry, **11** inquiring as to what or what manner of time the Spirit of Christ within them was indicating as he bore witness ahead of time to the sufferings of Christ and the following glories, **12** to whom it was revealed that it was not for themselves, but for you that they were ministering these things, which things have now been announced to you through those who proclaimed the gospel to you by the Holy Spirit who has been sent from heaven, into which things angels long to set their gaze.

1:13 So then, preparing your minds for action, [that is,] being completely sober, hope completely in the grace that is being borne to you at the revelation of Jesus Christ. **14** As obedient children, not being conformed to the former lusts that you had in your ignorance, **15** but rather in accordance with the holiness of the one who called you, you too be holy in all your conduct, **16** since it is written, “You shall be holy, for I am holy.”

1:17 And if you invoke the help of the Father, the one who without partiality judges each person according to his deeds, conduct the time of your sojourning in fear, **18** since you know that it is not with corruptible things—silver or gold—that you have been redeemed from your futile way of life you inherited from your ancestors, **19** but rather with the precious blood—as of a perfect and spotless lamb—of Christ, **20** foreknown on the one hand from before the foundation of the world, made manifest on the other hand at the final days of time for your sakes **21** who through him have believed in God, who raised him from the dead and gave him glory, so that your faith—and [your] hope—rest in God.

1:22 Having purified your souls in the obedience of the truth through the Spirit for an unfeigned familial love, from a clean heart love one another fervently, **23** since you have been born again not from a corruptible seed, but from an incorruptible one—through the living and abiding word of God. **24** For, “All flesh is like grass, and all the glory of humankind is like the blossoming of grass. Grass has withered, and its blossom has fallen, **25** but the word of the Lord abides eternally.” Now this is the word that was proclaimed to you.

2:1 Therefore, putting away all wickedness and all deception and hypocrisy and ill-will and all slander, **2** as newborn infants long for the rational, pure milk, in order that by it you may grow, **3** since you have tasted that the Lord is good, **4** to whom approaching as to a living stone—[a stone] rejected on the one hand by people but chosen, [and] honored, by God **5**—you yourselves also, being comparable to living stones, are being built into a spiritual temple, a holy priesthood, to bring spiritual sacrifices which are thoroughly pleasing to God through Jesus Christ, **6** since this [statement] stands in Scripture: “Behold, I am laying in Zion a chosen, honored cornerstone, and the person who believes in him will by no means be put to shame.” **7** So to you who believe is this honor; but to those who disobey[, the following Scriptures apply]: “The stone that the builders rejected—that very stone became the chief cornerstone,” **8** and, “A stone of stumbling and a rock of offense”—[such passages as these apply to those] who stumble at the word, being disobedient, to which [fate] they were indeed appointed. **9** But you are a chosen people, a royal priesthood, a holy nation, a people for a treasured possession [of God’s], so that you may proclaim the excellencies of him who called you out of darkness into his awe-inspiring light—**10** you who once were not a people, but now are the people of God; who had not been shown mercy, but now have been shown mercy.

2:11 Beloved, I exhort you as foreigners and sojourners: abstain from the fleshly lusts that wage war against your soul, **12** maintaining honorable conduct among the gentiles; then, even though they malign you as evildoers, they will by your honorable deeds, which they will have seen, give glory to God on the day of reckoning.

2:13 Submit, then, to every human [institutional] creation on the Lord’s account—whether to a king as having authority, **14** or to governors as those sent by him for justice to those who do what is evil and for recognition of those who do what is right **15** (for such is the will of God, that by doing what is right you may silence the foolish words of the ignorant)—**16** as free people, and that not using your freedom as a coverup for evil, but rather as servants of God. **17** Honor everyone; love the brotherhood;

fear God; honor the king.

2:18 Servants, submit with all respect to your masters—not only to the ones that are kind and reasonable, but also to ones that are unfair. **19** For this is favor, if—because of one’s consciousness of God[’s presence]—a person endures griefs as he or she suffers unjustly. **20** After all, what renown is there if, when you sin and suffer [as a result], you stay strong? On the other hand, if you do what is right and [yet] suffer, this is favor before God. **21** For you were called for that purpose, for Christ also suffered on our behalf, leaving you a model so that you can follow in his steps: **22** he had not sinned, nor was deceit found in his mouth; **23** when being insulted did not shoot back insults in reply, suffering did not threaten, but gave himself over to the one who judges justly; **24** he bore our sins in his body upon the tree, so that, our sins having been taken away, we might live to righteousness; by his wounds you are healed: **25** you were wandering like sheep, but have now returned to the shepherd and caretaker of your souls.

3:1 Likewise, wives, submit to your own husbands, in order that even if any of them are disobeying the word they may through their wives’ conduct be won without a word, **2** as they observe your respectful, pure conduct. **3** Wives should be known not for the outward—braiding of hair, and putting on golden ornamentation or wearing fancy dresses—**4**but rather for the hidden person of the heart by that which is imperishable: a quiet and gentle spirit, which is of immense value in the sight of God. **5** For in such a fashion in ancient times the holy women who hoped in God dressed themselves, submitting to their own husbands; **6** for example, Sarah submitted to Abraham, calling him “lord”—you have become Sarah’s children as you do what is right and are afraid of nothing.

3:7 Husbands likewise, live knowledgeably, as with a weaker vessel, assigning honor to the female [vessel] as indeed coheirs of the grace of life, so that your prayers will not be impeded.

3:8 Finally, all of you be harmonious, sympathetic, fraternal, compassionate, [and] friendly, **9** not repaying wrong for wrong or insult for insult, but on the contrary saying a blessing, knowing that you were called for this [purpose], so that you might inherit a blessing. **10** For “The one who desires to love life and to see good days—let that one stop his tongue from wrong and his lips from speaking deceit. **11** Let him incline away from wrong and toward good. Let him seek peace and pursue it. **12** For the eyes of the Lord are on the righteous, and his ears on their appeal, but the face of the Lord is against those who do wrong.”

3:13 And who is there to wrong you if you are imitators of what is good? **14** But if you do actually suffer for the sake of righteousness, “Blessed!” And do not fear what they fear, nor become hyperactive, **15** but sanctify the Lord God in your hearts, and always be ready to give a justification to everyone who asks you for the reason for the hope within you[, doing so] **16** with humility and respect, maintaining a good conscience, in order that in the matter in which they defame you as wrongdoers they who threaten your good conduct in Christ might be put to shame. **17** After all, it is better as doers of good, if God should happen so to will it, for you to suffer or be wronged. **18** For Christ [himself] also suffered once [for all] for sins, the righteous for the unrighteous, that he might bring you to God, having been put to death on the one hand in the flesh, yet raised to life on the other hand by the Spirit, **19** in whom he proclaimed [victory] to the spirits in prison, **20** who formerly were disobedient when the patience of God waited in the days of Noah as the ark was being prepared in which a few (specifically, eight) souls were saved through [the] water—**21**with respect to this water baptism as an antitype now saves us—not the removal of dirt from the flesh, but a pledge from a good conscience to God through the resurrection of Jesus Christ, **22** who, [now] at the right hand of God, has proceeded into heaven, angels and authorities and powers having submitted to him.

4:1 Therefore, with Christ having suffered on your behalf in the flesh, you also arm yourselves [for war] with the same mindset (for he who has suffered in the flesh has put an end to sins) **2** so that the remaining time in the flesh you may live not for humankind’s lusts, but rather for God’s will. **3** After all, the lifespan that has [already] passed is sufficient for you to do the will of the gentiles—spent in outrageous behaviors, in lustful actions, in drunken incidents, in wild festivals, in drinking parties, in

godless idolatries, **4** concerning which they think is strange that you do not rush to the same wasteful excess, badmouthing [all the while]; **5** they will give an account to him who is ready to judge the living and the dead, **6** because for this purpose the “dead” indeed were told the good news, so that they might be judged on the one hand by men in the flesh, but might live on the other hand because of God by the Spirit.

4:7 Now the end of all things has come near. So then, be attentive and sober for the purpose of prayers. **8** And above all, be intentional in loving one another, because “love covers a multitude of sins,” **9** being hospitable to one another without grumbling, **10** each person, inasmuch as he [or she] has received a gift, employ it in the service of one another as good stewards of the varied grace of God—**11** if one speaks, as [speaking] God’s words; if one serves, as [serving] with the strength that God supplied; [in all cases doing so] in order that in all things God may be glorified through Jesus Christ, to whom be the glory and the strength forever and ever. Amen!

4:12 Brothers and sisters, do not be surprised at the fire for testing that appears among you, as though something strange was happening to you. **13** But to the extent that you participate in the sufferings of Christ, rejoice, in order that in his glory which is to be revealed you may rejoice with overwhelming joy. **14** If you are reviled in the name of Christ, “blessed”! For the Spirit of God and of glory rests upon you—he who is ridiculed on the one hand by people, but glorified on the other hand by you. **15** For no one among you is supposed to suffer because he is a murderer, or a thief, or an evildoer, or a meddler; **16** but if [anyone suffers] because he is a Christian, he should not be ashamed, but glorify God in this destiny. **17** For it is the time for the judgment to begin from the house of God, and if first from us, what will be the fate of those who disobey God’s gospel? **18** And if the righteous is saved only with difficulty, where will the impious and the sinful be? **19** Accordingly, those who specifically suffer according to God’s will should entrust their souls to him, as to a faithful creator, while doing what is right.

5:1 Elders—those who are among you—I urge, as a fellow elder and a witness of the sufferings of Christ and also a participant in the glory that is about to be revealed, **2** shepherd the flock of God that is among you, exercising oversight not under compulsion, but with eagerness; and not greedily, but zealously; **3** and not lording it over those under your charge, but acting as examples for the flock. **4** And when the chief shepherd is manifested, you will take hold of the unfading crown of glory.

5:5 Similarly, you who are younger, submit to the elders. And all of you, submitting to one another, wrap yourselves in humility, since “God opposes the proud, but gives grace to the humble.” **6** Submit yourselves, then, under the mighty hand of God, so that he might exalt you at the proper time, **7** placing all your cares to him, because he cares about you.

5:8 Be alert; be watchful. For your adversary, the devil, roars like a lion, seeking someone he can devour. **9** Resist him, firm in the faith, knowing that the same sufferings are being fulfilled by your brotherhood in the [whole] world. **10** And the God of all grace, who called you into his own eternal glory in Christ Jesus, will, after you have suffered a little while, personally restore your strength; he will steady, strengthen, establish [you]. **11** To him be the glory and the strength for ever and ever. Amen!

5:12 Through Silvanus, the faithful brother (as I regard him), I have briefly written to you, exhorting and testifying this to be the true grace of God in which you have taken your stand. **13** The one in Babylon who is likewise chosen greets you, as does Mark, my son. **14** Greet one another with love’s kiss. Peace be to you all in Christ Jesus. Amen!

Notable Abbreviations

cf.: Compare, see also

e.g.: For example

esp. Especially

etc.: And so on, and the others

f(f): And the verse(s) following the one cited

lit.: literally

NT: New Testament

OG: Old Greek (otherwise known as the Septuagint), that is, one of principal the translations of the Hebrew Bible into Greek made in ancient times

OT: Old Testament

viz.: namely, that is.

Commentary

1:1.1 *Peter*: Before Jesus called him to be his disciple, Peter was a fisherman (Mat 4:18) from Galilee (Mat 26:37), a poor region in northern Israel. As such, Peter was lacking in higher education (Ac 4:13), though it must be emphasized that a lack of education does not mean a lack of intelligence. He was married (Mat 8:14) to a believer (1 Cor 9:5). It is unknown whether he had any children.

Peter had a strong personality, to say the least. He was often the first to speak (e.g., Mat 17:4, 26:35). He also seems to have been unafraid to ask questions of Jesus (e.g., Mat 15:15, 29:27) or even (momentarily at least, and out of good intentions) to rebuke Jesus (Mat 16:22, Ac 10:14). It was Peter who swam to meet Jesus, rather than wait for the boat to sail to shore (Jn 21:7); and it was Peter who cut off a man's ear when Jesus was being arrested (Jn 18:10). Yet almost immediately after that act of violent resistance, Peter left Jesus and ran (Mat 26:56). That tendency of Peter to vacillate would surface later in his life (contrast Ac 11:17 with Gal 2:11-12).

Yet neither Peter's inconsistency nor his impetuosity prevented Jesus from preparing Peter for a prominent role. Indeed, the change that Jesus made in Peter's name might have been a way of saying that Jesus would push past these very faults in order to use Peter for his saving purposes: Peter was at birth given an ordinary Jewish name, Simon (in Hebrew, שמעון; in Greek, Σίμων or Συμεων), but at a crucial moment (Mat 16:13-20) Jesus gives to him the name Peter, which means "Rock" (the Greek Πέτρος being a calque of the Aramaic כִּפָּא, a name which comes into Greek as "Cephas"). Now, the interpretation of Mat 16:13-20 is much disputed, but it can be agreed that Simon's new name was meant to signal in some way the unstoppable and unending reign of Christ that was being in some sense prepared for (cf. Bavinck, 3:339-340). Peter was not infrequently still called Simon after that point, and, more importantly, he had some serious low points in his spiritual life (most notably, the events recorded in Mat 16:21-23, 26:69-75). But Jesus was preparing, even *before* Peter's denial of him, to see him restored and to entrust to him moral leadership among the apostles (Lk 22:31-33). And that is exactly what happened: In the days after the resurrection of Christ, Peter had the courage to lead God's people and to speak God's truth in Jerusalem and beyond (Ac 1:15ff and *passim*). His influence extended at least as far as Corinth (1 Cor 1:12) and, as his two epistles demonstrate, throughout Asia Minor.¹ The fisherman from Galilee spread his net far, catching many men for his master, the Messiah. In this letter Peter will use his influence to point his readers to the "true grace of God" (5:12).²

1:1.2 *an apostle of Jesus Christ*: During his earthly ministry Jesus had numerous followers, but he chose only twelve to be his apostles (Mat 10:1-4). These twelve, of whom Peter was one, were not intrinsically

¹ See Jobes (33-36) for the possibility that Peter resided for a time—perhaps a long time—at Rome.

² Some scholars in modern times have doubted that Peter really composed this epistle. But the case against Petrine authorship is speculative at best, and there are various points that argue in favor of Petrine authorship. For instance, the author seems to make various subtle allusions to Pentecost or to OT texts used by him on that day, and these interconnections are just what one would expect for someone so impacted by that event. From another direction, the letter lacks any heavy handed proclamations of apostolic grandiosity such as a forger attempting to convince readers that he was Peter might insert. Also pointing in the direction of Petrine authorship is the style of Greek used by him (see Jobes, 325-338)—notwithstanding the efforts of some to use the Greek style of the epistle to *oppose* Petrine authorship. See further Jobes, 5-19; Schreiner, 21-36.

more spiritually grounded than everyone else—one of the twelve, after all, was Judas Iscariot—yet were chosen, for reasons known only to God. The Greek term behind “apostle” (ἀποστολος) is a fairly general one for someone given a mandate. The closest thing we have to a job description is found in Mk 3:14-15—they were to “be with” Jesus, to “preach,” and “to have authority to cast out demons.” The first item is manifestly preparatory; the second underscores the propositional and ethical content of Jesus’ mission and the need to communicate such; and the third evidently is indicative of their role as Jesus’ servants in the in-breaking of God’s kingdom (cf. Mat 12:28). Paul found it necessary in his epistles repeatedly to make reference to the authority associated with apostleship (e.g., 2 Cor 13:10). And as difficult as some of the questions that arise concerning the institution of apostleship are, it is beyond doubt that Peter had received from Jesus Christ himself important and recognized authority.

Indeed, Peter could have simply said “an apostle,” but stating distinctly that his apostleship comes from Jesus Christ distances the former fisherman from authority: His authority is *not* his own, and he can offer leadership only because he has been given this role by the one all Christians call “Lord.” In this first reference to that Lord, Peter supplies both Jesus’ name (Ἰησοῦς, a partly declinable form of the Hebrew יֵשׁוּעַ, which means “God brings salvation”) and his title (χριστός, a translation of the Hebrew word [מָשִׁיחַ] for “messiah,” which means something like “God’s chosen instrument”), thus speaking in one breath of the man whom he had known face to face and the savior whose work ensured the renewal of all things.

1:1.3 *To the elect sojourners of the dispersion:* Peter addresses his readers not as those who *live* in their hometowns, but as those who *sojourn* in those places. Thus from the outset the recipients of the apostle’s letter begin to see themselves in a new light, viz. as people whose real home lies elsewhere. Indeed, Peter sharpens the image by saying that his readers belong to “the dispersion” (διασπορά), a keyword in Jewish thought in the late Second Temple Period (and beyond). The Jewish people had long been familiar with being far removed from their homeland, scattered in foreign and sometimes hostile cultures. Peter now applies this familiar term to a new situation, viz. that of Christians scattered among unbelievers, distant for a time from their eternal home in the embrace of their lord.

Some have seen Peter’s words here as quite literal, as addressing ethnically Jewish people scattered across Asia Minor (this verse will go on to specify five regions, all of them to be found within Asia Minor).³ The apostle is admittedly called the one “entrusted with... the apostleship to the

³ Some background notes on the regions sketched:

(1) Pontus: This region occupied roughly the northeastern coast of this land mass. Military and political intrigue had long characterized this powerful polity. Most notably, the Mithridatic Wars had pitted the Kingdom of Pontus against the Roman Republic a couple of generations before Peter’s birth. Aquila was a native of this region (Ac 18:2), and just possibly he was among those who heard Peter preach on the day of Pentecost (cf. Ac 2:9).

(2) Galatia: This region lies in central Anatolia. The name is related to the word “Celt”; a Celtic migration had, a few centuries before the present epistle, caused upheaval in the wider area, and eventually settled in Galatia. Gradually these Celts became assimilated to the wider culture, yet retained a strong local identity. Nevertheless, Christians there were interconnected with Christians elsewhere: Jews from Phrygia, a region split between the administrative units of Galatia and Asia (on which see below), were present at Pentecost (Ac 2:10); Galatia was visited by Paul at least twice (Ac 16:6, 18:23); and of course Paul wrote at least one epistle to those believers (doing so, most likely, well before 1 Peter was written).

(3) Cappadocia: This region lies in the east of Asia Minor. Its strategic location encouraged the movement of armies, its rich soil allowed the breeding of strong horses, and its easily-carved volcanic rock provided places of political refuge or spiritual contemplation. Jews from this area too were present at Pentecost (Ac 2:9).

(4) Asia: In modern English, this term of course refers to the continent of Asia. In Peter’s day, however, the term referred to a compact, populous region in the west of modern Turkey. The region was in ancient times the territory of the Lydians, an Anatolian people known for its prowess in commerce and in architecture. Asia long continued to

circumcision" (Gal 2:7-8), but that passage is a generalization, not a hard-and-fast division of labor.⁴ Furthermore, there is good reason to think that the present epistle was *not* addressed only—or even primarily—to Jewish believers. "To say that [the recipients of the letter] lived in 'ignorance'... suggests an idolatrous and pagan past (1:14). Even more telling is the claim that they had been 'redeemed from the empty way of life handed down to you from your forefathers' (1:18). Peter would scarcely say that Jewish forefathers lived vainly... The Gentile origin of the readers seems clear [also] from 4:3-4" (Schreiner, 38-39).

Karen Jobes has advanced an interesting theory: Reflecting on the large-scale colonization efforts of the Roman imperial administration, she suggests that the letter's recipients are displaced colonists, quite possibly hailing from the city of Rome (28-41). (To be clear, Jobes does not deny a spiritual dimension to the "sojourner" language [e.g., 41].) It seems to me that there are significant problems with this approach, as striking as it is. For instance, if 1:1 is (at least primarily) literal, it would seem likely that the same literalness would apply elsewhere. But it seems unlikely that Peter would (v17) limit the need for reverence to the time of their exile from Rome. Less likely still is the idea that their status as *literal* sojourners could be the basis on which they resist sin (2:11). To my mind, Jm 1:1 provides important precedent for using "diaspora" in a metaphorical sense—for there James' audience is, even if mainly Jewish by ethnicity, not ethnic Israel *as such*, but the Church (cf. Richardson, 54-56). All these matters are debatable, however.

These citizens of heaven are "elect." The Greek term—more lit., "chosen" (ΕΚΛΕΚΤΟΣ)—is in Scripture often a shorthand for "chosen by God for salvation." This idea is spelled out by Peter a bit more fully soon, so I will postpone discussion until later (viz., under 1:2.1) except to say here that the believers in Asia Minor are not aimless wanderers, but sojourners who benefit from divine care.

1:2.1 according to the foreknowledge of God the Father: Here "according to" (κατά) could mean "in conformity to," or "on a scale that matches" (these glosses come from Harris, 152). Also a bit ambiguous—at least when taken in isolation—is "foreknowledge" (προγνωσις), which could mean either "prior factual awareness" or something like "prior personal connection." It is possible, then, to understand Peter to mean that (1) God in the past accurately predicted the readers' election, or (2) that election bound up in God's eternal relationship with the readers (which, in the nature of the case, must have its origin in God, not in them). I think that the second interpretive option is correct. Merely to say that the Father was aware of the elect would do hardly do justice to the theocentric items in 1:2.2 (where the Spirit sanctifies) and 1:2.3 (where the Son, though obeyed by his people, is the one whose sacrifice brings them into the covenantal framework where their obedience takes place). Indeed, a key word for knowledge "in Hebrew [יָדַע] often refers to God's covenantal love bestowed on his people (cf. Gen 18:9; Jer 1:5; Amos 3:2). The rich associations of that term continue in the New Testament. That foreordination is involved is clear from Acts 2:23, where foreknowledge is paired with predestination. Romans 11:2 drives us in the same direction" (Schreiner, 53).

be an economic powerhouse. For Peter and the early Church, it would surely have been well known for its many churches: all of the seven churches to whom Jesus in Revelation writes letters were located in Asia.

(5) Bithynia: This region constituted roughly the central part of the northern coast of the Anatolian peninsula.

Bithynia was with Pontus part of a single province from the Roman administrative viewpoint. However, Bithynia and Pontus had long been rivals, and so it was only natural for a distinction between the two to be made at times.

⁴ "We know in fact that the gospel had first broken through to the Gentiles through the witness of Peter in his preaching to the household of Cornelius. Likewise, Paul continued to preach to the Jews, finding in their synagogues many God-fearers and proselytes who responded to his message and who frequently became the beachhead of a new Christian community in their city" (George, 162). (All this is in reference to the era that began at Pentecost; in scattered instances some gentiles in OT times did believe in God for salvation.)

“Such foreknowledge is laden with comfort for Peter’s readers” (Grudem, 54): Their membership in the Christian community is not happenstance, as arbitrary lost as gained; their acceptance by God was not spur-of-the-moment, soon to be regretted; and their relationship with God is not rooted in their own goodness, quickly to be found deficient.

1:2.2 in the sanctification of the Spirit: The Holy Spirit is referred to in a number of ways, e.g. as the “Holy Spirit” (e.g., Mat 1:18, 1 Pet 1:12), the “Spirit of God” (e.g., Mat 3:16, Rom 8:9) and more simply as “the Spirit” (e.g., Mat 22:43, Rom 8:16).

OT prophets pointed to a time when God’s Holy Spirit would be poured out on believers (Eze 39:29, Joel 2:28) leading to holiness in living and fellowship with God (Eze 36:27-29, Joel 2:27). Peter (citing Joel in particular), while himself filled by the Holy Spirit (Ac 2:4), announces (at least the beginning of) the fulfillment of this prophecy (Ac 2:14-21). Such a fulfillment is of no small significance: Comparison of Jer 31:31-34 with the above-mentioned prophecies of Ezekiel, Joel, and others will make clear that this pouring out of the Holy Spirit accompanies and is intrinsic to the advent of the New Covenant. The Holy Spirit, upon entering a New Covenant believer, sanctifies—makes holy—the believer in what begins as at the moment of conversion (cf. 1 Cor 6:11) and continues throughout the course of life (cf. 1 Thes 4:3).

1:2.3 for obedience and sprinkling by the blood of Jesus Christ: I shall address the matter of “sprinkling” first. Under the Old Covenant (that is, the Law of Moses) entrance into the covenant, and preparation of the implements of the sacrificial system, was signaled by the sprinkling of the blood of animals (see esp. Ex 24:3-8, Num 19:1-10). The New Covenant likewise was inaugurated by blood—the blood of Jesus Christ (Lk 22:20; cf. 1 Pet 1:19). In other words, the foreknowledge of the Father and the sanctification of the Spirit has placed believers under the sprinkled blood of Christ, his sacrifice qualifying them for membership in the New Covenant.

When the “sprinkling” has been seen in this light, the significance of “obedience” becomes clear: As has been shown from the OT already, the New Covenant entails a permanent forgiveness of sins and a profound fellowship with God that those who lived under the Old Covenant could scarcely imagine. The New Covenant does not entail sinless perfection in the near-term—as Peter will go on to say in this very epistle (cf. esp. 4:15)—but it does immeasurably broaden and deepen the degree to which obedience wells up in the Christian’s soul. Probably obedience specifically to Christ is meant.

1:2.4 God the Father... the Spirit... Jesus Christ: In the course of a few words (and in less than one verse) Peter has invoked all three members of the Trinity. So while the *word* “Trinity” is not found in the Bible, in an absolutely crucial sense the Trinity *is* present in the pages of the NT. In the present verse Christians are brought immense hope by the fact that all three members of the Trinity contribute to their salvation. God in all of his fullness and love embraces them and equips them.⁵

1:2.5 Grace to you and peace be multiplied! Allowing for variations, this greeting seems to have been quite common in the early Church (cf. the epistles of Paul, 2 Pet 1:2, Jd 2, Rev 1:4). The term “grace” (χαρις) here is probably a play on words, for in Greek it sounds quite similar to the more usual term for “hello” (χαίρειν; this can also mean, “goodbye”) while of course celebrating that aspect of God’s character which lies at the heart of the Christian faith, viz. his freely-given favor (see further under

⁵ Most Christians are most familiar with the sequence “Father, Son, and Holy Spirit.” Here Peter uses a different sequence, viz., “Father, Holy Spirit, and Son.” In fact, the sequence varies considerably throughout the NT (Letham, 64-65). How far this is significant for debates concerning intratrinitarian roles is hard to say, but the NT writers feel no need to insist on a single formula. There is no magic in any set of words.

1:10.3). The word “peace” continues a Jewish tradition of greeting people with that sentiment. The call for these things to “be multiplied” might trace its origin to the exile in Babylon (cf. Dan 4:1, 6:25). It is evidently a common addition, since it is used by Peter again (2 Pet 1:2) as well as by Jude (2). Whatever the history behind his greetings, Peter takes care to impart warmth to his epistle.

1:3-12 It is not too difficult to identify the genre which Peter employs in these verses, except that the genre lacks a particularly suitable label in English. The keyword is “blessed,” and so I could appeal to the Latin word for “blessed” (*benedictus*) and call this genre “benediction”; or I could appeal to the Greek word for blessing (εὐλογητός), and call it “eulogy.” But the first word might call to mind the end of a sermon, while Peter is just getting warmed up; and the second, a funeral. Perhaps one could label the genre “baruch,” based on the Hebrew language (ברוך). But I will stick with “benediction” as already known. At any rate, this genre consists in a more or less elaborate ascription of blessedness to God, in the praise of whom a great deal can be said incidentally: the user of this genre declares, “Blessed be God,” and then supplies one or more relative clauses (“who”) to which any number of ideas can be attached. The result is language that is enchanting without quite being poetry (cf. Cohick, 84-86). The form probably goes back to OT antecedents (e.g., 1 Ki 1:48, Ps 144:1; cf., in the NT, Lk 1:68-79), though as a self-contained and sustained genre, it apparently evolved in the late Second Temple period or so.⁶

Despite the way that this passage is often translated into English, or punctuated in Greek, this entire passage is *one* sentence in the original.⁷ Now, Greek style permits much longer sentences than English style does, so the length of this sentence is not absurd from the perspective of the cultural milieu in which it was composed. Even so, 1:3-12 is something of a *tour de force* on Peter’s part, matching an exalted topic with exalted language.

1:3.1 *Blessed be... God:* When God is called “blessed,” it is thereby confessed “that God is absolute perfection, for blessedness is the mark of every being that is, and to that extent is complete... because God is absolute life, the fountainhead of all life, he is also the absolutely blessed God” (Bavinck, 2:251).

1:3.2 *the God and Father of our lord Jesus Christ:* “God is described as ‘God and Father.’ What does Paul intend with the conjunction ‘and’? This syntax [viz., the Granville Sharp rule; see von Siebenthal §132c, p186]... indicates [in Greek] that the second noun further describes the first. Thus Paul identifies God as Father... and, by implication, [he] has always had a Son. Said another way, there was never a time when God was not Father, nor was there a time when the Son was not [in existence]” (Cohick, 90). God “is the Father of Christ and, by extension, of us only when we are adopted into His family” (Sproul, 11); that this thought, or something close to it, is in Peter’s mind is shown by the following words (1:3.3).

1:3.3 *who in accordance with his abundant mercy caused us to be born again:* Peter echoes the language of Jesus (in Jn 3:3) in describing the believer as someone who has been born a second time. (Indeed, that conversation between Jesus and Nicodemus seems to have so impressed itself on Peter that he invented a new Greek word [ἀναγεννάω]). Every birth is in a sense a miracle; and every new child brings to her or his parents feelings of awe, love, and responsibility. So it is with God, though God’s role in the birth is

⁶ It is possible that Peter in some respects patterned this benediction after that found in Eph 1:3-14 (also one sentence in Greek).

⁷ von Siebenthal (§289g, p545) notes, with reference to v12, that sometimes a relative pronoun can forgo a grammatical antecedent. But granting that there the identification of the antecedent is more a matter of logic than of syntax, features associated with this genre strongly suggest that vv3-12 are meant to be a single sentence—or at the very least, a single, tightly bound unit.

sovereign in a way that no human role could ever be. A new believer on the earth is not a new tally mark on a score sheet, but a baby whose newborn cries bring tears of joy to God's eyes.

It is evident that believers' spiritual rebirth is not something that they accomplish on their own (cf. Schreiner, 61; Sproul, 12-14). Indeed, "great mercy" was required. Peter does not here spell out why this is so (he will later gently say things like "you were [once] wandering like sheep" [2:25.1]. Elsewhere, however, Scripture paints a bleak picture of what humankind in itself is like (e.g., Jn 2:24-25, Rom 1:18-32). That humanity is so undeserving of God's kindness underscores God's magnanimity.

1:3.4 *to a living hope through the resurrection of Jesus Christ from the dead:* The contemporary pagan "bleak view of the afterlife... killed any hope one might seek; therefore, hope among pagans was dead. This Greek thought is not unlike the existentialist and materialistic philosophy apparent today. In stark contrast, the Christian's new birth has been achieved through the resurrection of Jesus Christ (1 Pet. 1:3). Christian hope is everlasting because Christ, the ground of that hope, is everliving" (Jobes, 85)

This "living hope" does not come from thin air. Its source is instead that day of pious women, doubting disciples, mighty angels, trembling soldiers—the day when "the Author of life" (as Peter himself put it in Ac 3:15) was raised to life again.

1:4 *resulting in an undying, uncontaminable, and unfading inheritance reserved in heaven for you:* Peter offers great reassurance to his readers. The blessed future which Christ's resurrection has secured is utterly indestructible. No impermanence or imperfection mars it. God in heaven always keeps it safe.⁸

1:5.1 *through faith:* The Anatolian believers "receive his [viz., God's] protection simply 'through faith,' that is, through committing themselves in trust and obedience to God. They may seem vulnerable... and indeed in themselves they are, but God's goodness and protection surround them. *He* will do the protecting" (Davids, 53 [emphasis added]). Due to Peter's having written only two epistles, it cannot be determined whether Peter proclaimed a doctrine of salvation through faith as insistently and in as much detail as Paul in his own letters, but Peter certainly did speak along these lines at least from an early period after Christ's resurrection (Ac 3:16).

1:5.2 *for a salvation:* The word "salvation" (σωτηρια) denotes the fact or means of rescue from some physical or spiritual danger. Often in the Bible it is used to refer to deliverance from the coming wrath of God against sin (e.g., Rom 5:9, 1 Thes 5:9).

1:5.3 *ready to be revealed in the last time:* There is a past, a present, and a future aspect to salvation: there is a sense in which believers' salvation can be looked on as an accomplished fact (e.g., Eph 2:8), a sense in which salvation is progressively working itself out (e.g., 1 Cor 15:2), and a sense in which in which salvation awaits the believer at Christ's return (e.g., Rom 5:9). While Christians are not without blessing in their daily lives, their gaze is really on the future, for only when Christ returns will the renewal of all things come (see further 1:7.4).

⁸ The Greek behind the first adjective (αφθαρτος) could also be rendered "incorruptible" or "imperishable." Related forms of the word—but without the initial, privative α- ("un-")—notably occur in v23 (there alongside our present word by way of express contrast) and in Ac 2:31, where Peter in his Pentecost sermon declares that Jesus by his resurrection escaped "corruption" (διαφθαρτος), just as was foretold in Ps 16:10 (in the versification of the OG, which is the version Peter was citing, this is Ps 15:10). I borrow the rendering of the second adjective from Montanari (109b), though he does not cite this passage.

1:6.1 *in which [final day]:* The Greek shows that the “last time” (not the “salvation”) of the previous verse is meant (for “in which” [ἐν ᾧ] is grammatically masculine, which matches “time” [καίρος], not “salvation” [σωτηρία]). It is not that *only* in the last time there will be rejoicing. Rather, the expectation of that coming day is the thing which brings about believers’ joy.

1:6.2 *you rejoice even if now, if necessary, for a short time you have been made sorrowful by diverse trials:* Peter implies quite a bit in these words. For instance, (1) “suffering is not a normal part of life; it was not ordained by God in creation” (Davids, 56). (2) The suffering we endure will one day seem short, at least in comparison to what is to come (cf. Rom 8:18). (3) The rejoicing Peter speaks of “is not a continual feeling of hilarity nor a denial of the reality of pain and suffering” (Davids, 55); our suffering is real, and to be repulsed by it is only natural. (4) Trials take many forms—persecution, sickness, financial stress, loneliness, etc.; we should not glorify certain trials and trivialize others.

1:7.1 *in order that the genuineness of your faith:* Implicit here (“genuineness”) is a recognition that while anyone can claim to have faith, not all stated faith is real faith. Yet Peter’s goal here is to comfort, not frighten, his readers (see on 1:7.2).

1:7.2 *much more valuable than perishable gold—tested by fire:* The Greek syntax and Peter’s train of thought here are a bit difficult to follow (see esp. Davids, 57). In any case, “Peter does not wish his readers to confuse the testing of their faith with the failure of their faith” (Jobes, 94). On the contrary, Christians should recognize that “testing... produces steadfastness” (Jm 1:3); many of the miseries they face are in fact the means by which God makes them more mature, and their scars are signs of their sincerity. Moreover, the riches of this earth are temporary, and they pale in comparison with genuine faith. Believers might not have a penny to their name, but if they have faith in their heart, the treasures of heaven are theirs.

1:7.3 *might be found worthy of praise, and honor, and of glory:* Peter “does not specify whether this praise is the praise which God gives to his people on the last day (as in Rom. 2:29; I Cor. 4:5; I Pet. 5:4), or the praise which people give to God” (Grudem, 69). If one has to choose between the options, the latter is better, “since in this context Peter is encouraging his readers to hope in their heavenly reward (v. 4)” (Grudem, 69). Indeed, nearly every word, phrase, and clause of the benediction (viz., 1:3-12) is clearly designed to comfort and strengthen the churches of Asia Minor in light of what is to come for those who are in Christ. “While their faithfulness to God may be why they are not receiving any praise, glory, or honor from their society, that same faithfulness will ultimately result in praise, glory, and honor when all is said and done. Therefore, the very experiences that cause them distress because they are Christians should also cause them joy because they are Christians” (Jobes, 95-96).

1:7.4 *at the revelation of Jesus Christ:* Peter might have gotten this wording from Paul (e.g., 1 Cor 1:7) or derived it independently (cf. Lk 17:30). Either way, he uses this or similar language fairly often relative to the size of his two epistles (1 Pet 1:7, v13, 4:13), again (as with, e.g., his term “sojourners” in 1:1.3) prompting his readers to orient their lives around the future, not the present.

The term “revelation” (ἀποκαλύψις, “uncovering”) implies that in some sense that which is revealed has been there all along, though unseen or unrecognized. Accordingly, “the revelation of Jesus Christ” is “an apt phrase, for in the eyes of the NT Jesus is already exalted and already has power and already is present in his gathered church (e.g., Matt. 18:20); what remains is for that power and glory to be demonstrated on earth, that is, for it to be revealed or unveiled. That is the point of consummation toward which the church is moving” (Davids, 58). When that day comes, the righteous will be vindicated

and the wicked condemned (Mat 25:31-46), the earth renewed (Mat 19:28), the saints gathered (Mat 24:31) and enthroned (Rev 22:5); and the face of God will be seen by his beloved (Rev 22:4).

It is fitting that the revelation is not the revelation of the Father or the Spirit, but the Son: “Because Christ is the savior of the world, he will someday return as its judge. The crisis, or judgment... that he precipitated by his first coming he consummates at his second coming. The Father gave him authority to execute judgment... because he is the Son of Man (John 5:27). Eschatology, therefore, is rooted in Christology and is itself Christology” (Bavinck, 4:685).

1:8.1 *whom—though you have not known him personally—you love*: Few things could be more poignant than that the apostle Peter, who had walked and talked with Jesus for several years—throughout the length of Israel and beyond; in every high and low; hearing his words with his own ears and seeing his miracles with his own eyes; running away from him at his arrest and running to the empty tomb—to contemplate that he is writing to believers in far-off Asia Minor who have never seen Jesus face-to-face or heard his voice. It must have been with some wonderment that he sees such a faith—a kind of faith that he himself had not been called to—in these believers.

1:8.2 *[and] in whom—though not presently seeing him, but believing*: For the more general principle that faith involves acceptance of things not immediately apparent to human perception, cf. 2 Cor 5:7, Heb 11:1. Here Peter points to a specific—and indispensable—instance of faith, viz. that by which the Anatolian believers have set their faith in Jesus Christ, despite the fact that that man is currently unseen by them (and by a critical world around them).

1:8.3 *you rejoice with a joy that is inexpressible and glorious*: “Peter’s point is that even in the midst of outward trials we can already experience by faith and rejoice in our coming Lord. Thus the joy is ‘unspeakable’ or inexpressible, for it defies outward circumstances (and thus is hard to explain) and is rooted in a realm that is beyond our physical experience” (Davids, 59).

1:9.1 *receiving as the final result of your faith*: The words “final result” (in Greek, one word [τέλος]) do not imply a long chain of previous results, only that “salvation” (1:9.2) is what will eventually come for those who believe in Christ.

1:9.2 *the salvation of [your] souls*: (On “salvation” see under 1:5.2.) “Salvation of ‘souls’ could easily be misunderstood by moderns, as if Peter referred to the salvation of our immaterial substance [only]. The word ‘souls,’ however, refers to the whole person and does not suggest in any way that the body is left out” (Schreiner, 71). God’s redemptive work will be all-encompassing for his saints.

1:10.1 *concerning which salvation the prophets who prophesied*: “It was the first conviction of the church that this [grace-filled] future had become a present reality in the coming of Jesus, his resurrection, and the outpouring of the Spirit, as one can see in the citing of the OT as a basis for belief in all four Gospels (e.g., Matt. 13:16-17; Luke 10:23-24), in Acts (e.g., Acts 2), in Paul (e.g., Rom. 4:7-8; 1 Cor. 9:10; 10:11), and in Hebrews (e.g., Heb. 1-2)” (Davids, 61).

1:10.2 *concerning the grace that would obtain in your cases*: Clearly, for Peter “salvation” and “grace” are virtually synonymous (cf. Schreiner, 71 n56); grace “is the gospel in one word” (Hoehner, 149). The following selected comments from Moo (with Greek and Hebrew diacritics removed) summarize “grace” (χαρις) well: “In secular Greek, χαρις is ‘what delights,’ and is often used with reference to things that bring joy (χαρά), esp. gifts... It can also be used of the ‘favor’ of the gods... and occurs frequently in the Hellenistic period to denote instances of a ruler’s ‘favor’ [or ‘benefaction’]. In the LXX [that is, the OG],

χάρις occurs over 190 times. Of those with a Hebrew equivalent (only about 70), most translate יָרַן. This word has the special connotation of the ‘assistance’ rendered to a weaker person by a stronger... Note, e.g., the ubiquitous phrase ‘to find grace [יָרַן; χάρις] in the eyes of’ (Gen. 6:8; Exod. 33:12; Num. 11:15; Deut. 24:1)... One of Paul’s characteristic (though not unique) emphases... is that God’s grace is... given to people who are utterly undeserving of it” (249 n744). Peter would certainly agree with that Pauline emphasis (note, e.g., 5:5 for the word “grace” and 2:24-25 for the idea). (For further study on the concept of grace and its (mis)uses in Church history, see Bavinck, 3:573-579.)

1:10.3 *made diligent search and inquiry*: The word “diligent” is not in the Greek. Intensity is, however, likely communicated by the two-fold ἐκ-prefix Peter enhances these verbs with. By highlighting the great efforts expended by the prophets, Peter highlights the great assets enjoyed by believers.

1:11.1 *inquiring*: Even within the pages of Scripture, we get glimpses of the kind of self-awareness that biblical writers felt (e.g., Jer 32:8). Such is not a denial of the biblical doctrine of inspiration. Rather, it is an affirmation of the intensely human character of the people God chose to write his Scriptures. (Peter will interact with bibliology at greater length in 2 Pet 1:19ff).

1:11.2 *as to what or what manner of time*: This could be rendered, “as to what person or what manner of time,” but in that case Peter would probably have used καὶ rather than ἢ (Jobes, 101). Judaism in the late Second Temple period felt more consternation over the question of “when” than the question of “who” in regard to the coming messianic age (see esp. Davids, 61-62).

1:11.3 *the Spirit of Christ*: This does not mean “Christ’s immaterial being” or “Christ’s mental life,” but rather, “the Holy Spirit, whose identity is wrapped in the proclamation of Christ”: prophetic guidance in the OT was a function of the Holy Spirit (cf., e.g., Num 11:29, 2 Sam 23:2), and the Holy Spirit rests on and points to Christ (cf., e.g., Isa 11:2, Jn 16:14). There are similar expressions elsewhere in the NT. For example, “‘Spirit of Christ’ in Rom. 8:9 is interchangeable with ‘Spirit of God’” (Grudem, 74 n12).

1:11.4 *as he bore witness ahead of time to the sufferings of Christ and the following glories*: See, e.g., Isa 52:13-54:17 and Zech 13:7-14:5; a longer, though surely still not comprehensive, list is to be found in Grudem (75). The theme of days of gloom followed by a dawn of glory is a theme found numerous times in the books of the prophets.⁹

1:12.1 *to whom*: That is, to the prophets (as the Greek [οἷς, not ω] shows).

1:12.2 *it was revealed that it was not for themselves, but for you that they were ministering these things*: Try as they might, the prophets could not pinpoint the exact timing of the prophecies they had been given, but “they did know that their prophecy would be fulfilled in a distant age (Gen. 49:10; Num. 24:17; Deut. 18:15; Dan. 9:24-27; Joel 2:28; Hab. 2:1-3); that is, says Peter, they realized that they ministered to you, those on whom the age of fulfillment has dawned” (Davids, 64). “Of all the times to be alive in human history, it is a supreme privilege to be alive in the period of history following the coming of Christ” (Jobes, 103). In the eyes of the world, Christians are often poor, marginalized, and misguided; in the eyes of God, Christians are rich in spirit, central to his plans, and on the path of eternal blessedness.

⁹ It is also noteworthy here that for Peter, David is also among the prophets (Ac 2:30)—certainly with reference to the content of his psalms (e.g., 17:14b-15), and perhaps also with reference to the typology of his life as a whole (cf. Grudem [75]).

1:12.3 *which things have now been announced to you through those who proclaimed the gospel to you:* Peter points to the means by which the gospel reached his readers—the witness of proclaimers of the good news (the Greek behind “proclaimed” neither implies nor excludes a formal role, such as evangelist or pastor, for those who did the proclaiming). Who exactly these individuals were, we do not know. But from Peter’s day to ours, probably the vast majority of those who have come to know Jesus as their savior have done so because someone told them about him. Probably, too, most such transfers of the good news leave no detailed historical record—yet surely have received or will receive Peter’s admiration, and certainly will receive Jesus’ commendation (cf., e.g., Mat 25:31-40).

The content of the proclamation is “the gospel.” In Greek (as, incidentally, in English) the word (εὐαγγέλιον) means “good news.” In most contexts, a Greek speaker would need somehow to specify exactly what good news (s)he was referring to. But for Christians, at some early date the word came to mean, almost without exception, “the good news about salvation in Christ.” The closest the NT comes to consciously and specifically defining the term is 1 Cor 15:1-11 (though even there, Paul is concerned with a particular facet of the gospel, viz. Christ’s resurrection). As real and as perilous as the bad news of hellfire for the wicked is, the characteristic messaging of the NT is the *good* news of salvation in Christ.

1:12.4 *by the Holy Spirit who has been sent from heaven:* Those who preached the gospel to the Anatolian believers did not do so alone; the Holy Spirit was with them (cf. Jn 14:17). Such is a source of reassurance for everyone sharing the gospel, for it is not their words alone that work in their hearers. Such is also a source of reassurance for those receiving the gospel, for the substance of what they hear is not merely some human philosophy, but indeed a heavenly promise (cf. 1 Thes 2:13).

When Peter describes the Holy Spirit as the one “sent from heaven,” he surely alludes to Pentecost. Before his crucifixion, Jesus spoke (Jn 15:26, 16:7) of “sending” the Holy Spirit (admittedly, the Greek word in John is different from that in 1 Peter); and before his ascension, Jesus reiterated that the Holy Spirit would soon come (Ac 1:4-5). Then, on the day of Pentecost, this promised sending of the Holy Spirit came about (Ac 2:1-4), signaling the New Covenant era (cf. 1:2.2 above) and launching an era of missionary activity (Ac 1:8). This concept—that the Holy Spirit was sent at the birth of the Church—is also alluded to in Eph 1:13 (for “promised” there can refer to nothing except the fact that Pentecost was the fulfillment of the OT prophecies concerning the New Covenant).

Now, in unpacking the background of Peter’s description “sent from heaven,” it becomes evident that behind this sending is a promise. So here, as at many other points, Christianity stands at an intersection between history and eternity: the Church and its New Covenant blessings traces its origin to a particular date in history (Pentecost), yet the events of that day were the outworking of a plan formed in eternity (cf. 1 Pet 1:2, Eph 1:4). Moreover, by using the circumlocution of “heaven” for “God,” Peter might be also hinting at the manner in which Christianity stands at the intersection of physics and metaphysics: in the Spirit’s coming from “heaven” to earth, the tangible and material has been touched by the intangible and immaterial; “truth flowers from the earth, and righteousness smiles from heaven” (Ps 85:11).

1:12.5 *into which things angels long to set their gaze:* The word translated “set their gaze” here (παρακυπτω) more lit. means “to bend over to look” (cf. Montanari, 1557a), “to peer into from without” (Jobes, 104). Angels are intensely curious about God’s plan of salvation, yet for all their power, they do not experience this salvation themselves (cf. Heb 2:5). The benediction thus ends with one final note of comfort for those sojourning on this troubled earth: God is the creator of and is ruler over a vast array of cosmic beings—whose existence and powers scarcely enter our awareness or are encompassed by our understanding—yet focuses his Triune, salvific energy specifically and only on believing *humans*.

1:13.1 *preparing your minds for action:* More lit., “girding up the loins of your mind for action.” In ancient Israel, people wore long skirts or robes which would need to be hiked up part way if people were going to run to or work hard on some task involving a lot of movement. The preparedness Peter calls his reader to is not physical, but mental. Life is too full of dangers and distractions for believers to wander around, giving no thought to the best course of action. And not only trials and trivialities lurk in the shadows: There are also temptations, as will become evident in the following verses.

1:13.2 *being completely sober:* The mind is made ready for action through a careful, circumspect attitude.¹⁰

1:13.3 *hope in the grace that is being borne to you at the revelation of Jesus Christ:* Inasmuch as “hope” (ἐλπιζω) is a future-oriented term (it could be paraphrased, “to hold it in one’s mind that something good is coming”), Peter is telling his readers to shift their gaze from the present to the future. In other words, he is reminding them of their status on the earth as sojourners (cf. 1:1.3).

Such a mindset “prompts a reordering of priorities according to God’s agenda (Matt. 6:19-21, 24) and inevitably leads to ethical changes in one’s life (cf. I John 3:3). Since Peter is about to launch into an extended section of moral commands (beginning at v. 14 and continuing with only a few interruptions through the rest of the letter), this exhortation to hope appropriately forms the transition point to the rest of the letter. If Peter’s readers will first know the great truths about their salvation (vv. 1-12) and then begin a habit of visualizing themselves personally on a path of life leading without fail to unimaginable heavenly reward (v. 13), they will be mentally and emotionally ready to strive for a life of holiness (vv. 14-16, etc.)” (Grudem, 81-82).¹¹

1:14.1 *not being conformed to the former lusts:* The “lusts” (ἐπιθυμιαί) need not be desires for sexual pleasure; they could also be longings for riches, revenge, food, fame, or any such thing that not only bends the human will but also distorts the divine image in the person thus consumed. These powerful and perverse impulses controlled believers in “former” times, viz. before they came to know Christ. They must not shape Christians’ lives any longer.

Peters’ words in the previous verse imply two things about these lusts: (1) If believers are not alert, these lusts are liable to creep in again through subtle means; and (2) these things will draw believers’ hearts away from entire devotion to the blessed future (at the revelation of Christ) in exchange for a wretched present (in the grip of sin).

1:14.2 *that you had in your ignorance:* Peter’s intent here is debatable. Perhaps he is pointing to a culpable lack of attention to the things of God (cf. Rom 1:21, Eph 2:12). Or perhaps he aims to ameliorate somewhat the charge he has just made that they had long indulged in lusts by observing that they did not then have the deep understanding of right and wrong that they now do. The latter train of thought seems probable, in that the same train of thought with much the same wording occurs in Peter elsewhere (viz., Ac 3:14-17). The Christians’ former life of sin is not excusable, but it is understandable. Christians today should similarly be generous in spirit, like the apostle Peter. When unbelievers around them sin, they should be sad, but not surprised; concerned, but not condescending.

¹⁰ In Greek (νηφω), as in English, this can either mean “not influenced by excessive alcohol,” or “not driven by wild impulses.” There is no particular reason to think that Peter has abuse of alcohol in mind here, while the metaphor of “girding up the loins of the mind” he has just used warrants some explanation (cf. Jobes, 111).

¹¹ The future orientation of this whole verse undercuts the so-called “prosperity gospel,” according to which God promises wealth and other such temporary blessings *now*. God may or may not provide financial or other abundance, but the Christian is not ultimately happy with the pleasures of this life, finding instead her or his joy in the coming Lord Jesus.

1:15.1 *but rather in accordance with the holiness of the one who called you:* The source of believers' behavior should not be the unbelieving world from which they came, but the God who called them out of that world. (On the holiness of God alluded to here, see below on 1:16.2.)

The term "call" (καλεω) is in the NT at times almost a technical term for "the choice of pers[ons] for salvation" (Arndt and Gingrich, 400b). A few examples include 2 Thes 2:14, 1 Tim 6:12, and Rom 8:30. That last text is particularly instructive in that this call is rooted in a prior predestination (cf. 1:2.1 above) and is followed by justification and eventual glorification; God's call, in other words, is part of a chain of saving actions that in the final analysis find their actualization in God's faithfulness, not mankind's fallibility. Humans can neither earn nor lose God's call.

1:15.2 *you too be holy in all your conduct:* Although saints can neither earn nor lose God's call, God's call *does* affect human conduct. It would be absurd and immoral for God's abundant mercy in calling a person to find absolutely no positive response in that person.

1:16.1 *since it is written:* In Lev 19:2 (and cf. 11:44-45, 20:26), where God is speaking.

The Greek for "it is written" (γεγραπται) is in the perfect tense, which emphasizes that the composition of Lev 19:2 is not merely a historical event, but an event with an abiding significance. The authority of Scripture is something that continues. Such a conviction is not new to Peter; it is something that he had inherited from his Jewish heritage. In fact, the use of the specific form γεγραπται to cite Scripture—with every indication of Scripture being authoritative—goes at least as far back as the OG translation of Josh 8:31 (OG 9:2b), where καθο γεγραπται is used to represent ככתוב. Such language is used by Herod's advisors (Mat 2:5), by Jesus (Mat 4:4, etc.), by Satan in an attempt to manipulate Jesus (Mat 4:6) by various gospel writers (Mk 1:2, Lk 2:23, Jn 12:14), Peter (Ac 1:20), James (Ac 15:15), Paul (Ac 23:5, etc.). It is also to be found (in one form or another) in various other OT texts, and is constantly met with in exegetical, ethical, and other Jewish literature from ancient times and beyond. Never do any of these sources question the validity of Scripture, provided it is rightly interpreted. Clearly, a recognition of Scripture as authoritative is vital for the Christian community.

1:16.2 *You shall be holy, for I am holy:* The etymology of קדש (Hebrew for "holy") is less than clear, and the usages of the root are many and varied. But it seems fair to posit that when in said in reference to God, "holy" means something close to "transcendent," both in the realms of capacity and of morality; in reference to people, it means "devoted to God," "serving God to the exclusion of all else," and "eschewing those things that, if found in God, would mar his perfections." Holiness is intrinsic to God; indeed, it "is the quintessential quality of Yahweh" (Hartley, 312). Holiness is a nonnative element in humans, who must grow in the realization that ethical, sexual, and other impurities cannot be allowed in their divinely possessed lives. (For more on the concept of holiness, see Bavinck [2:216-221].)

The book of Leviticus gives to OT Israel "regulations concerning clean and unclean food, purification after childbirth, regulations about infectious skin diseases and mildew... and various other laws. Interestingly, Peter does not mandate that his first-century readers in Greco-Roman Asia Minor follow the particular instructions of the Holiness Code. His application of the OT law is direct but differentiated. He quotes Lev. 19:2 to establish the principle that, as Christians, his readers must be set apart from their surrounding culture in a way that is consistent with God as revealed in Jesus Christ... Peter's differentiated application of Leviticus is interesting in that it preserves the authority of God's word to ancient Israel as binding on Christians, but it does *not* prescribe the specifics of the Levitical code as the way of life to be followed by his Christian readers... after the resurrection of Jesus Christ and after the coming of the Holy Spirit at Pentecost" (Jobes, 114-115). Peter's silence on this topic is particularly telling since the Judaism dominant in Asia Minor long had syncretistic tendencies, so that

Jewish readers, let alone Gentile ones, could not safely be presumed to be following kosher laws. Moreover, he will later make bold connections between the OT people of God (e.g., 2:5ff, 3:6) and his readers (at least partly gentile: see 1:1.3, second paragraph). Although it has not always been a steady process (Gal 2:11-14), Peter has by now learned well the truth of what Jesus long ago (Mk 7:19) implied: the Mosaic regulations, having had their intent fulfilled in Christ, have ceased (Heb 10:1ff). Accordingly, it is unhelpful and misguided at the interpersonal level to require adherence to food laws and the like (Col 2:16ff); and it is deluded and dangerous on the political level to attempt to impose some scheme of Israelite-style civil administration on a nation (1 Pet 2:17).

1:17.1 *And if you invoke the help of the Father:* For the meaning of this verb (ἐπικαλεῶ), see Montanari (768). Calling God “Father” is not unique to Christianity, but it is distinctive of it. The development of this terminology no doubt stems from the teachings of Jesus (e.g., Mat 5:16, 6:9, Jn 20:17), which of course are Peter’s lifeblood. The Christian’s connection to God is not ritualistic, but familial. Christians thus find themselves in an incredibly privileged position—and yet in Peter’s worldview the father ideally not only loves his children but also dispenses discipline as necessary (see 1:14.2 above). So, reasons Peter, if his readers consider themselves God’s children, they must be aware that precisely because he is their Father he holds disciplinary authority over them and has definite expectations for them. “God’s tenderness... is mingled with his judgment and the fear [see 1:17.3 below] that should mark Christians in this world. Apparently Peter did not think that the two themes [of tenderness and judgment] negated each other but are complementary” (Schreiner, 82-83).

1:17.2 *the one who without partiality judges each person according to his deeds:* God’s fairness and omniscience is a constant theme of Scripture (e.g., Ps 28:4, Isa 59:18, Jer 17:10, Rom 2:6, Rev 2:23, 22:14-15); he shows no bias, and cannot be bribed.

1:17.3 *conduct the time of your sojourning in fear:* Peter again calls on his readers to visualize their lives in the world not as the sum total of their existence, but as a temporary stay-over on their journey toward eternity. Yet how they live as sojourners matters greatly, since after what in the end will be seen to have been a short earthly life, they will face the Father who is also an impartial judge. Thus, their day-to-day activities should be informed by “fear” (φοβος). Now, it has already been noted (1:17.1) that there is a unique intimacy with God inherent in Christianity. This “fear,” then, cannot be the sort of terror that horrifies and immobilizes. Far from it: “There is a kind of fear that does not contradict confidence. A confident driver also possesses a healthy fear of an accident that prevents him from doing anything foolish” (Schreiner, 81). Life is a matter of great seriousness. There is no place in Christianity for a spirit of presumptuousness.

1:18.1 *since you know that it is not with corruptible things—silver or gold—that you have been redeemed:* In saying “since you know” (εἰδοτες), Peter implies that in connection to the price of their redemption, they do not need new information, but to be reminded of old information. Such will be a key theme of Peter’s in his second epistle (1:12-13, 3:1-2). Being reminded is a key idea throughout the Bible.

It is true that gold does not rust, and indeed Peter assumes that gold does have considerable value. The high value of gold, together with silver, serves to heighten the value of the blood of Christ, which is even more valuable than these precious metals (cf. Sproul, 20-21, 31). Yet it is the clear teaching of Scripture (e.g., Ps 39:6, Pr 15:17) and the repeated experience of humankind that wealth is transitory. Hence it was necessary that something far more lasting and valuable obtain our redemption.

There is a range of rich possibilities for the background of “redeem” (λυτρω). Jobes (116-118) makes, on lexical and literary grounds, a strong case both for (1) the manumission of a slave and for (2) the redemption of God’s people from exile. In addition, Davids (72-73) points to (3) various connections

with the Passover narrative (in which [Ex 12:1ff] the sacrificial lamb serves as a type of the sacrifice of Christ on the cross). If one has to choose between these options, the second is preferable given Peter's rich and full use of the OT (cf. Schreiner, 84) and his frequent sojourning imagery. Yet perhaps it best to say that the whole complex of ideas—deliverance from the grip of sin, release from the oppression of captors, sacrifice of the best of lambs—swirls in the background.

1:18.2 *from your futile way of life you inherited from your ancestors:* As noted above (1:1.3), it is unlikely that Peter would say this to a predominantly Jewish congregation. Even Paul—for whom demonstrating the inadequacy of the Mosaic Law for salvation was constantly necessary—spoke highly of the Jewish people and of his heritage (e.g., Rom 3:1-2, 7:12, 11:28). Jobes (119) points to Phil 3:4-9 as an example of Paul speaking of “the heritage passed down to him as ‘garbage’ (useless) compared with” salvation in Christ. In that passage, however, Paul is reacting against a resurgence of works-based Judaism within the Church (see vv2-3). Here in 1 Pet 1:18 there is no hint that Peter is speaking specifically of distortions of the intent of the OT when he describes his readers' paternal heritage as “futile” (μᾶταιος)—the whole package seems to be in view. Moreover, Jobes also notes that in the OG versions, the term just mentioned is “often used... to describe pagan idols” (118).

At any rate, the main point is that believers' redemption has rescued them from a way of life that, though pervasive, offers no hope of true and eternal life. Contrary to certain modern ways of thinking, mankind is not by its own inherent genius and effort becoming morally better and better (even if in a two steps forward, one step back manner). Humankind constantly inflicts fresh misery on itself, and can never secure its own salvation; God's intervention is necessary. For human civilization is “empty of hope and value when viewed in the light of the gospel (1 Cor. 3:20; Eph 4:17; cf. Rom. 1:21; 8:20; Jas. 1:26). This same evaluation of pagan worship is made in both Testaments (Lev. 17:7; 2 Chron. 11:15; Jer. 8:19; Acts 14:15). Before they had received the gospel, these believers had a culture with its values and religion, indeed perhaps a high culture, but however sincere they may have been about it and however beautiful it was, they can now see that in the end it was a futile existence” (Davids, 72).

1:19 *but rather with the precious blood—as of a perfect and spotless lamb—of Christ:* Scholars debate whether the imagery used here is specifically of the Passover lamb (Davids, 72-73) or more generally of the OT sacrificial system in general (e.g., Grudem, 89-90). It is probably impossible to know precisely what OT text or texts animates Peter's mind at this point, but it makes little difference. God's expectation of an unblemished sacrifice for sin (e.g., Lev 22:21, Mal 1:6-9) is fully met in Christ, whose life was altogether flawless and hence whose death on the cross was infinitely valuable. It is also evident that Christ's death was no mere exemplar of selfless living, but a *substitution* for the sinner (see further Bavinck, 3:337ff).

1:20.1 *foreknown on the one hand from before the foundation of the world:* The coordinating conjunctions “one the one hand... on the other hand” (here and in the following segment) set up a remarkable pairing of facts: (1) God the Son was known (by God the Father, together with God the Son; on this verb, cf. on 1:2.1) in eternity past (“the foundation of the world” is a Jewish expression for creation); and (2) at a certain point in history, this Son became human in order to save humans (see below). Thus, before God spoke the world into existence, he had already planned its rescue.

1:20.2 *made manifest on the other hand at the final days of time for your sakes:* Or (by way of slight simplification/paraphrase), “and appeared for your benefit at history's end.”

While Christ's saving work had been planned before the very first moment of time (cf. Jobes, 119), his unveiling has come at a crucial juncture of human history (cf. the reflections on 1:12.4 above). The word for “make manifest” (φανερω) is a charged one: It speaks of something truly remarkable—in

the Greco-Roman tradition, sometimes a god—coming into view. In the case of Christ, this was his becoming human in order to bring God’s revelation and redemption (cf., e.g., Jn 1:1-29).

Peter’s words “at the final days of time” (cf., e.g., 1 Cor 10:11, Heb 1:2, 9:26) allude to the fact that Christ’s finished work has already decided the course of human history. What Christians are presently seeing is the denouement of God’s dramatic intervention in human affairs. This intervention will culminate in the new heavens and new earth (a point the apostle will make explicitly in 2 Pet 3:13). The salvation of God’s elect is not an uncertain outcome but an unfolding plan.

“Peter appends the stupendous words ‘for your sake[s].’ Others waited and longed for this revelation of Christ (1 Pet. 1:10-12); the church (indicated by the collective ‘you’) has received it and benefits from it. This sense of their place in God’s plan, their privileged status, along with their sense of the impending end, should strengthen these believers in the face of their concomitant trials” (Davids, 75).

1:21.1 *who through him*: That is, through Christ. Now, the Greek for “through” here (διὰ) could be translated “because of,” in which Christ’s work provides the motivation for people to believe. However, the NT often speaks of Jesus as the channel through which God’s saving benefits reach believers (e.g., Jn 1:17, Rom 5:2, Eph 2:18, Heb 7:25), and Peter will go on to say (1:21.3) that believers’ faith and hope rest in *God*, not themselves. So what Peter is saying here is more than that Jesus is an inspirational example. Jesus is rather the one and only door. Clearly, Peter has fully absorbed the words of Jesus recorded in Jn 10:1ff. Indeed, this is neither the first time that Peter himself uses such language (Ac 2:22), nor the last (1 Pet 2:5; cf. 4:11.2).

1:21.2 *have believed in God*: The very belief of Christians is said to come through Christ. In a sense, then, faith is not the key that opens the door to God’s treasury; it is rather part of the treasury itself. If it was not for Christ’s self-sacrifice, no one would believe.

1:21.3 *who raised him from the dead*: Peter returns to Christ’s resurrection (mentioned in 1:3.4). As in that previous passage, Peter closely connects Christ and believers in Christ. Just as God raised Christ from the dead on the third day, so he will raise up those who believe in Christ on the final day.

1:21.4 *and gave him glory*: Christ’s resurrection was no mere returning to the way things had been before he perished, as remarkable as that would be. Nor was Christ’s resurrection a reincarnation, a return to a life that is comparable to, or at most a bit superior to, his former life. Christ arose to claim a glorified life. It was crucially his own life, his own body, to which he returned; yet in exchange for lowliness and humiliation, he received from his well-pleased Father greatness and exaltation.

It is possible that Peter here refers not simply to the resurrection, but to the ascension (cf. Lk 24:26, Jn 17:5, Heb 2:7, where the same Greek word [δοξα] for “glory” also occurs). Peter does combine those two events in 3:21-22. If he has it in mind here, such would underscore the importance of Jesus’ ascension as a clear indication of God’s vindication and honoring of him.

There is an implication that just as God raised up Jesus after Jesus’ death, so he will one day raise up the Anatolian believers; and just as he brought honor to Jesus—who was publicly shamed before and at his crucifixion—so he will one day honor the Christian in Asia Minor “no matter how oppressed and shamed they may be now” (Davids, 75).

1:21.5 *so that your faith—and [your] hope—rest in God*: This is Peter’s version of Rom 3:27a or Eph 2:9. No one will stand before the throne of God and speak of what he or she has done; it is all *God’s* doing.

In the two Pauline passages just mentioned, Paul for his purposes dilates on the concept of faith. Peter’s scope is broader, for in this epistle he is redirecting his readers’ gaze to their *future* blessings,

calling on them to consider their current circumstances—trials and all—as merely temporary phenomena. So it is that he adds to “faith” (ΠΙΣΤΙΣ) the term “hope” (ΕΛΠΙΣ). This, too, is from God.

1:22.1 *Having purified your souls:* Most cultures, ancient and modern, have some notion of purity as something that is vital to gain or maintain. Purity certainly was a feature in Hellenistic culture, though with considerable variety from one locale and community to another. Doubtless, Peter had principally in mind—and his readers would have understood to refer to—biblical notions of purity, wherein access to formalized and legitimate worship of God, or the means to such, is effected or restored (cf., e.g., Lev 8:15, 12:4). Peter does not mean to reinstate the procedures of the Mosaic Law (cf. 1:16.2)—Peter’s use of the word “souls” (ΨΥΧΗ) “emphasizes the inward, spiritual nature of this purification” (Grudem, 93)—but the pattern of the OT does provide a model: loving one another (1:22.7) does not come out of nowhere, but develops out of a prior consideration for one’s own purity.

The timing of this purification is debated. Some equate it with (1) the believer’s initial conversion (e.g., Grudem, 92-93; Sproul, 34); others equate it to (2) the progressive sanctification that is to characterize a believer’s life as a whole (e.g., Davids, 76; Jobes, 123-124; Schreiner, 92-93). (Against the idea that Peter refers to baptism as such, see Jobes [123-124].) Some scholars feel that the fact that *ἡγνικότες* is in the perfect tense (which highlights ongoing results) supports the first position. But as far as I can tell, that is too specific a meaning to expect a tense-form to bear (cf. Grudem, 92). Some scholars feel that the words “in the obedience of the truth” (1:22.2) necessitate adopting the second position, since elsewhere Scripture clearly indicates that salvation is a matter of grace, not merit (Eph 2:8-9, etc.). But inasmuch as human rebellion against God makes casting oneself upon his grace necessary, it is not optional (cf., e.g., Ac 4:12) and can be called “obedience” (cf. Rom 2:8, 10:16). It is difficult to decide between these options, but either way a dedication to God’s ways over against human ways must be the grounding for love.

1:22.2 *in the obedience of the truth:* Truth is a significant concern of Peter’s (cf. 2 Pet 1:12, 2:2). As these and other passages (e.g., Rom 1:18 1 Tim 2:4, 3 Jn 12) suggest, “truth” here refers not to any one particular truth of Christianity, but rather to the whole system of Christianity, which is the only fully correct account of cosmology and ethics. Western “culture is against the idea of objective truth, and this antipathy is rooted and grounded in fallen humanity’s fundamental hostility to truth itself... The tragedy of fallen humanity is that we tend to give ourselves in obedience to the lie, to that which is false” (Sproul, 35). The joy of redeemed humanity is that we who make Christ our hope find pleasure in doing what is right and genuine (Ps 119). But such obedience is not our doing; it comes with the Spirit’s enabling (1:22.4).

1:22.3 *through the Spirit:* As Peter alluded to in his letter opening (1:2.2), God the Spirit takes an active and indispensable role in believers’ sanctification. Having begun by the Spirit, his readers will continue by the Spirit (cf. Gal 3:3). Peter does not detail just how the Holy Spirit aids believers in their purification (perhaps because the Spirit’s work is tremendously variegated [cf., e.g., 1 Cor 12:4-6] and often subtle [cf. Jn 3:8]); but his readers would be fooling themselves if they thought that they could accomplish this purification by themselves. Believers are continually “dependent on the operation and energizing influence of the Holy Spirit” (Sproul, 35).

1:22.4 *for an unfeigned familial love:* Peter does not imply that his readers have so far been merely *pretending* to love, for his language here is standard in the NT (Davids, 77). But while he is not criticizing them, he clearly feels strongly about this subject, as becomes evident as he continues.

Probably every culture has some sense of the propriety of devotedly loving one’s own family. But Christians “are to have that kind of fervent love not only for our biological families but also our family in

the Spirit, our brothers and sisters in Christ” (Sproul, 36), as Peter indicates by his “familial love” (φιλαδελφια).¹²

1:22.5 *from a clean heart love one another fervently*: The Greek word behind “clean” (καθαρος) can bear a variety of senses. For present purposes, the most important of these are (1) ritually pure, i.e. suitable for worship; and (2) innocent of wrongdoing. If Peter intends the first sense, then he is reiterating the point about purity he has already made (1:22.1). If he intends the second sense, he might be clarifying that the love he calls on believers to exercise toward each other should not cross certain boundaries (cf. 1 Tim 5:2 for a similar thought). In later times at least, Christians would be falsely accused of licentiousness, so perhaps Peter is seeking to safeguard the reputation of the Church. It is hazardous, however, to read later Church history back into Peter’s day. Moreover, the NT calls for Christians to love one another so frequently that it is questionable whether Peter would feel it necessary to explain the concept here. It seems somewhat more likely, then, that Peter has in mind the need for prior consecration to God’s service; Christians cannot simply conjure up love for one another, but must draw that love from a well that they dug by a life of Spirit-empowered obedience to God’s truth.¹³

If Peter puts certain limits on the nature of the love to be offered, he puts up few, if any, boundaries on the extent of the love to be offered: The Anatolian believers are to love one another “fervently” (εκτενως). In light of the gospel (as the following verses will show), it would be absurd for Christians to be stingy in their displays of love for another.

But what *is* love? Surely this is among life’s more difficult questions—and yet most people know love when they see it. For the purposes of reflecting on this verse, the question is of course focused on love between Christians. When it comes to what love looks like, Sproul’s definition is compelling in my view: “[l]oving our neighbor means treating him [or her] with care, kindness, and patience” (36). I would add that love, when it is not responded to, causes pain, or at least disappointment. What Bavinck says concerns the love of God is, it seems to me, true to an extent of love in general: “the goodness of God appears as *love* when it not only conveys certain benefits but God himself” (2:215, italics his). Genuine love is not simply some word or deed entirely separable from the person uttering or accomplishing it, but represents a certain investment of himself or herself in the wellbeing of another.

Certainly, there are many kinds and many degrees of love, and so it bears repeating: Peter calls on believers to love one another not halfheartedly, but “fervently.” Perhaps no human alive can fully capture what love is with words; but every believer must zealously show what love is in their lives.

1:23 *since you have been born again not from a corruptible seed, but from an incorruptible one—through the living and eternally abiding word of God*: On “born again,” cf. 1:3.3.

The idea behind “corruptible seed... an incorruptible one” is roughly as follows. A person’s initial birth into the world comes about through mortal parentage, and just the parent will one day die, so will the offspring. But a believer’s second birth comes about from something permanent, and so her or his

¹² It is commonly, but incorrectly, stated that the ancient Greek language had morally stratified terms for love, ranging more or less from (1) purely sensual love in ερωσ (usually transliterated *eros*) through (2-3) a more mixed φιλια (*filia*) and φιλαδελφια (*philadelphia*) to the purest sort of love in (4) αγαπη (*agape*). This approach does not handle any of these Greek terms fairly, however. For instance, in Jn 5:20 the Father is said to “love” the Son, and the Greek words used there is verb form of the second noun, not the fourth; then too, in Mat 5:46 tax collectors (in a context where their reputation for being cheats and traitors is in view) are said to “love” one another with αγαπη love. The truth is that these Greek terms differ in ways that are not morally categorizable—apart, in some instances, from contextual indicators.

¹³ One implication of this necessity is that even where partners in a homosexual relationship feel genuine affection for one another, that affection does not justify homosexuality. Love, however one defines it, cannot operate independently of God and of his wisdom.

spiritual new life will likewise endure forever.

1:24-25 The quotation is (allowing for slight variations, due either to textual variants or to paraphrase from Peter) taken from Isa 40:6-8 as translated in the OG. Peter might be consciously making use of the main Greek version available to his readers, few of whom know Hebrew; or it might simply be what feels natural to him, since he is writing in Greek, not Hebrew. Either way, it should be noted that in Peter's day it was not easy to consult a work to check the exact wording, nor was it expected in most situations to reproduce a quotation to the letter; so he is not being careless if his wording differs from his source in immaterial ways.

1:24.1 *All flesh is like grass, and all the glory of humankind is like the blossoming of grass:* The term "flesh" (Greek σαρξ; Hebrew בשר) in the Bible can bear a variety of senses (see further on 3:18.3, second paragraph). In this case, (1) the context and (2) the fact that "the glory of humankind" is parallel to it indicate that the idea is human mortality as opposed to divine immortality. So Peter is echoing Isaiah's declaration that the human lifespan is temporary—indeed, fleeting.

Moreover, not only is any individual human life fleeting, but the collective achievements of the human race ("all the glory of humankind") is in the larger scheme of things every bit as transitory as the flourishing of grass is. A green field soon loses its color as the season changes, and a prosperous civilization soon loses its luster as time marches on.

1:24.2 *Grass has withered, and its blossom has fallen:*¹⁴ The point is again that all the might of humanity is as transitory as the flourishing of plant life in spring and summer.

1:25.1 *but the word of the Lord abides eternally:* The main terms for "word" in the Bible (in Greek, λόγος and, as here, ῥημα; in Hebrew, דבר) can denote more than just one item in a sentence: they can denote a saying, message, declaration, or topic. Now, there is (at least in English) a strong tradition of using the term "the Word of God" to mean "the Bible." It is certainly fine in English speech and composition to use that term with that meaning, but it should be noted that it is not clear that the NT ever uses "the word of God" to mean *specifically* "the Bible." In some instances, it certainly does not. For example, in Ac 12:24 the meaning is "the message concerning Christ" (the Bible was not gradually growing and spreading during this period). Similarly, in Heb 11:3 the meaning is "the words spoken by God at the beginning of time" (for God, not the Bible, spoke the universe into being). In the context of Isaiah chapter 40, the prophet is not concerned with the eternal significance of the Bible (though his high view of Scripture cannot reasonably be denied; see, e.g., 8:20), but with the proclamation of God's coming in salvation for his people: God, Isaiah proclaims, is coming to rule and care for his people (40:10-11). So this part of 1 Pet 1:25 could be translated, "but the declaration of the Lord [that salvation is coming for his people] abides eternally."

To say that the declaration of the Lord "abides" (in Hebrew, דיק; in Greek, μενει) forever is to say that it can never be countermanded or fail. What God begins in the life of the believer, he finishes (Phil 1:16, 1 Thes 5:24). Those who by faith receive the gospel are eternally secure.

1:25.2 *Now this is the word that was proclaimed to you:* "This" refers to the everlasting proclamation of

¹⁴ From the perspective of a native English speaker, this translation is a bit wooden and strange. I have rendered it this way because the Greek seems a bit odd (though I could be wrong on this point, as there is some evidence for the use of the aorist tense in comparable cases in native Greek literature). The reason for this stylistic ruggedness is that these two clauses are translated from Hebrew, and the OG versions tend to sacrifice smoothness for literalness (even in OG-Isaiah, which is a highly interpretive translation).

God that his people will be saved (1:25.1).

“Proclaimed” (εὐαγγελισθῆν) is in Greek the verb form “gospel” (on which see 1:12.3); if there was such a verb in English, this part of the verse could be translated, “Now this is the word that was gospelled to you.” When the Anatolian believers heard the good news about Jesus, the prophecy found in Isaiah chapter 40, which had begun to be fulfilled in the days of John the Baptist (Mk 1:1ff), continued its promised fruitfulness in their own lives. It continues in the present whenever one turns to Christ, and will do so until all of God’s people find their shepherd-king in Christ.

As Jobes (126-130) points out, Peter does not limit the prophecy to ethnic Israel. This is despite the words of Isa 40:6, “Say to the cities of Judah.” Perhaps Peter takes his cue from v5 (“all flesh”), or perhaps a wider hermeneutical enterprise is at work wherein OT texts connected to Israel are connected to the Church. Certainly Peter had wrestled intensively with these matters in the past (cf. esp. Ac 10:9ff), and here he makes a special point (“to you”) to connect his Anatolian readers with the ancient words of the OT. In Christ every promise of God is “yes” (2 Cor 1:20), and this is true for all believers.

To cycle back to the main point of Peter’s paragraph (1:22-25), the apostle brings up the eternal security of the imperishable gospel not to cause his readers to rest on their laurels, but to impel them to fervent love for one another. If God’s love for us is unstoppable and unending, so should be our commitment to the well-being of those who are now by faith a part of our family.

2:1.2 *Therefore, putting away:* That is, eliminating from one’s conduct.

2:1.2 *wickedness:* I tentatively follow Montanari’s first (1014a) suggested translation of κακία. Some (e.g., Arndt and Gingrich, 397b) argue that the Greek word can be more specific, meaning something like “hatred.” It is difficult to decide between these options. Either way, Peter is—to judge from the terms that follow in this verse—principally concerned with improper behavior in interpersonal relationships. Such things as deceptions, hypocrisy, ill-will, and slander are “community-destroying vices that are often tolerated by the modern church” (Davids, 80).

2:1.3 *deception:* Many attempt to justify at least some degree of deceptiveness in their dealings with others. The apostle Peter, however, sees deception as inconsistent with the new birth (cf. 1:2.1 above). “Deceit involves a definite attempt to distort, hide, or undermine the truth” (Sproul, 43).

2:1.4 *hypocrisy:* Or “pretense” (Montanari, 2225c). Possibly the meaning is more generally “evil-doing,” but the density of speech-related sins suggests the meaning is “hypocrisy” here. In Greek, the word is plural.

2:1.5 *ill-will:* Or “envy” (both these renderings being found in Montanari, 2274c).

2:1.6 *slander:* Slander can be defined as “any speech which harms or is intended to harm another person’s status, reputation, etc.” (Grudem, 99).

2:2.1 *as newborn infants... milk:* That is, just as babies urgently desire their mother’s milk, so believers should urgently desire God’s means of grace (see further 2:2.4 below).

2:2.2 *rational:* The meaning of the Greek here (λογικός) is much debated. It might be best to list the major glosses provided by a recent scholarly treatment (that of Montanari): (1) “concerning speech or speaking”; (2) “concerning prose, written in prose” (both 1249b); (3) “concerning reason, rational”; (4) “in conformity with reason, rational”; (5) endowed with reason, rational”; (6) “spiritual” (1249c).

The first sense does not fit the context particularly well. Despite Peter’s recent emphasis on

proper speech (see the previous verse), what he goes on from here to talk about in the following verses is something much more expensive than simply pure modes of communication. The second sense obviously does not fit the context in that Peter is not talking about genre. The third sense does not fit the context in that Peter is not talking about logic as a branch of human investigation.

The fourth sense seems plausible in that (1) Peter has recently (2:2.1) used a logical connective (“therefore”) and, more importantly, (2) the apostle has been speaking at length (from 1:13 on) about what attitudes and actions would be appropriate responses to God’s grace in the lives of Christians. The present adjective could, then, underscore the fact that what he is urging his readers to seek after is only that which is fitting for people like them.

The fifth sense seems highly problematic to me in that it would attribute a human-like consciousness to the “milk” (2:2.4). Some, taking that “milk” as a reference to the Bible, might appeal to Heb 4:12-13, but it is not clear to me that there is sufficient contextual grounds for thinking that the milk refers to the Bible. If the milk refers more or less directly to God, why would Peter feel the need to specify that God possesses rationality?

The sixth item is described by Montanari as “late,” and indeed, although Montanari himself puts Rom 12:1 in this category, this usage might postdate NT times. Of the early instances that scholars cite in support of this usage, it is not entirely clear to me that any of them bear this meaning. For instance, Arndt and Gingrich (477b) cite Philo (*Special Laws* I, 277) and Epictetus (3.1.26), but both passages seem to me to reflect the fifth sense listed above (cf. Schreiner, 100). Nor is it clear whether or how far this sense overlaps with the meaning “metaphorical,” and if it does, whether this latter sense forms a part of Peter’s Greek.

An item *not* on Montanari’s list should be mentioned because it is frequently found in translations and commentaries, viz. “biblical,” in which case one might translate “the pure milk of the word” or something similar, that is, “the pure milk which is [metaphorically speaking] the Bible.” Multiple assumptions are at work in such a view: One needs to argue that λογικός can safely be freighted with the possible senses of the term λογος, that the specific sense meant is “the word of God,” and that that “word of God” is the Bible in particular, not any other pronouncement or decree of God in general (cf. 1:25.1; cf. further Jobes, 133). This is not *necessarily* to say that “rational milk” cannot be a metaphor for Scripture (for an example of this view, see Grudem [101], only that the adjective λογικός cannot straightforwardly be construed as bearing this meaning *in itself*.

In the end, then, the fourth sense (“rational”) seems to be best. The adjective points to the fact that the milk is what is reasonable for Christians to desire. Those saved by God cannot reasonably do otherwise than seek the things of God.

2:2.3 pure: That is, “unmixed,” “unadulterated” (αδολος); the milk is untainted by evil.

2:2.4 milk: On the metaphor as a whole, see on 2:2.1 above. There are two primary questions to answer the milk here. (1) Does it imply a subtle criticism of the Anatolian believers, since a need for milk is associated with immaturity in 1 Cor 3:2 and Heb 5:12? (2) What does the metaphor refer to?

As to the first question, the initial answer that can be given is, “Not necessarily.” Elsewhere in Scripture milk is used in a positive, or least neutral, way (e.g., Ex 3:8, SS 4:11, 1 Cor 9:7), and so also in other literature roughly contemporary with Peter (Davids, 82). And on further investigation, the answer is, “Probably not.” While Peter can imagine his readers getting themselves into trouble (1 Pet 2:20, 3:17, 4:15), the trouble in all these passages is hypothetical, not actual. There is no definite rebuke from the apostle to his readers in either of his epistles. On the contrary, he speaks quite positively of them (e.g., 1 Pet 4:4). In the immediate context, Peter will speak of his readers as approaching Christ whereas unbelievers reject Jesus (2:4ff); in other words, he definitively classes them with the redeemed of God.

As to the second question, the milk is frequently identified by commentators with the Bible (e.g.,

Grudem, 101; Sproul, 44-45), but this identification is questionable. Jobes argues at length (132-141) that the meaning is “God’s life-sustaining grace in Christ” (141). There is no clear contextual indicator that the Bible is Peter’s main concern here (cf. on 1:25.1 above), and it is far from obvious that Peter could expect his readers to understand milk here as referring to the Scriptures without some explanation. Moreover, the preceding elements of the current sentence deal with wrong sorts of things to say and to think, not wrong sources of information and knowledge; and the following clauses will dwell at length on christology, not bibliology. There is some precedent in Judaism for comparing the Bible to milk (Yamauchi and Wilson, 1204), and Peter will later (2 Pet 1:19) point out how indispensable the Bible is for the Christian pilgrimage. Still, it seems to me most probable that Peter casts a wider net, saying that that believers need to seek nourishment not only in holy Scripture, but also in spiritual song (Col 1:16), in Christian community (Heb 10:24-25), in fervent prayer (Jude 20). To be clear, these things are never to be pitted against Scripture, as if, for instance, a hymn could be said to override or nullify a doctrine taught in Scripture. But a flourishing Christian life is not one which consists entirely in sitting and reading the Bible; biblical truths must also be put into action. Some Christian traditions speak of various “means of grace”; as long as one does *not* mean by that term some sort of mechanical infusion of merit, this is an apt phrase, inasmuch as God’s unprompted kindness and undeserved goodness reach his people through various channels, many seemingly ordinary and mundane yet nonetheless enlivening and sustaining. Every form of spiritual nourishment God has provided should be eagerly sought.

2:2.5 *in order that by it you might grow*: Christian life must not be static. Having come to know Christ, it is only fitting to press on to know him more (Phil 3:10). Babies do not remain babies; they grow into adults. So it is with believers as well.

2:3.1 *since*: The NT often (see Davids, 83-84) uses such language “not... to sow doubts in the minds of the readers” (Schreiner, 101) but rather to invite them to internalize the logic for themselves (“Have I tasted that the Lord is good? Yes, I certainly have! So I should...”). Peter’s tone here is one of approval and affirmation (cf. on 2:2.4, second paragraph). Consequently, it can be said that the apostle is drawing attention to the logic of Christian living: Christians know from personal experience (2:3.2) that God is good, and so in their more rational moments they reject what is worldly and cling to what is godly.

2:3.2 *you have tasted*: In other words, “You have experienced.” Authentic Christianity is not only heard, but felt. This metaphor comes from Psalm 34:8 (in the OG, 33:9).

2:3.3 *the Lord is good*: Although Psalm 34 was written in Hebrew, it just so happens that v8 (in Hebrew, v9), becomes, when translated into Greek, a pun: “The Lord is good” (χρηστος ο κυριος) sounds extremely similar to “Christ is the Lord” (χριστος ο κυριος). This double meaning fits beautifully here, where the goodness of God’s milk is a wholly natural prompt to good behavior (vv1-2) and the authority of God’s anointed is a powerful magnet to chosen saints (vv4ff).

2:4.1 *to whom*: That is, “to Christ” (“the Lord” in the previous verse).

2:4.2 *approaching*: Peter uses the same Greek verb (allowing for suppletion) as the OG translation of Ps 34:5 (in Greek, 33:6), “Come to him,” thus continuing to use that passage as a guiding star. Though this Greek verb paraphrases the Hebrew, it catches the meaning: the OG versions employ it in contexts of “drawing near” to God, either to hear him speak (Lev. 9:5; Deut. 4:11; 5:27) or to come into his presence in the tabernacle to offer sacrifices (Exod. 12:48; 16:9; Lev. 9:7-8; 10:4-5; etc.). It is also used in Hebrews as a specialized term for ‘drawing near’ to God in worship (Heb. 4:16; 7:25; 10:1, 22; 11:6; 12:18, 22)” (Grudem, 103) suggesting to a wide use of this term in early Christianity. “For Peter, the exhortation... to

‘come to God’ is achieved through coming to Jesus through faith” (Jobes, 145). Believers’ worshipful encounter with Jesus forms the setting of the benefits that the apostle will shortly (2:5.2) discuss.

2:4.3 as to a living stone: The prophecies in Isaiah (8:13-15, 28:16; cf. 17:10, 26:4, etc.) and in Psalms (118:22; cf. 18:31, 95:1, etc.) provide ample precedent for picturing Christ as a stone—not to mention Jesus’ own use of such passages (e.g., Mat 21:42ff).¹⁵ The reason for this stone imagery will be explored below (vv6-8). Why describe the stone as “living”? Various theories could be discussed, but to my mind the most straightforward explanation is that Peter is repeating the same keyword as in 1:3.4 (viz., “living” hope). It is no minor point that there, practically at the outset of his epistle, Peter made mention of the resurrection of Christ: that Jesus left his tomb, never to die again, forever changed how Peter looked at the world. In a crucial sense, Christ’s work is not a thing of the past; it is a present reality. Christ did not just die, he *lives*.

2:5.1 you yourselves also, being comparable to living stones: The Anatolian believers, as so many redeemed individuals, form the stones from which God’s temple is being constructed.

2:5.2 into a spiritual temple: The language¹⁶ is not only figurative (human beings do not *literally* turn into a temple!), but also transcendent: the rites and requirements associated with the temple of Jerusalem were for Peter a thing of the past (cf. on 1:16.2, second paragraph). Accordingly, Peter makes clear that he is speaking of a “spiritual” (πνευματικός) temple. The old temple was made of carved stone blocks. The new temple is made of redeemed human hearts. Congregations that use a building—however ornate that structure might be—are no exception. “The church is not the building itself, but the people meeting there. People don’t enter a church; the church enters a building” (Allberry, 17).

2:5.3 a holy priesthood: Broadly speaking, the role of a priesthood is to mediate God’s blessing to an individual or to a people by means of certain prescribed rituals performed by priests whose descent, qualities, and/or actions qualify them for this role. Variations on this theme pervade numerous cultures around the world. For Peter’s purposes, the key such institution is that of the OT levitical priesthood. Among other things, a priest under that system was required to boast descent from certain descendants of Aaron, the brother of Moses. Whether the readership of this epistle was primarily Jewish or primarily Gentile (for discussion, see 1:1.3, second paragraph), Peter does not have the levitical priesthood in mind, for he describes *all* of his readers as priests (something hardly true even of all Jewish readers). All believers can render service to God without the mediation of other people.

Peter qualifies “priesthood” with the adjective “holy.” In this context—where a sharp distinction is being drawn between Peter’s readers, who make Christ the foundation of their lives, and unbelievers, who reject Christ as the foundation of theirs—this term is probably not said by way of exhortation (as if

¹⁵ While it is precarious—being at a distance of two millennia from the apostolic period—to draw fine distinctions between Greek words, Sproul is perhaps right to “find it interesting that here Peter does not use the word *rock* (Greek *petros*) which is in the name Jesus gave him, saying, ‘You are Peter, and on this rock I will build My church’ (Matt. 16:18),” using instead the word *lithos* (46). In a similar vein, Jobes notes that Peter’s disinclination in this passage “to give himself any special place in this spiritual house is revealing and suggests that the author was not writing under the later Catholic doctrine of Peter’s primacy” (144).

¹⁶ More lit., “into a spiritual house.” However, the noun here (οἶκος) refers (occasionally in pagan literature [Montanari, 1435a] and often in Judeo-Christian writings [Arndt and Gingrich, 563a], in imitation of the Hebrew בית) in some contexts to a temple, particularly the temple of God in Jerusalem. Since the fact that the temple in Jerusalem was made of magnificent stones was something that impressed itself on the minds of many (Mk 13:1), and particularly since Peter will go on to speak of priestly service and of cultic sacrifices, the meaning “temple” is surely intended here (so also Davids, 87; Grudem, 105; Schreiner, 105-106; and cf. Jobes, 148-150).

you say, “and you ought to be holy”), but by way of affirmation (as if to say, “you, though not [at least for the most part] yourselves descendants of Aaron, have been deemed fit for God’s service”). “Even if Peter’s readers find themselves alienated from their society and suffering a loss of status, Peter assures them that they have become part of a much grander and everlasting community” (Jobes, 149).

2:5.4 to bring spiritual sacrifices: Here “spiritual” (πνευματικός) could be “Spirit-enabled” or “nonphysical”; the latter is more likely in this context (cf. 2:5.2 and the comments there). Moreover, in both Jewish and in Greco-Roman milieus *physical* sacrifices (whether of an animal, wine, or something similar) formed an intrinsic part of religious life, such that Peter likely felt it necessary to clarify that he is talking about *nonphysical* sacrifices. Having accepted the work of Christ on the cross, the Father requires no physical loss from his people, no giving up a valuable part of their material property.

But if the sacrifices of the NT era are not animals, wine, or any such thing, what are they? Peter doesn’t directly answer this question, but he will shortly say that his readers have been constituted as a nation (2:9.3) “so that you may proclaim the excellencies of him who called you out of darkness into his awe-inspiring light” (2:9.5). So at least part of the answer is the praise of God, whether in word or song. But in Rom 12:1ff, Paul gives a somewhat fuller answer: to worship God in view of the coming Christ and the outpouring of the Spirit is to resist conformity to the mindset of the unbelieving world, to humbly participate in partnership with the other members of the church, and to love one another sincerely and fully. None of these things can be captured in formulas or enacted by rituals. They cannot be quantified, but they are very real.¹⁷

2:5.5 which are thoroughly pleasing to God through Jesus Christ: Ancient readers of this epistle would not have taken for granted that any sacrifice would automatically be acceptable, for it was widely accepted that proper protocols would have to be observed. The “spiritual” nature of the church’s sacrifices just mentioned (2:5.5) might have given Peter’s readers pause, so the apostle emphasizes the point that “such sacrifices are pleasing to God” (Heb 13:16).

But just *how* are such things as praise to God? The good deeds of humankind are tainted by sin (Isa 64:6); faith in Christ, not the keeping of the law, is what saves (Gal 2:16). Christian’s good deeds are an outcome, not the means, of their salvation (Eph 2:8-10). So it is that Peter adds here the crucial words “through Jesus Christ.” Jesus Christ is “the mediator of a new covenant” (Heb 9:15), as Peter alluded to at the beginning of his epistle (1:2.3).

2:6.1 Since this [statement] stands in Scripture: In Isa 28:16.

2:6.2 “Behold, I am laying in Zion a chosen, honored cornerstone: These words of God’s through the prophet come in a context where people were “placing their trust in someone other than God (28:15). God’s secure foundation (28:16) offers hope to those in Zion, but it was rejected for a political solution (the “covenant of death” made with Egypt) that would end up destroying the nation... The theological principle Isaiah promotes is that if people trust God for security, they will have nothing to fear, but if they refuse to trust God and depend on man’s strength, political treaties, or human attempts to fix things, God will purposefully work against them” (Smith, 1:485). In the latter verse, “[t]he imagery of laying a foundation for a building is used to make the point. If the foundations are cheap stones, shoddily laid, it

¹⁷ This fact should on the one hand give pause to those inclined to run the church as if it was a capitalistic enterprise, described and propelled by graphs and charts; and on the other hand, it should give comfort to all humble Christians who feel keenly their lack of expertise, their inability to point to economic indicators of their usefulness. God delights in simple kindness, like that of Ruth to her grief-stricken mother-in-law; and prefers the two coins of the destitute widow to the riches of the wealthy (Lk 21:1-4).

is not possible for the building to survive the shocks which will come to it (Matt. 7:24–27)” (Oswalt, 1:517-518).

2:6.3 *and the person who believes in him will by no means be put to shame*: It is debated whether the sole reference of the passage in Isaiah is to Christ (so, e.g., Young, 2:284-288) or to a more general truth, of which Christ is the ultimate personification (Oswalt 1:518). Either way, for Peter the key takeaway is that Jesus has come to be the ultimate test of human loyalties: “by means of this stone [2:6.2] men will be tested. To some it will be an occasion of offense; to others, a foundation for their souls and lives. It is Jesus Christ who divides men; they are known by their attitude toward Him [Mat 10:34-36]” (Young, 2:287).

2:7.1 *So to you who believe is this honor*: That is, the honor of being built into a temple (2:5).

2:7.2 *but to those who disobey[, the following Scriptures apply]*: The Scriptures Peter will cite are Ps 118:22 and (in 2:8.1) Isa 8:14.

2:7.3 *The stone that the builders rejected—that very stone became the chief cornerstone*: The same general imagery of building material found in Isa 28:16 occurs also in Ps 118:22. In the latter passage, like the former, a life-altering decision separates people from one another: some people reject the building material (a *stone*) that God provides, while others accept it, and in fact find it to be the foundational structural element (the *chief cornerstone*) of what is being built.

2:8.1 *and, “A stone of stumbling and a rock of offense”*: The context of Isa 8:14 is very much like that of 28:16 (discussed at 2:6.2): people can either understand those things which most alarm the unbelieving nations as the things which should be most consequential in guiding their behavior (8:11-12), or they can view God’s nature and stances as more important and consequential than anything else (v13). v14 sharpens the focus: God himself is what people either stand on or trip over. Many (v15) find God unacceptable, leading to their destruction.

2:8.2 *who stumble at the word, being disobedient, to which [fate] they were indeed appointed*: The “word” (λογος) here could be the Bible (that is, what is said in the Bible, not the historicity of its contents *per se*; cf. on 2:8.1), or it could be the gospel message (cf. on 1:25.1). In this passage, where the fact that ultimately just two fates—salvation or damnation—dominate the scene, the latter is more likely, but there is little difference in these two approaches (for on the one hand the Scriptures send people to contemplate the truth of the gospel; and on the other hand the backstory, facts, and implications of the gospel are described in the pages of Scripture).

Peter clarifies that the “stumbling” referred to in Isa 8:14 is not some accident, some misstep; rather, it is unambiguous disobedience. The readers’ neighbors sin constantly (1 Pet 4:4), and they themselves need to take steps to ensure their own purity (e.g., 1:22.1). The world is not full of innocent toddlers. It teems with insolent rebels.

Peter has already (1:1ff) spoken of God’s sovereignty in the fate of believers (Sproul, 49). Here he adds that the stumbling of the wicked is also a part of God’s immutable plan. Theologians sometimes label this particular decree of God as “reprobation” or “double predestination.” “From the perspective of the comprehensive character of the counsel of God, we have every right to speak of a ‘double predestination.’ Also sin, death, and eternal punishment are subject to God’s governance... Scripture, in fact, speaks very decisively and positively in this connection. It is true that Scripture seldom speaks of reprobation as an eternal decree. All the more, however, does it represent reprobation as an act of God in history. He rejects Cain (Gen. 4:5), curses Canaan (Gen. 9:25), expels Ishmael (Gen. 21:12; Rom 9:7;

Gal. 4:30), hates Esau (Gen. 25:23-26; Mal. 1:2-3; Rom. 9:13; Heb 12:17), and permits the Gentiles to walk in their own ways (Acts 14:16)... he creates the wicked for the day of evil (Prov. 16:4), does whatever he pleases (Ps. 115:3), inclines the heart of all humans as he wills (Prov. 16:9; 21:1), and orders their steps (Prov. 20:24; Jer. 10:23). Out of the same lump of clay he makes one vessel for beauty and another for menial use (Jer. 18; Rom. 9:20-24)" (Bavinck, 2:393-394; see further, pp393-399).

"Peter's purpose in making this comment is to comfort his readers. He has shown that the rejection of Christ and even the hostile unbelief which confronted these Christians on every side was predicted by God long ago in the Old Testament (vv. 7-8a). Now he says that they were not only predicted but also planned by God (v. 8b) and are therefore within the scope of his sovereign and wise plan for the world. Hostile unbelief should not terrify Christians against whom it is directed, for God their Father holds it all under his control, and will bring it to an end when he deems it best" (Grudem, 112).

2:9.1 a chosen people: Peter applies the words of Isaiah (and, below, of Moses) to his Anatolian readers (see further on 2:10.1 below). What's more, they are not just *any* people; they are God's "chosen" (ἐκλεκτός) people. Once again God's predestination arises to comfort the believers of Asia Minor (cf. on 1:2.1): they might be shunned by neighbors, but they are chosen by God; they might experience friction or breakage in their relationships with their earthly friends, but they gain greater and eternal connection with the global church.

2:9.2 a royal priesthood: Peter's wording here follows the OG paraphrase of the words ממלכת כהנים (lit., "a kingdom of priests") in Ex 19:6. As with the previous item, then, Peter applies a title given in the OT to the ancient Jewish nation to the modern diverse Church. Specifically, just as Israel could hold its head high among the nations of the earth, its God being the king of the universe, so can the Anatolian believers take solace in their royal Father; and just as Israel was to mediate the blessedness of God to the wider world, so can the readers of this epistle be a light to those around them.¹⁸

2:9.3 a holy nation: "Holy" here could refer either to the fact (1) that Peter's readers (like OT Israel, for Ex 19:6 is again being quoted) need to reflect God's righteous character or (2) that they uniquely belong to God (cf. on 1:16.2 above). Both in the context of Exodus chapter 19 (God establishes the nation as his by covenant) and in the present context (Peter contrasts the fate of those who come to Christ with those who reject him) the second sense is most apropos. The world might disown Peter's readers, but God claims them as his own.

Israel in OT times and the Church in NT times are also designated a "nation." Granting the unique roles of Moses and Joshua, the political organization of Israel was very loose indeed until, centuries later, it had a king in its midst. So too does the Church have a loose structure (though not *no* structure, as Peter will imply in chapter 5). Yet those individuals whom God calls to himself do not remain so many separate, isolated people, but are made by God into a cohesive, united people.

2:9.4 a people for a treasured possession [of God's]: Peter now quotes from Ex 19:5 (perhaps following a variant form of the OG, or placing these words last in order to use them as a climax). These words—placed as they are by Peter side by side with the words "a holy nation"—are not tautology, but emphasis by repetition. Peter's readers are, whatever their various lines of physical descent, a single *people*; and, whatever their former sins, they are *God's* people.

¹⁸ It would not be strictly accurate to derive the doctrine of the priesthood of all believers from *this* verse: as noted above, similar statements were made to OT Israel, and yet there was a crucial distinction in that polity between the levitical priests and everyone else (see, e.g., 2 Chron 26:16ff).

2:9.5 *so that you may proclaim the excellencies of him who called you out of darkness into his awe-inspiring light:* Peter seems to model the first part of this section (ὅπως τὰς ἀρετὰς ἐξαγγειλήτε) with the OG paraphrase of Isa 43:21: the OG οὐ... τὰς ἀρετὰς μου δῆγυσθαι (“who will show forth my excellencies”) represents the Hebrew תהלתִי יספרו (“my praise they will recount”).

The Greek word for “excellency” (ἀρετή) “was used to refer to the excellent character of one who is worthy of praise, as expressed, for instance, by acts of civic beneficence. Greek moral philosophers use... [the term] in discussing virtues of character that Greek society highly esteemed. In the religious context, the word referred to manifestations of divine power” (Jobes, 163; see further Davids, 92). God’s mighty and righteous deeds on behalf of his people deserve public announcements and loud singing (see Davids, 92-93; also Sproul, 53).

Peter could have spoken simply of the excellencies “of God,” but in his enthusiasm he chooses a more transcendent appellation: “of him who called you out of darkness into his awe-inspiring light.” In other words, God’s mighty deeds are to be viewed not merely as the acts of an omnipotent being, but of a wonderful savior. “Conversion is often depicted in the New Testament as a transfer from darkness to light” (Schreiner, 116). The apostle and his readers lived, of course, in an era without electricity: the darkness of night was palpable, the piercing freedom of dawn keenly felt. So such imagery is natural—so much so, perhaps, that Peter adds “awe-inspiring” to underscore the weighty transcendence of this light.

All this is stated in a context where the difference between Peter’s readers and their neighbors is an established fact, so this calling which which Peter’s readers have been “called” (καλέω, here in the Greek aorist tense-form) is not an invitation that might be rejected or withdrawn; rather, it is a certain, unchangeable decree from the same being whose “word creates light” (Schreiner, 116) in Genesis chapter 1 (similarly, from a slightly different angle, Sproul [53-54]).

2:10 *you who once were not a people, but now are the people of God; who had not been shown mercy, but now have been shown mercy:* Peter is giving the gist of Hos 2:23 (in Hebrew and Greek, this is v25), understood as (ultimately) referring to his readers. The question of the relationship between OT Israel and the NT Church has vexed theologians, especially in the last century or so. One could argue that Peter’s citation here is merely literary (cf., e.g., Schreiner, 115), but this argument fails to convince me for a couple of reasons: (1) In this short passage Peter accumulates Israel-oriented OT texts and concepts applied to the Anatolians, so the association of Israel and the Church is in no instance a one-off remark, not to be read into overmuch; and (2) several of these OT passages place particular emphasis on the *uniqueness* of God’s relationship of God to his people, so there is little to be said here for a view that God has two peoples—Israel and the Church—existing side-by-side or in succession.

That said, Peter’s use of Hos 2:23 does raise significant questions, especially this: the first three chapters of Hosea depict God’s redemption of certain unfaithful people, and it is crucial to the prophet’s message that the unfaithful and the redeemed are the *same*, not different. Accordingly, it would be problematic for Peter to imply that ethnic Israel had been deprived of mercy and peoplehood, while its replacement (the modern Church) has now gained mercy and peoplehood. But surely this is not the apostle’s meaning: “*you* were once not a people,” but “*you* are now the people of God.” As in Hosea, the unfaithful and the redeemed are the same.

How exactly all this is to be worked out, Peter does not explain. In truth, the NT at most touches on this matter; arguably, only Romans chapters 9-11 come close to offering a systematic treatment of the subject, yet has left many readers with questions (or with disagreements with other believers). Perhaps to some extent we ought to see the Israel-Church relationship less as a dogma of Scripture to be explained and defended than as an accomplishment of Christ to be received and advanced. Jesus, without—to our knowledge (cf. Ac 1:7)—explaining the theological basis for this, commanded his disciples to teach and baptize, not Israel as such, but the *nations* (Mat 28:19). This the apostles did (Mk 16:20, Ac 13:1ff), despite their former eschewal of people who could not boast pure Jewish blood (e.g., Mat 15:23,

Lk 9:54).¹⁹

In any case, Peter encourages his readers by reminding them of the effects of the gospel. Though at one time the Anatolians lacked a corporate life that linked them to God (cf. on 1:18.2) and had heaped up wicked deeds that had alienated them from God (cf. 1:14.3), they have now been linked together in a common life around God's unprompted kindness.

2:11.1 *Beloved:* "The address, 'beloved,' marks off the beginning of a new section of the letter; it is a common formula in Christian letters, although relatively rare in other Greek letters" (Davids, 94). It is surely evidence of God's work that this brash fisherman addresses his readers with overt affection.

2:11.2 *I exhort you as foreigners and sojourners:* With warmth and kindness, Peter once again (see 1:1.3) reconceptualizes the Anatolian environment. Their houses are not their eternal homes; their employment is not their key output; their relatives are not their true kin; their society is not their proper place; their burials are not their ultimate destiny. They are called to more.

2:11.3 *abstain from the fleshly lusts that wage war against your soul:* If the believers of Asia Minor had Asia Minor as their ultimate home, then in some measure giving in to the desires that characterize the land would be understandable. But Peter's readers are foreigners (2:11.3), so they must remain true to their calling—even in the face of grave internal conflict ("wage war"; see further Sproul, 59).

By "fleshly" (σαρκικός) Peter means "narrowly human, this-world principles and values" (this wording comes from Moo, 444). On "lusts" (ἐπιθυμιαί), see on 1:14.3. On "soul" (ψυχή), see on 1:9.2.

2:12.1 *maintaining honorable conduct among the gentiles:* An important corollary to the Christian's careful defense against sin (2:11.4) is the display of right behavior in the sight of unbelievers. As will be seen later in this verse, this is not a command always to have a good reputation—something that is sometimes unattainable in any event. Nevertheless, believers must display their status as God's people by tangible, visible deeds.

The word Greek word behind the term "gentile" (ἐθνος) is ambiguous: as with a key OT term (גוי), it can mean either "gentile" (someone who is not a part of God's people) or "nation" (roughly, a large-scale polity). In this instance, the difference between these two meanings is not great, and a case could be made for either meaning. The former meaning seems to fit the context better, as long as it is not understood that the Jewish people was replaced on account of their unworthiness (cf. on 2:10.1, second paragraph). The Church, God's own people, is surrounded on every side by people who walk in darkness and should glimpse the light by looking at the believers among them.

2:12.2 *then, even though they malign you as evildoers, they will by your honorable deeds, which they will have seen, give glory to God on the day of reckoning:* (This is a slight paraphrase, since the Greek syntax is hard to transfer to English.) The "day of reckoning" is a synonym for the final day, the day of judgment (see on 1:7.4).

With these words Peter, among other things, clarifies that his words (in 2:12.1) were not intended to say that the goal is a good reputation among unbelievers. A good reputation is surely

¹⁹ In the very next verse Peter will reiterate the fact that his readers are sojourners (not governors), and later in this chapter (2:18) he will appeal to servants to be submissive (not rebellious). So then, Peter's language of nationhood is not to be construed to mean that it is possible to have—and still less that Christians should pursue by political means or by military stratagems—a "Christian nation," a system in which Christian belief and behaviors can be imposed from above. Christ's Church is the truest and most eternal people, but for the time being, Church and state or two different things.

desirable (for instance, it is a requirement [1 Tim 3:7] for pastors), but some unbelievers will malign believers right up into the day of judgment. Anti-Christian “slander was the common fare of public discourse and, when brought to the attention of the authorities, became the basis for judicial persecution. Peter knows that nothing can be done to confront this rumor mill directly, for it is a spiteful slander based on the guilt of those who perpetrate it. But, like Jesus, whose words he may echo (cf. Matt. 5:16, where both the ‘good works’ and ‘give glory’ themes appear), Peter argues for a steady course of righteousness that even the pagans will have reason to approve of in the end” (Davids, 97-98). It will reflect well on God’s character if his people have visibly demonstrated God’s holiness and goodness. What kind of a God leaves absolutely no ethical imprint on his redeemed?

Two final remarks will be made here. First, “Peter did not summon believers to a verbal campaign of self-defense or to the writing of tracts in which they defend their morality. He enjoined believers to pursue virtue and goodness, so that their goodness would be apparent in all society” (Schreiner, 122; see further Jobes, 165). Second, Peter implies that—at least to a notable degree—even unbelievers are capable of evaluating honorable conduct, and that there is genuine moral sensibility to be detected even in pagan society (Jobes, 171). Paul implies the same elsewhere (e.g., 1 Cor 5:1). As wicked as the world is, believing eyes can be trained to spot traces of grace in it.

2:11-12 With these words, Peter kicks off a major new section of his epistle (with multiple subsections, as will soon become clear).²⁰ Peter will proceed from here to apply the general principles of vv11-12 to a variety of specific relationships and scenarios. Believers must fix their hope on heaven and conduct their lives in holiness, mindful of the watching eye of unbelievers—whether government officials, masters, or spouses, or others.

2:13.1 *Submit, then:* That is, “defer to,” “follow the directives and policies of”; Peter does not mean absolute subservience (cf. 2:15.1), as if the authority could demand any action whatsoever. He himself had opposed authorities at times (Ac 5:29). Still, it is not the duty of the Christian to oppose human leadership, but, so far as possible, to follow its lead.

2:13.2 *to every human [institutional] creation:* Peter uses an unexpected noun here, viz. ΚΤΙΣΙΣ, which I have translated literally (“creation”) clarifying it with a bracketed adjective (“institutional”). Arndt and Gingrich speculate that “this particular word... is meant to convey the idea that the authorities derive their power fr[om] God (457a). Or perhaps Peter, becoming more cosmopolitan as ministry becomes increasingly international, is impressed by the fact that humanity in its spread across the earth has creatively formulated diverse political institutions. The Roman empire was in theory a republic, though in practice an autocracy with oligarchic features. The diverse areas of Anatolia boasted a variety of local institutions with differing connections to the Romans. Peter’s own homeland suffered under a nauseatingly complex juridical and political structure (cf., e.g., Lk 23:7, Ac 23:33-35). The family was paradigmatically instituted by God in the earliest days of the earth (Gen 2:18ff); otherwise, the social structures people across the earth have made for themselves are in ways artificial. But Christians who happen to live in a more or less autocratic nation must, like Peter, obey their rulers, whatever their opinion of those leaders (the Roman authorities of the apostolic era were brutal, immoral, exploitative

²⁰ It is not clear to me how far the section extends. Most commentators end it at 4:11 (see esp. Schreiner, 117-118). Another potential approach is to begin the next major division at 4:7, where arguably Peter shifts from being particularly concerned with his readers’ lives as played out in the public and relational spheres to his readers’ lives as lived out in the light of the fleeting nature of life and the potential onset of persecution. Tentatively, I take 3:8.1 as signaling that 3:8-12 wraps up the section, in which case 3:13ff constitutes a major new section in the epistle (3:13ff would be a long digression in any case).

men); and Christians who happen to live in a more or less democratic nation have certain opportunities to voice their own opinions on public matters, yet are not thereby excused from obeying the commands of Scripture, including those found in the present verses.

2:13.3 *on the Lord's account:* Why must believers submit to every human institution? Peter's answer is "because of the Lord." Since "Lord" (κύριος) often refers specifically to Jesus in the NT, Peter might be referring to him or to his teaching on the matter (Mat 22:21). Many among Peter's readers likely faced temptations to oppose, rather than submit to, secular government; while others among the churches to which the apostle writes faced temptations to sideline their Christianity, living lives just like those of their pagan neighbors (on both points see Jobes, 165).

2:14.1 *whether to a king as having authority or to governors as those sent by him:* "King" here (βασιλεὺς) could also be translated "emperor"; the Greek language of the time did not make that distinction. "Governor" here (ηγεμῶν) is quite a general term, and could refer to any number of authority figures.

2:14.2 *for justice to those who do what is evil and for recognition of those who do what is right:* Peter willingly grants that unbelievers can recognize right and wrong to a significant extent. Governments—frequent claims to the contrary notwithstanding—often do at least *attempt* to curb vice and promote virtue. Also, while Christians may disagree about whom and how to punish, the apostle Peter does here indicate that punishment is an important function of civic institutions. That said, the main intent of the passage (viz., Christians' submission to government, not the formulation of policy) should be borne in mind.

2:15 *for such is the will of God, that by doing what is right you may silence the foolish words of the ignorant:* In other words, "God's desire for you is to live honorably. When you do, you will put an end to baseless accusations [against your character]; [for] when they say such things, they do not know what they are talking about."

2:16.1 *as free people:* Based on the qualification he will make shortly (2:16.2), Peter evidently does not mean political freedom—he means spiritual freedom. That is, to whatever extent his readers have earthly masters, they nevertheless have the highest status imaginable: they are priests of God, royal offspring, a blessing in the midst of a parched earth. So "the submission of the believer is never servile or rendered out of weakness" (Schreiner, 131), but with head held high.

2:16.2 *and that not using your freedom as a coverup for evil, but rather as servants of God:* Sad to say, from the earliest days people have often confused liberty in Christ with license to sin (see esp. Davids, 102). To ward off this confusion, the apostle adds that freedom should not be a banner which hides sin. No human has unqualified authority over or more importance than a believer, but God is all in all. Every action of the believer should be done as in service to the heavenly master.

2:17.1 *Honor everyone:* "Believers are to treat every person with dignity and respect since all human beings are created in God's image (Gen 1:26-27). Even sinners are to be accorded respect and honor as human beings" (Schreiner, 133).

2:17.2 *love the brotherhood:* As has been implied by Peter's language of peoplehood and of believers having God as their Father, Christians are (in a non-genetic—but nonetheless real—sense) each other's siblings.

“[L]ove for community members if a constant stress of the NT (John 13:34-35; Rom. 12:9; Eph. 1:15; Phil. 2:2; etc.). While nothing in this passage should be construed to deny the demand to love one’s neighbor, whoever he or she might be (Matt. 5:43-46; Luke 10:25-37; Rom. 13:8-9), the NT is aware that the church... is family, brothers and sisters, and therefore has a call upon the Christian’ love in a way others do not” (Davids, 103). (For more on love, see on 1:22.5, third paragraph.)

2:17.3 *fear God*: To speak of fearing the Lord in the OT “expresses the inner disposition of the devout Israelite toward the holy laws that the Lord has instructed him to keep. But this fear is essentially different from... anxious timidity... This is evident from the fact that this fear of the Lord passes into and is bound up with an assortment of other religious attitudes such as believing (Gen. 15:6; Isa. 7:9; Hab. 2:4), trust (Ps. 26:1; 37:3, 5), taking refuge in (Ps. 5:11; 37:40), leaning on (Isa. 48:2), holding on to (2 Kings 18:6), hoping, expecting, even loving God (Exod. 20:6; Deut. 6:5; Ps. 91:14)... In the New Testament we encounter essentially the same view” (Bavinck, 1:237-238). God’s holiness must deeply impress itself on the attitude and character of the believer.

2:17.4 *honor the king*: A specific subcategory of the first imperative of this verse (2:17.1). As mentioned above (on 2:13.2, second paragraph; 2:13.3), submission to the Roman emperor might have been a bitter pill for some in Asia Minor to swallow, and so Peter mentions it once more in order to be quite clear.

2:18.1 *Servants*: This term (οικετης) can refer specifically to a household slave (that is, a slave devoted to one or more of the menial tasks that keep a household running) or to any kind of slave (e.g., Montanari, 1432c). The term “master” below (δεσποτης) also has a wide range of meaning—anything from the head of a household, to a despot, to a divine being.

Among writers in the ancient world, Peter is unusual in speaking directly to enslaved people (see Davids, 105; and Jobes, 181-187), giving an agency to enslaved persons that few of his contemporaries would endorse. Christianity entails great respect for the lower rungs of the social ladder.

2:18.2 *submit*: See on 2:13.1 above.

2:18.3 *with all respect*: Or “with all fear” (εν παντι φοβω), though cf. on 2:17.3 for the idea that fear need not be terror. Commentators are divided on whether this attitude is to be directed to God (Davids, 106; Schreiner, 137) or to human masters (Grudem, 133; Jobes, 180, 189-190; Sproul, 66). Certainly, believers ought not to fear God and fear man in the same sense, yet Paul can tell wives to fear/respect their husbands (Eph 5:33) and also, without contradiction, indicate that they should *love* their husbands (Tit 2:4). It seems to me that Peter intends here to undercut the tendency of workers for sullen grumbling.

2:18.4 *kind*: More lit., “good” (αγαθος), but in English “good and” can mean “somewhat,” so I have translated with a bit more specificity in order to avoid the ambiguity.

2:18.5 *reasonable*: This rendering comes from Montanari (765a).

2:18.6 *unfair*: More lit. the Greek term (σκολιος) means “bent” or “crooked” (these two renderings come from Montanari, 1932a). “It is easier (but by no means automatic) to submit to those who are kind... but much more difficult to do so with the... evil” (Grudem, 133 [italics removed]).

2:19.1 *For this*: That is, for suffering unjustly imposed griefs because of one’s love for God.

2:19.2 *favor*: That is, *God's favor*, or possibly *God's grace* (χαρις, on which see on 1:10.2).

2:19.3 *because of one's consciousness of God[']s presence*: Some argue that the meaning is "because of one's conscience before God," but it is not clear that the Greek (δια συνειδησιν θεου) can mean this. It seems to me that what the apostle is pointing to here is the truth that some theologians have labeled *coram deo*, that is, life lived in the full awareness that God is continually aware of one's actions. In the final analysis, good deeds are not done to be a witness to unbelievers, but to be a devotee of God (though the latter entails the former to a significant extent).

2:19.4 *a person endures griefs as he or she suffers unjustly*: The Greek word for "grief" (λυπη; here plural, viz. λυπας) is a broad one, and could include not only physical injury or loss of possessions but also emotional trauma. Thus, for example, suffering verbal abuse is genuine suffering, even if no visible mark on the body remains. Indeed, Peter might well be writing with an awareness that his readers are facing just such abuse, and that it is difficult for them to bear (cf. Jobes, 152-153).

Peter "does not say that it is pleasing to God merely to endure unjust suffering and the accompanying sorrow. Rather, it is only such action endured while one is mindful of God" (Grudem, 134; italics removed), as he just intimated (2:19.4). Still less does Peter indicate that suffering in itself has any sanctifying effect (he inserts the qualifier "unjustly").²¹

2:20.1 *renown*: A good reputation, a name remembered for great and noble deeds, is something that the apostle doubtless knows his readers (as members of a Greco-Roman culture) aspire to.

2:20.2 *when you sin and suffer [as a result], you stay strong?*: There is no renown to be gained in bravely facing the consequences (a beating, a financial setback, etc.) for wrongdoing (thievery, defamation, etc.).

2:20.3 *if you do what is right and [yet] suffer*: Both by the contrast with "sin" (2:20.2) and by the fact that masters surely would not punish their servants for submitting to them, it is evident that "do[ing] what is right" here has a broader reference than simply submitting. Christian servants are to live as Christians in every respect.

2:20.4 *this is favor before God*: On "favor" (χαρις), see on 2:19.2 above. On the grammar (of παρα θεω), cf. Harris (172-173). God's assessment is the one that matters.

2:21.1 *you for were called*: "This call is to Christ and therefore has many implications bound up in him: it is God's call (1:15), it is a call to privilege and light (2:9), its purpose is blessing (3:9), and its end is eternal glory (5:10). But as Christ did not receive the crown of glory without the crown of thorns, this call also means following the example of Christ in suffering" (Daivs, 108-109).

2:21.2 *for that purpose*: That is, for the purpose of doing what is right even in the face of suffering.

2:21.3 *for Christ also suffered on our behalf*: Just as Jesus during his earthly sojourn suffered unjustly, so many of his followers suffer unjustly during their sojourn. In fact, Jesus' suffering provides the template (2:21.4) and the power (2:24.2) for his followers' righteousness during suffering.

²¹ Peter does not breathe a word about the possibility of armed revolt. One could argue that this is to avoid arousing the ire of the Roman authorities, for whom the Servile Wars were a fearful memory. But surely there is more to it: this Peter who writes saw Jesus turn the other cheek. I would contend that Christians should have a strong bias toward nonviolence and a considerable reluctance to engage in politics.

2:21.4 *leaving you a model so that you can follow in his steps*: Christ's life—and particularly his attitude during his final, great trial—gives believers a visual lesson in how they ought to respond during their own hours of trial. Imitation of Christ does not save, but the saved will imitate Christ.

2:22 *he had not sinned, nor was deceit found in his mouth*: On the grammar, cf. von Siebenthal (§289g, p545). Much of the language in this and the following verses is drawn from Isaiah chapter 53 (see esp. Jobes, 194). Probably the singling out of Jesus' lack of speech-related sin is to prepare for 2:23.1.

2:23.1 *when being insulted did not shoot back insults in reply, suffering did not threaten*: "The instinctive response of human beings when... abused is to try to get even, to hurt in return for being hurt. Or if that is impossible people will threaten to get even later, trying to give their enemies at least the anxiety that revenge may be taken sometime in the future" (Grudem, 138 [italics removed]). Not so with Jesus: cf., e.g., Mat 27:27ff., noting the lack of a verbal retort. "[I]n some situations, silence is the best response... It is, however, not the silence of passive resignation but of patient confidence" in God (Jobes, 196; see also Davids, 111-112; Schreiner, 144).

2:23.2 *but gave himself over to the one who judges justly*: That is, Jesus allowed his fate to rest entirely in the control of the Father (see e.g., Lk 23:46), trusting his promise of speedy justice (see e.g., 18:8).

2:24.1 *he bore our sins in his body upon the tree*: Crosses, such as the one Jesus was crucified on, were typically fashioned from trees. Peter might be alluding to Dt 21:23 (as Paul certainly does in Gal 3:13). In any case, Peter quite specifically (Jobes, 197) calls to mind the death of Jesus upon the cross.

In saying that Jesus carried "our sins" in "his body" on the cross, this verse points to the doctrine known as the "substitutionary atonement" or "vicarious satisfaction" of Christ (see esp. Bavinck, 3:393-398). In brief, Jesus on the cross took on himself the punishment for believers' sins, satisfying God's justice (for God would not be just if he ignored sin), displaying God's love (for God has not left humankind to its fate), and allowing humankind in its second Adam to fulfill its highest purpose (for Christ willingly and fully obeys God in everything).²²

2:24.2 *so that, our sins having been taken away, we might live to righteousness*: "Such a remarkable statement is similar to Paul's teaching in Romans 6:1-23 that at conversion Christians have died to (the dominating power of) sin... and are able to make progress in sanctification" (Grudem, 140 [italics removed]).

2:24.3 *by his wounds you are healed*: Jesus' wounds at the time of his death were, of course, extremely grievous. "The cross of our Lord was the worst injustice in all of human history, yet it pleased the Father [Isa 53:10] that He should suffer that injustice at the hands of men so that the Father's justice could be satisfied for the guilty. This side of heaven we will never comprehend the depths of that substitution" (Sproul, 68).

2:25.1 *you were wandering like sheep*: As in the last few verses, Peter is drawing on Isaiah chapter 53 (in this case, on v6). This imagery surely impacted the apostle deeply, for he—though himself a fisherman,

²² While believers can follow Christ's example in responding graciously to mistreatment, they cannot follow Christ's example in dying on the cross for the sins of others. (Some believers do die on a cross, but they cannot [Heb 7:27, etc.] repeat Christ's bearing of sins.) Peter's point here is instead that the culmination of Jesus' suffering—the work of the cross—is what makes possible the righteous life to which they are called (2:24.2).

not a shepherd—would have seen sheep many times as he grew up. Doubtless many of his readers would similarly have firsthand experience with sheep.

Using the prophet's imagery, the apostle describes his readers in the time before their conversion to Christ: "a loose group of sheep... is chaos in motion. They do not stay together. They run to and fro and trip over themselves. They go astray and lose their way. We are all like that" (Sproul, 69).

2:25.2 *but have now returned to the shepherd and caretaker of your souls:* Since the imagery used in the first part of this verse is that of aimlessly wandering sheep, it would be out of place to press the word "returned" here to imply that a Christian's relationship with God is precisely the same as (s)he had at birth (or otherwise prior to conversion). That said, there is a sense in which all humanity belongs to God, has gone off on its own, and must return to his care.

3:1.1 *Likewise:* With this conjunction (ομοίως; cf. Arndt and Gingrich, 571a; Grudem 142-143; Schreiner, 148), Peter pivots from servants (2:18-25) to wives (3:1-6) in his application of the principles of 2:11-12 to specific groups of people (2:13-17 applies, of course, to everyone); in 3:7 the apostle will again use ομοίως to pivot (to husbands). Alternatively, "likewise" indicates that the respectful attitude that servants are to have must be found in wives and husbands also (Jobes, 202), though this approach seems strained to me.

3:1.2 *submit:* Cf. on 2:13.1 above, where the same Greek word (υποτάσσω) is used.

3:1.3 *to your own husbands:* Not to men in general—though there are restrictions as regards church life (1 Cor 11:2-16, 14:34-34, 1 Tim 2:12).

3:1.4 *even:* This adverb "may indicate that the majority of the husbands [in the Anatolian churches] were believers" (Schreiner, 149), but if it is difficult to be sure: the Greek word in question (καί) is a slippery one. In fact, the meaning might be "especially." But on any account Peter is quite mindful of the fact that some believing women have unbelieving husbands: see the following comment.

3:1.5 *are disobeying the word:* Does this mean (1) unbelievers who have (so far) rejected the gospel, (2) believers who are (at the moment) walking in disregard for God's ways, or (3) whichever of the previous scenarios happens to obtain in any given marriage? Given that for Peter "the word" (here λογος, but ρημα as well) is "the gospel" (cf. 1:25 and the comments on it), that the verb "to win" later in the verse can refer to being the means of salvation for another (see Davids, 116), and that the present passage illustrates the principle of "maintaining honorable conduct among the gentiles" (2:12.1), the first option is the most probable. Peter clarifies that wives should be submissive not only if their husbands are believers, but also if they are unbelievers. (On "obedience," cf. on 1:22.1, first paragraph; and on 1:22.2.)

3:1.6 *be won:* Be saved (see the previous note).

The grammar in vv6-7 is one of intent, not promise: some men will, sad to say, never turn to Christ in faith. Women must not be made to feel ashamed at their husbands' unbelief, as if that unbelief was their fault. Nevertheless, they should continue steadfastly in righteous conduct in the hope that that conduct will be the means by which God's grace reaches their husbands.

3:1.7 *without a word:* Without their wives having to say anything. This is a play on words (no pun intended): hopefully, husbands who do not obey the "word" (viz., the gospel) will be saved without a "word" (viz., their wives' urging). Now, certainly Peter frowns on "continual nagging" (Davids, 116; cf. Pr 21:9), but it is to be noted that the contrast that the apostle is making here is between a submissive

attitude (see also the following verse) on the one hand and an intractable mindset on the other: the former Peter can imagine leading a husband to faith in Christ, but not the latter. The goal for wives of unbelieving husbands is not necessarily to be as silent as possible. That said, there is much to be said for discreet, even infrequent, verbal exhortations. The key idea is that actions speak louder than words. Even if a person literally cannot speak, their actions still will.

3:2.1 *as they observe your... conduct*: The “they” refers to the unbelieving husbands; “your conduct” refers to the conduct of the wives to whom Peter writes. In a first-century context it is nothing short of “revolutionary” (Davids, 116) that Peter directly speaks to women in this way, granting them agency.

3:2.2 *respectful*: Or, “reverent” (ἐν φόβῳ). The situation is quite parallel to that in 2:18.3, for the respect/reverence could be directed toward people (there, masters; here, husbands) or towards God. Probably the former is meant, since the hope is that wives’ conduct will win their husbands. The question does not amount to much, for reverence toward God entails respect for others (2:17.1).

3:2.3 *pure*: The Greek word (ἄγνος) means such things as “pure,” “honest,” or “innocent” in a wide variety of connections, including sexual matters (Montanari, 17a-b). Nonchristian husbands need to see that their Christian wives are honorable, and perhaps particularly to know that their wives’ commitment to their local congregation does not mean that their wives are sexually involved with others.

3:3.1 *outward*: On the outward-inward contrast, see below on 3:4.1.²³

3:3.2 *braiding of hair*: Braiding the hair could be elaborate and time-consuming—as well as somewhat provocative—in Greco-Roman culture.

3:3.3 *golden ornamentation*: Either jewelry, or the weaving bits of gold into one’s clothes or hair.

3:4.1 *but rather for the hidden person of the heart*: Christian wives should not be known for the *outside*, but for the *inside*; that is, not for their attention-getting clothing, but for God-inspired character. “[T]he wife’s inward nature... is not visible in itself, but is revealed through words and actions which reflect inner attitudes” (Grudem, 148; cf. Mat 12:34). Peter is not denying the place which Scripture elsewhere gives to fancy clothing and impressive jewelry (e.g., SS 4:4; cf. Rev 21:3), only instructing wives to make sure that “a quiet and gentle spirit” (3:4.3) is what people see, not a proud and flashy exterior.

3:4.2 *that which is imperishable*: Beauty does not last, nor do beautiful clothes (Pr 31:30); but *does* last is “a quiet and gentle spirit,” on which see the following comment.

3:4.3 *a quiet and gentle spirit*: The first term can mean such things as “calm” and “peaceful” (both glosses come from Montanari, 920b). The second term refers in a social context to “an amiable friendliness that contrasted with roughness, bad temper, or brusqueness” (Davids, 119). The intersection between these two terms is probably the idea of being deferential and noncombative: the apostle will go on in the following verse to describe the submissive attitude of the matriarchs as exemplifying the kind of behavior he is calling wives to. Also, the OG version of Isaiah (which Peter has made ample use of in this epistle) uses similar language (in 66:2) to describe a submissive attitude toward God and toward God’s will. So, rather than undermining or grumbling about their husbands’ ideas with respect to

²³ The grammar of this verse is rather complex (cf. esp. von Siebenthal §289g, p545), so I have paraphrased somewhat in my translation. On the rendering “fancy dresses,” cf. Montanari (1167a).

finances, property, employment, etc., wives should respectfully follow their husband's lead.

3:4.4 *which is of immense value in the sight of God*: The world tends to assign value to that which boasts great achievements, or provokes widespread envy; God assigns value to that which quietly encourages.

3:5.1 *For*: Peter is about to give a rationale for why wives should make themselves known for their submissive character.

3:5.2 *in such a fashion*: That is, by choosing a submissive attitude over ostentatious display. (The wordplay involving "fashion" is not present in the Greek, but I feel it is within the spirit of Peter's words.)

3:5.3 *in ancient times the holy women who hoped in God*: As will become clear in the following verse, Peter is referring to the matriarchs of Genesis. (I have translated ΠΟΤΕ a bit loosely, which could be more literally translated "formerly," "in the past.")

By "holy" here Peter might mean (1) "exhibiting good moral character," (2) "devoted wholly to God," or (3) "made unique use of by God" (cf. on 1:16.2). If the first option is what he means, Peter surely does *not* mean "free from all sin" (Pr 20:9). His intent instead would be to speak well of their character *on the whole*. If the second option is what he has in mind, he evidently aims to point out how these women followed the one true God in an age when almost everyone else ran after a multitude of idols. If the third option reflects Peter's train of thought, the idea is not that the matriarchs were somehow passive objects (he immediately ascribes to them the action of having "hoped in God"), but that they had the honor of being God's chosen means through whom the promised descendants of Abraham and the savior of the world came. Most likely, either the first or the second option is what principally occupies Peter's thoughts, for, as just noted, he goes on further to define these women as people who "hoped in God": they did not stake present or future well-being on earthly possessions, on houses, family, or fame; rather, they based their conduct on the belief that theirs was a city designed and built by God himself (Heb 11:10). The "living hope" (1:3.4) to which the Anatolian believers have been raised was long ago anticipated by the matriarchs. The book of Genesis records some serious failures, to be sure, yet the apostle is correct to sum up their lives with a very positive assessment.

3:5.4 *dressed themselves, submitting to their own husbands*: That is, the matriarchs focused not on their outward appearance—even though at least some of them were beautiful by the standard of the day (e.g., Gen 12:11)—but on the cultivation of a "quiet and gentle spirit" under their husband's leadership. In the following verse, Peter will supply a concrete example.

3:6.1 *for example, Sarah submitted to Abraham, calling him "lord"*: Sarah, the first of the matriarchs, referred to her husband—even when he was not present, and even when she was indulging in cynicism with regard to the prophecy of Isaac's birth—as "lord" in Gen 18:12 (in Hebrew, אֲדֹנָי; in Greek, κυριος). In doing so, she modeled respect and submission.

3:6.2 *you have become Sarah's as you do what is right and are afraid of nothing*: In Greek, Peter's wording is ambiguous. It could also mean (1) that the Anatolian wives become Sarah's children *if* they boldly do what is right, (2) that have they become Sarah's purpose *for the purpose of* boldly doing what is right, or (3) that are they Sarah's children who can be further described as those who boldly do what is right? The translation given above would need to be adjusted somewhat ("if you do" or "so that you might do") if a different approach than mine was taken. For a survey of scholarly opinion, see Schreiner (157-158). Most commentators seem to assume some variation of the first option, but the third option seems best to me. It is striking that Peter could have been more clear, but seems to have been

untroubled by the ambiguity (cf. von Siebenthal §231c p391). Peter does not seem to be laying any particular stress on any conditional element of this statement; he is not wagging his finger, saying that if—and *only* if—his readers follow his instructions can they claim Sarah as their mother. Rather, the apostle, as often (1:12.3, 1:23.1, 2:10, 2:25.2), rounds out a section with an encouraging affirmation of his readers' elect status.

The status that the apostle points to is his reader's new descent from Sarah. While Peter's words could be taken simply to mean that his readers can be *like* Sarah, in the context of what he has said already in this epistle (particularly in 2:10), it seems likely that he wants to be taken literally: even if his readers are gentiles by blood, they are as much a part of God's one flock as Abraham and Sarah.

In this context, doing "what is right" surely includes submitting to husbands, but, as in 2:20.3, the meaning is likely quite broad. Christian women are to live out a fully God-centered ethic.

A more literal translation of "afraid of nothing" (μη φοβουμεναι μηδεμιαν) would be "not fearing any fear," but this a common Hebrew construction, frequently brought into the Greek language—so much so that it occurs in the OG version of Pr 3:25, which Peter is evidently quoting, even though the Hebrew original there is different (אל תירא מפחד פתאם). The apostle might be attempting to forestall fear of potential abusive responses by unbelieving husbands. But "even Greco-Roman statutes did not sanction spousal abuse" (Jobes, 206). If Peter did anticipate domestic abuse, he probably would have advised battered wives to seek safety (cf. Mat 10:23), and surely would not have taken time to warn about excessively fancy clothing (3:3.3-5). On the other hand, depending on how Col 3:19 is translated, Paul can envision even a Christian husband speaking harshly, so to some extent many wives surely would have things to be concerned about from their unsaved husbands. Still, giving the pairing of item with "do[ing] what is right" and the context of Pr 3:25 (the benefits of a life of wisdom, as opposed to reacting to the fears that motivate the ungodly), Peter's main concern here seems to be that the Anatolian women, like the matriarchs, hope in God rather than fear the passing troubles of this world (cf. Mat 13:21).

3:7.1 *Husbands likewise:* Peter now pivots to husbands and what it looks like for them to live honorably among the gentiles (2:11-12). (On the conjunction, cf. on 3:6.1 above.)

3:7.2 *live:* Or, "dwell" (συνοικουετε; on the grammar, cf. von Siebenthal §231k p397): the Greek verb speaks to the home life of husbands.

3:7.3 *knowledgeably:* Lit., "according to knowledge" (κατα γνωσιν). I am unaware of any exact parallel to this usage in ancient Greek literature, but "knowledgeably, informedly" would seem to be the general meaning. Schreiner (159-160) thinks that the knowledge is knowledge of God, so that κατα γνωσιν might be paraphrased "in a manner consistent with reverence for God," but it seems much more natural in this context to understand the knowledge to be knowledge of the wife. This knowledge "may include any knowledge that would be beneficial to the husband-wife relationship: knowledge of God's purposes and principles for marriage, knowledge of the wife's desires, goals, and frustrations; knowledge of her strengths and weaknesses in the physical, emotional and spiritual realms; etc... such knowledge can only be gained through regular study of God's Word and regular, unhurried times of private fellowship together as husband and wife" (Grudem, 151).

3:7.4 *weaker vessel:* As already implied (3:7.2), Peter is referring here to the wives of the husbands among his readers. Given the immediate (3:1-6; see esp. on 3:1.5) and broader (2:11-12) context, I maintain that he is also addressing situations where a believing husband has an unbelieving wife (so also Jobes 208-209; and cf. 1 Cor 7:16b), though believing husbands of believing wives would do well to listen in (cf., in a different context, Davids [115-116]).

Peter characterizes wives as “weaker.” “The most obvious meaning... is that women are weaker in terms of sheer strength” (Schreiner, 160), of muscle mass. Peter “affirms a theme found frequently in the New Testament, namely, that God is often pleased to give honour to those who are weaker or less honoured in the eyes of the world (cf. Matt. 5:3-12; 1 Cor. 1:26-30; [12:21ff;] Jas 2:5; 4:6; 1 Pet. 5:5)” (Grudem, 151); see further on 3:7.5 below. Also, women are in a fallen society “more vulnerable” (Davids, 123).

Concerning “vessel,” see on 3:7.6 below.

3:7.5 assigning honor: “Honor” is not a term of chauvinism, but of respect: honor assigns value to a person, even (or especially) if that person’s value is not in some superficial advantage, such as vast wealth or great strength. All other things being equal, women do not equal the strength of men in such things as digging mining shafts or defeating foreign invasions, but they are not for that reason to be thought of as less valuable than men.

3:7.6 to the female [vessel]: The best translation and intended significance of this term (τῷ γυναικείῳ) are a bit difficult to ascertain. While in Greek it is not unusual to leave a noun to be inferred from the context, this particular Greek expression is, as far as I am aware, an unusual way to refer straightforwardly to wives. Normally, the expression refers to characteristic traits or possessions of women. Sometimes it refers, more or less discreetly, to the female genitalia, in which case the phrase might be rendered, “to the female private parts.” If that is Peter’s meaning, the idea is evidently that husbands must not abuse their strength in sexual matters—viz., forcing their wives to engage in sexual acts things against their will, being rough with their wives in the bedroom, etc. Possibly reinforcing that last possibility is the fact that the metaphor of “vessel” (σκευός) is occasionally used as a euphemism for “genitalia” (male or female, as the context requires).²⁴ On the other hand, “vessel” can have a number of other metaphorical uses, among them “the person as a creature” (Davids, 122). To my mind, a nod to the shared mortality of men and women—that women are a weaker vessel implies that men are also a vessel—makes good sense, especially in light of the fact that the apostle will speak of the “grace of life” (3:7.7). Certainly, husbands must be considerate of and acknowledge the agency of their wives in the bedroom, but I suspect that that imperative is more an implication of the apostle’s words than their primary focus. Rather, I think that the meaning of τῷ γυναικείῳ here is either “to the female [vessel],” “to those of the female gender,” giving emphasis to the Anatolian wives as females (since the gender distinction is uppermost in Peter’s mind); or “to the things of women,” “to your wives and their interests and concerns,” such that the Anatolian husbands are warned not to be dismissive of the ways in which their wives are different from them. Either way, the diversity of the two genders is to be celebrated, and men in particular are to give thought as to how to nourish and cherish their wives (Eph 5:29).

3:7.7 as indeed coheirs of the grace of life: That is, both husbands *and* their wives inherit the grace of life, and this fact should inspire husbands to treat their wives respectfully.

But what is this “grace of life”? Some (e.g., Davids, 123; Grudem, 153; Schreiner, 161) take it to mean salvation, but it seems more straightforward to take it as meaning life itself. As already noted (on 3:5.4), the wives referred to in this verse are probably not all assumed to be unsaved at the time of writing; nevertheless, “[t]he Holy Spirit is the author of all life, power, and virtue, also among the Gentiles” (Bavinck, 3:218). Every human is made in God’s image (Gen 9:6), and everyone deserves honor (2:17.1). If God has preserved a man’s life from conception through birth and into adulthood, he has done the same for that man’s wife.

²⁴ For instance, (self-control over) male sexuality is probably the meaning in 1 Thes 4:4 (see Weima, 267-272).

3:7.8 *so that your prayers will not be impeded*: Peter “probably alludes here to the thought, common in ancient society, that the prayers of the male head of household to the gods are important for the prosperity and well-being of the household and therefore contribute to the well-being of the city” (Jobes, 209). Christians, of course, must pray only to God, and they do not mechanically or exclusively seek material blessings. Nevertheless, the idea that men should take a particular interest in prayer is certainly one that the Christian Scriptures endorse (1 Tim 2:8), and Peter assumes that his male readers are praying regularly. These men must understand, however, that God listens to a pure heart (Ps 66:18), not to outward religiosity that masks oppressive behavior (Isa 1:12-15).

3:8.1 *Finally*: Though there is some uncertainty as to the meaning of the Greek here, this translation seems plausible, and has been widely adopted by translators and commentators. Peter signals that he is wrapping up the section begun in 2:11-12. Or perhaps this is a way of summarizing what has recently been said (cf. Schreiner, 162).

3:8.2 *harmonious*: Or, “of the same feelings or thoughts” (both renderings from Montanari, 1461c).

3:8.3 *sympathetic*: This English word mirrors the etymology of the Greek word (συμπαθης), but probably does not in itself point to the same depth of feeling. The sympathy Peter is calling for, in other words, is not mild and distant, but deep and involved.

3:8.3 *fraternal*: That is, showing love toward one’s siblings. Assuredly Peter does not mean *only*, or even primarily, one’s physical brother(s) and/or sister(s). I have translated fairly literally, but a word of explanation is needed: the English word “fraternal” can have cultish or Orwellian overtones, but that is not the case for the Greek term (φιλαδελφοι).

3:8.4 *compassionate*: An emotionally-involved desire to help others in need.

3:8.5 *friendly*: Or “courteous” (φιλοφρονες; both renderings from Montanari, 2290c).

3:8.6 *harmonious, sympathetic, fraternal, compassionate, friendly*: Peter works to embed these important truths in the minds of his readers: he omits a verb (as the Greek language, unlike English, allows in a case like this); instead of using elaborate phrases, he uses five adjectives arranged in a rhythmic pattern and heavily favoring the letter Greek *Phi* (five times across five words); and he omits a conjunction before the final element, maintaining the pace. Rhetoric for its own sake or in the absence of substantive arguments is an evil, but a well-spoken word in the service of truth is a good (cf. Ps 45:1).

To whom are the Anatolian believers to direct these attitudes—toward believers only (or at least principally), or to everyone? Most commentators assume the former (e.g., Jobes, 215), and the call to “fraternal” (3:8.4) behavior could indicate a Christian orientation (so Schreiner, 163). On the other hand, Peter is still chasing the threads he began to pull on in 2:11-12, where “honorable conduct among the gentiles” is enjoined. The term “fraternal” (φιλαδελφος) need not be particularly literal (see, e.g., Xenophon, Memorabilia 2.3.17, a passage cited in Montanari, 2276a); the apostle might, in other words, be calling on the Christians of Asia Minor to treat everyone as reasonably as one would treat a brother or sister—people who, in most cases, are treated with sympathy, respect, and camaraderie. Clearly Christians cannot be as compatible in their feelings, thoughts, and teamwork with unbelievers as with believers; indeed, in 2:11-12 Peter predicts that the typical response of gentiles to Christians is to “malign” them. But Christians are to be magnanimous to all (Mat 5:43ff).

3:9.1 *not repaying wrong for wrong or insult for insult, but on the contrary saying a blessing*: The

instinctive response to a hurtful action or word is to respond with something hurtful, but Christians, like Christ (2:23.1), do not do this. Instead, they speak good words over their attackers (cf. Lk 23:34).

3:9.2 *knowing that you were called for this [purpose], so that you might inherit a blessing:* At the risk of overpressing a word, “inherit” seems to me to imply an orientation toward the final day, the day when Christ will reward his faithful. Such an idea would fit well with the pilgrimage theme of 2:11.3 and the even earlier references to the future day (e.g., 1:7.4).

3:10.1 *For:* Peter defends the statement he has just made (3:9.2) with a long citation of Scripture. In the rest of v10 and in the following two verses, he lightly paraphrases OG-Ps 33:13-17 (a literal translation of Ps 34:13-17), minus the last part of v17 (since Peter’s present emphasis is not on the fate of the wicked, and his Bible manuscripts did not have verse divisions anyway).

3:10.2 *“The one who desires to love life and to see good days:* To say it differently, “the one who[, reasonably enough,] wishes to avoid unnecessary pain and disappointment in life.”

Neither David (the author of Ps 34) nor Peter (the writer of this epistle) experienced anything resembling a trouble-free life, including in those times when they earnestly sought to please the Lord. These words, then, are not meant to promise prosperity in any merely material sense.

3:10.3 *let that one stop his tongue from wrong and his lips from speaking deceit:* As will soon become clear (see 3:11.1), the charge to do what is right is quite general, in no way limited to communication. However, the Scriptures often show a particular concern for using one’s mouth as an instrument of truth (e.g., Zeph 3:13, Eph 4:25, Jm 3:1ff).

3:11.1 *Let him incline away from wrong and toward good:* That is, the one who desires to love life and to see good days must choose to what is right instead of what is wrong, even in the face of wrongdoing at the hands of others.

3:11.2 *Let him seek peace and pursue it:* David modeled this, for, frequent murderous assaults against himself notwithstanding, he sought peace whenever possible, and was eager to spare life. Christian should stand for peace, even when others stand for war (Ps 120:7). There might be a playful touch: “pursuit” is something a warrior would do to a fleeing enemy, yet what the Christian so ardently chases after is peace (cf. Sproul, 92).

3:12.1 *For the eyes of the Lord are on the righteous, and his ears on their appeal:* That is to say, God’s attention is continually fixed on the righteous of the earth, and he will not ignore their troubles. (For a discussion of God’s omnipresence, see Bavinck, 2:164-170.)

3:12.2 *but the face of the Lord is against those who do wrong:* Whereas God smiles at the righteous, he frowns at the wicked. God cannot and does not approve of wickedness.

3:13 *And who is there to wrong you if you are imitators of what is good?:* In both the OT and the NT, questions are often used for reasons other than the seeking of unknown information. Here the tone is a bit playful: how many people, Peter asks, make it their life’s aim to hurt people who are polite, to shout at people who tip generously, or to punch people who inform their neighbor that a package has been delivered to that neighbor’s doorstep? Not many. Of course, the apostle knows full well that bad things are sometimes done to decent people (Christians in particular), as he will go on to discuss in the following verses. Yet the point stands: in general, if people practice the principles pointed out in vv8-12,

life will be smoother and easier than if people make a point to be grumpy or deceitful.

The language of imitation occurs a number of times in Scripture (e.g., 1 Cor 4:16, Eph 5:1). Human beings look at—and to some extent even hear or read of—other people, and in doing so they learn patterns of behavior from them. By whatever means the Anatolians learn what is good, such things can, should, and will be internalized.

3:14.1 *But if you do actually suffer for the sake of righteousness, “Blessed!”*: More fully expressed, “In the [somewhat unlikely but not impossible] event that you are mistreated [precisely] because you do what is right, [you are] blessed [by God].” In the terms that Peter actually uses, the single-word conclusion, “blessed” (μακάριοι), is notable—even granting that pronouns and state of being verbs are not as obligatory in Greek usage as they are in English. The abruptness of the term probably stems from the fact that Peter is thinking of a particular snatch of Jesus’ teachings, viz. Mat 5:1ff, and particularly v11, where the word “blessed” (μακάριοι) echoes again and again. Scholars debate whether Peter had access to the biblical book now traditionally called “Matthew,” or whether that book did not circulate until later; but there can be no doubt that the sermon recorded in Matthew chapter five rang in Peter’s ears all his days, and that at least summaries of that message were widely known in the early church. In sum, Peter appears to be using a kind of shorthand to connect Jesus’ words concerning righteous suffering with his readers in Asia Minor: to the extent that they are persecuted for Christian actions, Christ’s blessing rests on them.

3:14.2 *And*: The particle *ὅτε*, though frequently approximating the English “but,” at times approaches more nearly to “and” (so also, e.g., von Siebenthal 422 §251a).

3:14.3 *do not fear what they fear, nor become hyperactive*: The Greek behind the first clause (τον φόβον αὐτῶν μὴ φοβηθῆτε) is ambiguous. It could be rendered as above, or as “do not fear them.” Jobes (228-230) is quite helpful here, even though I tentatively disagree with her conclusion. She observes that Peter is drawing on Isa 8:12f. “Isaiah’s compatriots in Jerusalem and Judah... are overwhelmed by their fear of Aram and Israel. The Lord spoke to Isaiah, warning him not to cave in to the same fears” (229). But, contends Jobes, Peter “contextualizes it [viz., the quotation] for a completely different situation” (ib.), changing the singular of the OG (αὐτοῦ) to a plural (αὐτῶν). But granting that the situation in ancient Judah was quite different from that of first-century Anatolia, the change in grammatical number just mentioned does not necessarily indicate that Peter aims to adjust the meaning of the clause he has quoted. For one thing, Peter’s quotation is apparently inexact (assuming that the OG is accurately preserved for us), as Peter substitutes *μὴ* for *οὐ μὴ* and *μὴδὲ* for *οὐδὲ μὴ*. For another thing, Peter vacillates between the singular and the plural throughout this paragraph. More significantly, Peter will go on to urge his readers to be ready to explain their “hope” (3:15.6), not their courage.

So while the meaning *could* be “do not fear your detractors or attackers,” the meaning is probably rather “do not be driven to anxious, fretful activity by the things that disturb the unbelievers who oppose you.” What things? Peter does not say; evidently, the answer is anything that looms larger in the mind than God and his concerns (cf. 3:15.2 below)—anything from worries about the political scene (as Isaiah alluded to in chapter 8) to concerns about personal finances (as Jesus pointed out in Mat 6:25ff).

For “hyperactive,” other possible glosses include “upset,” “agitated,” “in a state of disorder” (cf. Montanari, 2085b-c). Panicked hyperactivity sometimes describes the behavior of unbelievers, but it should never be a label for Christians.

3:15.1 *but sanctify the Lord God in your hearts*: As some commentators point out (Davids, 131; Schreiner, 173), “sanctify” is the same Greek verb (αγιαζω) used in Mat 6:9; and in both passages, a distinction is

implicitly drawn between holiness as an attribute which God always has (cf. on 1:16.2) and as an honor which men and women are right to acknowledge as being his. If God is recognized as transcendent in significance, magnificent in glory, and innocent of wrongdoing, then lesser things will fade from view. Also by implication, if believers sanctify God, they will love what he loves, and hate what he hates. But the emphasis here is on the fact that if God is seen to be the great king, nothing else is found to be a grave concern.

“We should not understand the heart [here] as our inner and private lives, which are inaccessible to others. The heart is [instead] the origin of human behavior (cf. 1:22; 3:4), and from it flows everything people do... what happens within will inevitably be displayed to all, especially when one suffers (Schreiner, 173-174).

3:15.2 *and always be ready*: Although this passage is the basis for modern apologetics²⁵—viz., the (semi-)formal practice, particularly in an academic or public context, of promoting Christianity as intellectually credible—Peter’s concern here is more general, referring as much to casual conversation between friends as to structured argumentation in a formal setting; queries from unbelievers might occur during a lunch break at work, before the judge at court, or anywhere in between.

3:15.3 *justification*: I take the rendering from Montanari (258c, citing this verse); another way to render it is “defense.” For anyone to respond to adversity with joy is on the face of it absurd. Accordingly, Christians need to be prepared to explain themselves: their joy is not because they enjoy pain or disgrace (no one does), but because they expect a bright future (3:15.5).

3:15.4 *to everyone who asks you*: Many unbelievers will simply ignore or scorn Christians, but there will be those who approach Christians with genuine questions about the source of their confidence.

3:15.5 *for the reason for the hope within you*: “[W]e are to be ready to give... not a feeling, but a reason” (Sproul, 101); “believers have solid intellectual grounds for believing the gospel” (Schreiner, 174-175). Otherwise, God would have given people brains for no reason. No Christian knows everything, but every Christian should be able to recognize clear and compelling evidence of God’s care for them.

When Peter refers to “the hope within you,” he seems to be thinking particularly of the hope of resurrection that comes from Jesus’ own resurrection (cf. 1:3.4, 1:13.3, 1:21.3, 5; 3:5.4 might be more general, but cf. the patriarch Abraham’s faith in God’s resurrecting power mentioned in Heb 11:17-19). It is certainly no coincidence that the NT emphasizes the historicity of the resurrection (e.g., Mat 28:11-15, 1 Cor 15:3-11).²⁶ Christ’s resurrection is the basis for justifiable confidence: God has raised Christ, and he will raise those who are in Christ.

3:16.1 *with humility and respect*: The Anatolian believers are to give an answer to those who question then, “But it is not enough simply to give an answer; how they give an answer and the life behind the answer are far more eloquent than the words they speak” (Davids, 132). “When we engage in debates and arguments, we sometimes allow ourselves to be overcome with the heat of the moment and generate more heat than light” (Sproul, 106).

As previously in this epistle (cf. 2:18.3, 3:3.2), there is an ambiguity in the Greek as to whether

²⁵ This verse is the foundation of modern apologetics in two senses: (1) the verse obviously speaks of giving an answer to those who question Christians; and (2) the word “justification” (3:15.4) in Greek is *απολογία*, from which the English word “apologetics” is derived.

²⁶ For an accessible introduction to the historicity of the resurrection, see Strobel, Lee, *The Case for Easter: A Journalist Investigates Evidence for the Resurrection*, Zondervan, Grand Rapids, MI, 2003.

φοβος means something closer to “fear” or something closer to “respect.” If the former, then the context demands that the fear is of God, not people. But it seems more natural to take it in the latter sense (hence my translation above), and to understand it with reference to people who are asking questions. That said, to fear God implies respect for people made in his image; and respect for image-bearers derives from fear of him whose image is stamped on them.

3:16.2 *maintaining a good conscience, in order that in the matter in which they defame you as wrongdoers they who threaten your good conduct in Christ might be put to shame:* The expectation is that unbelievers will regularly claim that believers are acting wickedly (cf. Mat 6:11-12). The ideal is that these claims will be exploded by Christ’s examination of them on the day of judgment (cf. 1:17.3). Compromising one’s conscience in the name of Christ works at cross-purposes with the work of the cross (Tit 2:14).

3:17.1 *After all, it is better as doers of good... for you to suffer or be wronged:* Peter prefers undeserved to deserved suffering.

3:17.2 *if God should happen so to will it:* Peter carefully implies (by using the optative mood of *θελοι*) that while suffering for doing the right thing is certainly possible, it is not what Christians should expect from God. True, all people who desire to live godly lives will suffer persecution (2 Tim 3:12), but on the whole, by and large, it is kindness, even abundance, that God dispenses (Ps 145:9, Mat 5:45, etc.).

3:18-22 It should be admitted at the outset that this paragraph presents numerous difficulties at the levels of text, translation, and meaning.²⁷ Interpreters should venture their reasoned opinions with humility, and should listen to others’ attempts with patience. Also, no number of thorny exegetical quandaries should choke out amazement at Jesus Christ, who has died, risen, and ascended in glory.

3:18.1 *For Christ [himself] also suffered once [for all] for sins:* The idea of suffering, even though in the context of doing what is right, is reasonable (“For”). Specifically, the author and finisher of our faith, Jesus the messiah, did just this.

Peter is speaking above all of the work of Christ on the cross (as 3:18.3 will make clear; cf. also 2:24, where the larger train of thought is similar to that of these verses), so he could easily have said “died.” Yet Jesus’ murder involved a great deal of persecution and suffering, and it is that persecution and suffering that links his experience to that of his followers; hence Peter’s choice of the word “suffered.”

That Christ’s work on the cross happened just once for all time is an idea that is developed elsewhere in scripture, particularly in Hebrews (see especially 9:11ff); Peter mentions it only briefly here. That he does so at all is a bit surprising. Possibly he intends to forestall identifying too closely the many and various times at Christians suffer and the one and definitive time that Christ suffered on the cross; it is not as though Christian trials, if repeated, thereby accumulate merit. But it is far from clear that Peter is presently thinking along these lines. The apostle has shown great interest in the fact that Jesus, though separated from the Anatolians to various extents by time, geography, and ethnicity, won for the believers

²⁷ Indeed, this pericope is readily classed among the most exegetically difficult passages in the NT. Jobes does make a good case that it would have been less difficult for its first readers, given their greater familiarity with the theological and literary background of Peter’s words. Still, one can sympathize with Sproul when he says, “This is a text about which I am open to correction and reproof, and I will be quick to ask the Apostle when I see him in glory what he meant by these very enigmatic words” (111).

of Asia Minor full inclusion in his redeemed people (1:8, 2:20, 2:10, 2:24-25, 3:6). So it may well be that “once [for all]” here is meant to reassure Peter’s readers—especially those young in age—that although Jesus died on the cross long ago, Christ’s finished work still covers them and their sins. God is the king of the ages (Jer 10:10, 1 Tim 1:17) and king of the nations (Jer 10:7, Rev 15:3); there is no epoch or people that escapes his benevolent notice—the whole world is the object of his love (Jn 3:16).

3:18.2 *the righteous for the unrighteous, that he might bring you to God:* Christ, who lived rightly, suffered (3:18.1) on behalf of sinners, who have not lived rightly; and by bearing the penalty of our sins, he removes the unholiness that separates us from God’s approval—“bring” (προσάγω) signifies the favorable introduction of someone (here, believers) to an authority figure (God the Father). The apostle is, in other words, encapsulating the gospel in a handful of words.

3:18.3 *having been put to death on the one hand in the flesh, yet raised to life on the other hand by the Spirit:* Peter prioritizes stylistic impact over semantic clarity. He uses six Greek words (θανάτωθεις μὲν σαρκὶ ζωοποιήθεις δὲ πνεύματι), of which four form rhyming, opposite pairs (θανάτωθεις with ζωοποιήθεις; and σαρκὶ with πνεύματι) and two grammatically correlate (μὲν with δὲ). It is language as striking as it is concise. But it is not easy to understand the meaning, still less to translate it accurately and clearly into English. Most of the difficulty stems from σαρκὶ and πνεύματι, and from the relationship between these two terms in this verse. (The difficulty will be compounded when v19 arrives.)

As for σαρκὶ (the dative form of σὰρξ, “flesh”), Montanari (1899a) offers quite a few glosses, of which the more relevant are these: “flesh,” “body, limbs,” “carnal or corporeal nature,” “human, earthly condition, natural order,” and “living being, human.” Note also that the English definite article (“the”) can legitimately either be supplied or denied when rendered this term, depending on how one understands the Greek and chooses to render that meaning in English.

And not only does this lexeme (σὰρξ) have a wide range of meaning, but so does the case (dative). von Siebenthal (§§174-182, pp253-261) lists numerous possibilities, though most are highly improbable or outright impossible in this grammatical and semantic context. The main possibilities to keep in mind here are these: it could refer (1) to the sphere, realm, or respect in which the action takes place; (2) to the circumstances, manner, or time of the action; or (3) to the agent of the action or the means by which the action is accomplished.

The word πνεύματι is also in the dative case; its dictionary form is πνεῦμα. It can refer physically to “wind” or a “breath,” but such senses are clearly out of place here. Rather, the idea is (1) “that part of a human being that partakes of the spiritual realm,” (2) “the inner disposition and emotional/spiritual life,” (3) “spiritual being, angel, demon,” or (4) “the Spirit,” that is, “God the Holy Spirit.”²⁸ The third heading just mentioned requires further comment. It is unclear whether in the Greek of this period could in itself refer to deceased humans as such. Heb 12:23 might be an example of this word being used to refer to humans, but this verse is difficult in its details, and generally straightforward passages, not difficult ones, should be used to shed light on obscure ones.

These puzzle pieces can be put together in a number of ways.

(1) One possible construction would be “put to death with reference to his body, but raised to life with reference to his spirit,” that is, Christ was killed bodily, but came to life spiritually. But Peter, who saw the resurrected Christ for himself (e.g., Lk 24:36-43) and constantly referred to thereafter (Ac 1:22, 2:31ff, 3:15, etc.) would be the last one (except, perhaps, for Thomas!) to imply that Jesus’ resurrection was *merely* spiritual, not involving his flesh. “Peter is not contrasting two parts of the nature of Christ,

²⁸ Here it should be recalled that in ancient times the Greek script made no distinction between upper or lower case letters, so we cannot appeal to the *pi* to settle the question of whether a thing or a person is meant.

body and soul” (Davids, 137; cf also Jobes, 239).

(2) Another: “put to death with respect to the flesh, but... made alive with respect to the spirit” (Davids, 136), that is, Christ’s death affected “the natural human condition, [that is,] the flesh,” while his resurrection occurred “with respect to God and relationship with him, the spirit” (Davids, 136-137; cf. Grudem, 163-164; Jobes, 241-242). Expanding further: Christ’s death destroyed the basis of the reign of sin and inaugurated the “resurrected... mode of existence in which Christians, even before [their own] resurrection, can participate... although their complete participation awaits ‘the redemption of the body’” (Davids, 137, citing Rom 8:23). This seems like a lot to read in these terms, but as mentioned above, Peter’s language here is clearly meant to be concise. Furthermore, Peter’s train of thought in 4:1-6 seems to be similar.

(3) Quite similarly, “having been put to death with reference to flesh, but raised to life with reference to the Spirit,” that is, Christ’s death affected “the natural human condition,” and his new life introducing to the world Holy Spirit-empowered ways of life. Again, this reads a lot into a few words, but perhaps not impossibly so. It potentially also paves the way for seeing a reference to the Holy Spirit in the following verse, a topic I will take up later. On the other hand, it is not as though Jesus’ close association *began* at the resurrection (Mat 3:16), nor did the resurrection prove the moment that the Spirit would rush on Jesus’ disciples (Ac 1:4ff).

(4) Differently: “having been put to death on the one hand by flesh, yet raised to life on the other hand by the Spirit,” this is, Christ was put to death by men, but raised to life by the Spirit. Schreiner (184) does not think it is likely “that the singular ‘flesh’... refers to human beings,” but 1:24.2 arguably undercuts this objection.

(5) A variation on the preceding: “having been put to death in the flesh, but raised by the Spirit,” that is, Christ was bodily killed, but raised to life again by the Holy Spirit (so Schreiner, 184; Sproul, 106-108). In constructions like this one where two or more parallel nouns are in the same grammatical case, it is often queried whether the case usage must be the same in each instance. Schreiner (184) denies that it is necessary to interpret them in the same way, and I would agree, especially in such epigrammatic passages as this one. On the other hand, the sense might after all be the same.

All these constructions except for the first are plausible, but I think that the fifth one is the best. To say that Christ died “in the flesh” prepares the way for the idea that Christ suffered in his mortal body prepares the way for the thoughts of 4:1ff; and to say that the Spirit raised him from the dead prepares for 3:19ff. Yet there are elements of truth in the other views; perhaps insisting on a wide separation between constructions 2-5 is splitting theological hairs and missing the genius of Peter’s language.

3:19.1 *in whom*: The Greek here (ἐν ᾧ) could also be translated “in which.” I have argued above (on 3:18.3) that the Holy Spirit as a person is on Peter’s mind, but if it is the Spirit’s activity or sphere of activity that the apostle is thinking of, then “in which” is preferable as a translation.

3:19.2 *he proclaimed [victory]*: I have attempted with this translation (inadequately, to be sure) to capture an ambiguity in the Greek: ἐκηρυξεν refers to Christ having made a ringing announcement, but that announcement could be anything from the reassurance of the gospel message to the thunderclap of a victory declaration. So what did Jesus proclaim, and was the proclamation met with dancing or with dread? The answer is surely meant to lie in the words “to the spirit in prison,” to which I turn next.

3:19.3 *to the spirits in prison*: The identity of these spirits is much debated. Without going into detail, there are two basic approaches that are plausible.²⁹

²⁹ An implausible approach: these spirits are some or all of those men and women who have died in unbelief, and Christ offered (or offers) these spirits a second chance after their death to believe in him. This approach is

(1) One approach is to see them as the spirits of deceased humans—that is, as the souls of certain people who, though once alive, are now (as of the time that Peter writes, or rather much earlier) dead. More specifically,³⁰ these spirits are those people who in the days of Noah rejected the chance (2 Pet 2:5) to enter the ark to escape the impending floodwaters (3:20.1). Noah's preaching was at the Spirit of Christ's prompting. For their disobedience to the call of salvation, these men and women ended up (with their bodies dead, and their souls) in a kind of prison, awaiting the final day of judgment (cf. Gen 7:21, Rev 20:13). Bavinck (3:411-416), Grudem (163-169, 211-248), and Sproul (106-111) take this approach (or something close to it).

(2) Another approach is to see them as (then and always) purely spiritual beings, viz., demonic beings whose sin consisted in somehow transgressing the boundaries God had made between them and humans (Gen 6:1ff). Because of that sin, they were placed in (some sort of metaphysical) prison (cf. 2 Pet 2:4; and perhaps Rev 9:1ff). Davids (134-143), Jobes (235-251), and Schreiner (180-190) take this approach (or something close to it).

Both approaches have seeming strengths and weaknesses. For instance, the first approach arguably fits better with (3:20.1) the idea of God "waiting" (why would he wait for the demons?). Yet as mentioned above (on 3:18.3, fourth paragraph), it is unclear whether the Greek word for "spirit" here (πνεῦμα) can refer to a human; and in a passage which speaks of Christ's decisive, epochal actions ("once," 3:18.1; "angels and authorities and powers have submitted to him" (3:22.2), it seems strange to highlight the fact that *few* people believed the good news that the Spirit of Christ placed on the lips of Noah. As to the second approach, it seemingly reads the Greek more straightforwardly (I refer once again to "spirits"), and prepares the way for the reference to spiritual beings in 3:22.2. Yet this second approach depends upon a controverted interpretation of Gen 6:1ff,³¹ and it is not obvious why their fate is closely connected with the building of the ark, which was in no sense prepared for their benefit.

To my mind, one of the more important points to consider is 2 Pet 2:4-5, since there the same writer engages with closely related ideas. As indicated in the previous paragraph, that passage can in some measure be used to support either approach, in that (1) Noah is shown to be a preacher and (2) the angels are said to have been judged. But the second point connects to this passage quite specifically, because "spirits" are lexically likely to be angels; and because 2 Pet 2:4 refers to Tartarus, a place of confinement and torment that aptly ties in with "prison" here. To my mind, this consideration tips the balances in favor of the second approach—though the scales have only moved with much hesitation! (The comments on 3:20.1 below will flesh out my understanding of this passage a bit more.)

Where does this leave the interpretation of 3:18-20 as a whole? Christ, in the Spirit, announced his decisive victory over Satan to the demons. When he did this is not stated. The words "made alive... by the Spirit" (3:18.3) might well imply that this was at or after his resurrection, though in some respects the basis for the victory was the work of the cross (cf. 3:18.1). In any case, for as much as Jesus' earthly work was finished (cf. Jn 19:30, Heb 1:3), the Spirit remains with him (cf. Jn 1:32, Heb 9:14). Combined with the following reference to "the patience of God" (3:20.1), the Trinity is again invoked (cf. on 1:2.4), with Christ's redemptive sacrifice appropriately foregrounded.³²

implausible because it reads too much into these verses, misses the contrast that Peter makes between the unbelieving many and the redeemed few, and is incompatible with Heb 9:27.

³⁰ Many interpreters have taken the significance to be quite general—referring, e.g., to all OT saints who had died before Christ came. But Peter's reference to "the days of Noah" (3:20.1) demands that the scope of the statement is relatively limited.

³¹ The controversy is basically whether "the sons of God" (בני האלהים) in Gen 6:2 refers to angelic beings—or to humans under their control—rather than, as many prefer to hold, to descendants of Seth.

³² An addendum: many churches use one version or another of the so-called "Apostles' Creed," in which case there is some question concerning the Latin words *descendit ad inferos*. Depending on whether this phrase is accepted (it is not found in all the pertinent sources, though some might prefer to use it whether it is original to

3:20.1 *who formerly were disobedient when the patience of God waited in the days of Noah as the ark was being prepared:* The word “formerly” (πποτε) does not imply that these beings are *now* obedient, only that this obedience happened at a fairly definite point in the past. The time period referred to is that referred to in Gen 6:1ff. The ark took a great deal of time to construct and prepare.

The word “ark” (κιβωτος) is not the usual word for “ship,” but rather a specialized term referring to Noah’s ship.³³ Like the Hebrew word (תיבה) used in the book of Genesis, the word calls to mind its box-like shape. In contrast to how the ark is sometimes depicted, it was not a cute floating zoo, but (as the dimensions given in Genesis disclose) a massive structure designed to withstand a terrible deluge.

The Greek verb (απεκδύομαι) behind “waited” seems to be quite forceful (“wait impatiently,” is Montanari’s [233a] rendering, though of course this is not literally true of God). The enormity of the waiting is underscored in that the grammatical subject is not “God,” but “the patience of God” (in other words, God considered in his aspect of being patient). The grievous offenses of the earth would have caused anyone other than God rapidly to bring utter destruction.

3:20.2 *in which a few (specifically, eight) souls:* Noah; Noah’s wife; their sons Shem, Ham, and Japheth; and the wives of those three sons (Gen 6:18, etc.) were saved by being in the ark.³⁴ Why does Peter specify the number? Perhaps he aims concisely to emphasize that his “few” does not mean “a small number,” but “a very small number.” The Anatolian readers can take a certain comfort in the fact that although the vast majority of their neighbors are unbelievers, that does not mean that they, the minority, escape God’s notice.

3:20.3 *were saved through [the] water:*³⁵ Noah, his wife, and his sons and sons-in-law were delivered from the death that the floodwaters would have brought had God not instructed them to build the ark.

3:21.1 *with respect to this water baptism as an antitype now saves us:*³⁶ A type is a person, an event, or an idea that, though real in itself (and therefore not allegorical), points to someone or something far beyond itself; it is a kind of foreshadowing that God, as the author of history, can and does create. An antitype is the person or thing to which a type points. The place of typology has in recent centuries been

the creed or not), there are questions as to how most biblically to render it and understand it. Particularly if it is translated “descended into hell,” then there are questions concerning how biblical this phrase is. For instance: Jesus is said here to have “gone,” not “descended”; he was not, even temporarily, under Satan’s control; and he did not offer a second chance for salvation to those who were dead. Sometimes the phrase is rendered along the lines of “descended to the dead,” which is better in that Jesus definitely died (though redundant, since the creed has already indicated such in a previous line). If the oldest form of this creed lacked this line, then such a lack is evidence that progress is not always forward progress; sometimes less is more. Individual conscience should dictate whether some version of *descendit ad inferos* is recited or not, but I would suggest that no such line be included in a creed used by the Church today, for it goes beyond any clear teaching of Scripture, and might in fact be unbiblical. For more discussion, see esp. Bavinck, 3:410-417.

³³ The English “ark” and the Greek κιβωτος also often refer to the “ark” of the covenant (e.g., Josh 3:3), but the Hebrew in that expression is different (ארון).

³⁴ The Greek for “soul” here is ψυχη, not πνευμα (this latter noun being key in 3:18.3 and in 3:19.3).

³⁵ 3:20.2-4 could perhaps also be translated “into which [ark] a few (specifically, eight) souls fled for safety from [the] water” (cf. Grudem, 169); it is difficult to translate into English, though the general sense is not in doubt.

³⁶ This rendering I borrow from Davids (129; for discussion, see 143); the Greek is difficult (cf. also Jobes, 260). I have, however, modified Davids’ rendering slightly: I prefer the reading “us” (ημας) over “you” (υμας), since I count it somewhat unlikely that the majority of manuscripts would have erred at this point, especially there might have been a temptation to assimilate the majority reading ημας in 3:18.2 or to exclude the famous apostle from the need for baptism.

gainsaid by some interpreters, but passages like this one—and many others—demand that typology constitute an important element in biblical hermeneutics, and many books dealing with this topic have appeared in recent decades. The place of allegory is less clear (certain translations of Gal 4:24 notwithstanding).

At any rate, Peter describes the waters of Noah as a type of the waters of baptism. The correspondence between the two things is inexact, but such is the nature of typology (if type and antitype were the same in every respect, they would not be the thing pointed to and the thing that points to, but the *same* thing). Noah's passage through the ark—a vessel prepared at God's command (Gen 6:14ff)—prefigures the Anatolian believers' salvation through baptism—a rite enacted at Christ's command (Mat 28:19-20).

Peter has already established (1:5.1) that salvation is by faith. So in what sense does he say that baptism saves? He will, partly at least, clarify this matter in the words that follow.

3:21.2 *not the removal of dirt from the flesh, but a pledge from a good conscience to God:* Water obviously serves a hygienic purpose, but that is not what Peter is referring to in 3:21.1.

What is he referring to instead? Some translations have something along the lines of “an appeal to God for a good conscience.” In this case, the person getting baptized is either asking that the salvation available in Christ, symbolized by baptism, be applied in God's mercy to him or her; or that God would help this new believer, launching out on a new life of faith, to live rightly going forward. Either way, however, it is not clear that the Greek (ἐπερωτημα) can mean this. Rather, as indicated in the rendering above, the meaning is apparently rather that before or at baptism someone makes a good-faith pledge, viz. a sincere indication of one's devotion to God. That the pledge comes from the person being baptized (rather than her or his father or parents) seems to me the most natural way to read the passage, though Peter does not speak directly to that question. That the pledge is specified as coming from a good conscience might allude to the cleansing from sin that one receives upon receiving Christ, or it might emphasize that the baptism rite as such does not save (rather, the attitude behind it does). Baptism saves in the sense that in it a person commits herself or himself to *God*—the pledge is “to God,” not to any false god, to one's ancestry, or to one's own abilities or merit. Above all, in the light of the analogy of the rescue of Noah and only seven others, the pledge is to look away from the world and its ways and to God as one's sole source of salvation. In that sense it is a means of grace.

3:21.3 *through the resurrection of Jesus Christ:* Once again Peter makes Jesus' resurrection from the dead the basis for any efficacious hope.

3:22.1 *who, [now] at the right hand of God, has proceeded into heaven:* Jesus' ascension and heavenly rule ensure the present blessing and eternal salvation of his people (for the thought, cf. Eph 1:15-23).

3:22.2 *angels and authorities and powers having submitted to him:* Jesus' victory is total: no being, even the noncorporeal (angelic or demonic), no matter how great in influence or ability, no matter how potent in ways seen or unseen, dares or can resist his will. Jesus' enthronement is not titular, but real.

4:1.1 *Therefore, with Christ having suffered on your behalf in the flesh, you also arm yourselves [for war] with the same mindset:* Peter now takes the discussion of suffering, of living well, of Christ example, and of Christ's victory over all (3:13-18) in a slightly different direction: in the light of Jesus' cross-work (his suffering in the flesh, as the apostle labels it here) the Anatolian believers are challenged to say “no” to sin in their own lives. Here, as often in the NT, there is an “already/not-yet” element: Jesus' victory is complete (3:22.1), but his followers still need to wage war (4:1.1). The imagery of D-Day in World War II

is often invoked, and it is not far off the mark: once the Allies had successfully formed a beachhead in France, the fate of Hitler's Germany was sealed, though many battles remained to be fought.

4:1.2 *for he who has suffered in the flesh has put an end to sins*: This could be read as a general maxim (i.e., sufferers cease from sin), but Peter does not see value in suffering *as such* (cf., e.g., on 2:19.4), so the clause is best understood as a Christological statement (i.e., Christ defeated evil; cf., e.g., Rom 8:1ff). For another view, see Jobes (262-266).

4:2 *so that the remaining time in the flesh you may live not for humankind's lusts, but rather for God's will*: Whatever proportion of readers' lifespan was spent in sinful lifestyles, driven by human desires where these stood opposed to God's desires, Peter urges them to spend the remaining time on earth in earnest pursuit of God's ways.

4:3.1 *After all, the lifespan that has [already] passed is sufficient for you to do the will of the gentiles*: The tone is ironic: it is not that whatever sins they have committed were in their time necessary, but that their number by no means ought to be increased. A slight paraphrase would be "the sins that you committed in the past were more than enough, and now it is time for a turnaround!"

4:3.2 *spent in outrageous behaviors, in lustful actions, in drunken incidents, in wild festivals, in drinking parties, in godless idolatries*: The list of desires that formerly drove them—and continue to drive the nations around them—revolves around (1) social events and (2) excessive or misplaced sensual inputs (alcohol, sex, shouting, etc.). Peer pressure is a major driver of sinful acts, as is unrestrained pursuit of pleasure. The "godless idolatries" are acts of "worship... not authorized by God" (Davids, 151).

4:4 *concerning which they think is strange that you do not rush to the same wasteful excess, badmouthing [all the while]*: The general reaction of unbelievers engaging in such activities to believers who refrain from these activities is perplexity. And more than that, anger. Whether the ridicule is directed toward the Christians who (in their view, foolishly) keep away from wild parties and the like, toward the Christian God who causes people to be so (apparently) stingy, or both, Peter does not specify; but probably the first option is meant, esp. given the latter part of v6.

4:5 *they will give an account to him who is ready to judge the living and the dead*: "While the Christians may feel abandoned by God and unable to defend themselves, it is their accusers, not they, who have a problem, for the detractors will have to answer to God" (Davids, 152). Whether a man or woman is dead or alive at the coming of Christ, none will escape his unprejudiced and complete examination, leading either to eternal damnation or unending joy (Mat 25:31ff, Rev 20:1–15).

It is difficult to render this in English, but this verse is an aside: the grammatical pronoun is a relative pronoun (οἱ) referring back to those who are surprised at the morality of Christians, not a personal pronoun such as one would expect (and that mostly likely with some sort of conjunction) for an independent statement. The overall train of thought (4:1-6) is that Christians must and do live differently after their conversion than they did before.

4:6.1 *because for this purpose the "dead" indeed were told the good news*: This is a difficult verse.³⁷ I take it as follows: Peter takes the last word of v5 ("dead," νεκρός), and changes its meaning in order to

³⁷ It is to be noted that there were no English-style quotation marks in ancient Greek writing, so, while I have added quotation marks to "dead" to signal that the sense is figurative, the Greek does not tip its hand as to whether the spiritual or physical death is in view.

change his readers' perspective. Now, superficially these words here could be taken to mean that a second chance at salvation is offered to people after death, but not only does this run counter to biblical teaching elsewhere (e.g., Lk 16:19ff), but it also undercuts Peter's warning concerning the finality of judgment (4:5). Rather, in using "dead" here in v6, Peter is, like Jesus (Mat 8:28, and this likewise following a more literal usage of the term in the previous verse) using the term metaphorically: the believers of Asia Minor were once, like their neighbors, spiritually dead (cf. Eph 2:1). Yet the gospel has gone forth, and it has reached their hearts.

Many commentators think that the dead here are the physically dead at the time that Peter writes to the Anatolian believers. In other words, the dead "are those who are now dead but who heard the gospel in their lifetime" (Bavinck, 4:631; similarly Davids, 153-155; Jobes, 270-273; Schreiner, 205-210; Sproul, 126). But the argument that Peter would not use the word νεκρός to mean spiritual death seems to me a weak one, little more than an argument from silence (viz., the absence, in two brief epistles, of a clear instance of this usage elsewhere). A stronger argument is that of Jobes, who notes that the phrase "the dead" in 4:5 "forms half of a merism that refers to all humanity in all ages, whether physically alive at the moment or dead" (271). But the statement in 4:5 is, as noted above, an aside, not the main point of the paragraph; and a shift in meaning of some kind is necessary in any case, since in 4:5 the reference to both the righteous and the wicked (though the latter are in focus there), while here only the redeemed "dead" are in view (for the gospel preaching is efficacious—see 4:6.2). I think Peter is thinking of how his readers were once spiritually dead, just like those who now cannot believe that they refrain from sinful passions; but I hold this position tentatively, and the position sketched at the beginning of this paragraph could well be correct.

4:6.2 *so that they might be judged on the one hand by men in the flesh, but might live on the other hand because of God by the Spirit:* The difficulties of 4:6 continue. Peter's catchy, succinct Greek could be understood (and translated into English) in a variety of ways. For instance, "judge" here could refer to "popular opinion... or official action" (Jobes, 271). But it is clear that the apostle is contrasting the unholy world's assessment of Christians from that of God above (cf. Mat 5:11-12). The former condemns; the latter blesses.

4:7.1 *Now the end of all things has come near:* Peter uses the same word for "has drawn near" (ἤγγικεν) that he heard John and Jesus use many years prior (Mat 3:2, 4:17) with reference to the kingdom of God. The NT believer lives in the "last days" in which God's definitive revelation has been given in the person of his Son (Heb 1:2). Much has happened in history since the resurrection and ascension of Jesus Christ, but in a very real sense it is all a footnote. The key point for humanity is that Jesus has come, and could return at any moment.

4:7.2 *So then, be attentive and sober for the purpose of prayers:* The reality that human history is hurtling toward in dramatic conclusion should, the apostle reminds his readers, move them to sober, rather than frivolous, thinking; and in particular to devote themselves to prayer (cf. Ac 2:42).

The word "prayers" is literally "the prayers," presumably meaning prewritten prayers and/or prearranged times for prayer. There is ample precedent in the Scriptures for extemporaneous prayer, but the book of Psalms is in large measure a collection of written prayers. Both have their place.

4:8.1 *And above all, be intentional in loving one another:* Once again (cf. 1:22.4, 2:17.2, 3:18.3) Peter emphasizes the need for love. The immediate context of this emphasis is instructive: the apostle sees no contradiction in saying that believers should be fervent in their prayers but also loving toward one another; one, properly exercised, does not crowd out the other. No one should be too busy to pray, nor too occupied with prayer to lend a helping hand.

4:8.2 *because “love covers a multitude of sins”*: Peter is paraphrasing the second half of Pr 10:12. The first half of that verse mentions stirring up strife. So the second half of Pr 10:12 probably deals not with forgiveness or expiation of sin, but rather with forbearance—with a resistance of the urge to revisit the hurt that a sin caused.³⁸ Peter is then implying that although offenses are inevitable (cf. Jm 3:2), when his readers make every effort to show love, the worst effects of sins will be blunted.

“Nothing will destroy a church faster than pettiness, people picking at each other over trial things... We all bring baggage into the Christian life; we are each at a different point in our progression” (Sproul, 135).

4:9 *Being hospitable to one another without grumbling*: The believers of Asia Minor are—differences of culture, class, and native language notwithstanding—to be hospitable to one another. And their compliance cannot be merely formal and external, but must be heartfelt and internal.

4:10.1 *each person, inasmuch as he [or she] has received a gift*: Every believer, Peter says, has received a gift from God. He does not say when the gift was received (whether before, at, or after the moment of salvation); the point is that every believer has (at least) one.

4:10.2 *employ it in the service of one another as good stewards of the varied grace of God*: The gift is not the same; in fact, it varies considerably from person to person. The same point is made elsewhere (Rom 12:6ff, 1 Cor 12:4ff).

But whatever its nature, each gift is entrusted by God to a Christian with the expectation that it will be put to good use. The gift is not for one’s self alone, but is for the benefit of other believers. While Peter’s words are meant to be applied to the whole week, Spoul’s (138) comments about Sunday bear repeating: “Countless times I have heard people complaining after a church service, ‘I didn’t get anything out of it.’ I want to ask them what they put into it. They come to have their needs met, but the preacher does not preach to meet the felt needs of the people.”

4:11.1 *if one speaks, as [speaking] God’s words; if one serves, as [serving] with the strength that God supplied*: To flesh out the point he has just (4:10.2) made about the variability of gifts and the need to use them, Peter supplies two examples. (1) In the first example, Peter addresses those who “speak,” and tells them to speak “as [speaking] God’s words.” Of the various Greek terms Peter could have used for “words,” he chooses λογία, which is elsewhere used to refer to Scriptures. Accordingly, it seems that what Peter has in mind in this example is the exposition of Scripture. Such people as have been given a talent for explaining and proclaiming the truths of the Bible must do so fully cognizant of the tremendous value that the Scriptures have.

(2) In the second example, Peter addresses those who “serve,” telling them to do so with the recognition that their strength comes from God. That strength is required shows that Peter is not using “serve” in some abstract sense—old-fashioned elbow grease is required! It is perhaps not coincidental that this word for “serve” (διδάσκω) is the word from which “deacon” (διδάσκων) is derived; or that it is the very verb that Peter himself long ago used to describe the physical distribution of food to the needy in Ac 6:2, in a passage where he calls of the apostles to devote themselves to prayer and to the ministry of the word (admittedly, in that verse he uses a different word [λογος] for “word”). Peter might be calling for pastors and deacons to fulfill the differing roles that each has. One is not better than the other; both are necessary, and both derive their power from divine enablement.

³⁸ Gen 9:23 might be related: by covering their father, Shem and Japheth ameliorated the effects of Noah’s sin.

The universality of v10 (“each person”), however, should preclude any notion that only pastors or deacons can serve; everyone can, and everyone must, if the whole church is to flourish. But perhaps the two offices of the church represent in a sense two basic kinds of gifting, of which countless variations exist: the intangible and communicative on the one hand, and the direct and constructive on the other, kindness in word and kindness in action alike.

4:11.2 *in order that in all things God may be glorified through Jesus Christ:* The goal of all of this is no less than the glory of God. His Son purchased a people who, working together, live lives that show that glory and strength are not theirs, but God’s. The significance of followers of Jesus using their gifts to serve one another is cosmic and epochal.

4:11.3 *to whom be the glory and the strength forever and ever. Amen!:* Here we have a doxology, that is, an ascription of “glory” (δόξα, *doxa*) to God. In ancient times, doxologies often “appear as sectional closings” (Davids, 163), rather than at the very end of a sermon or document. Peter is indeed shifting focus, starting in v12, but does so on the note that God’s greatness and power are to be recognized unendingly.

The word “amen” (אמן) is Hebrew, borrowed into Greek on the basis of its various appearances in the OT and continued use in late Second Temple Judaism; the term at heart means “trustworthy,” and is used as a “solemn formula” to accept or round off a formulation or doxology (Koehler and Baumgartner, 1:64a).

4:12 *Brothers and sisters, do not be surprised at the fire for testing that appears among you, as though something strange was happening to you:* Believers encountering trials, particularly severe ones (hence Peter’s fire imagery), might be perplexed, feeling either that their sin has brought it on, or that Christ’s victory ought to have removed all such difficulties from life. Peter aims to get out ahead of such surprises, alerting his readers ahead of time that trials are a normal part of the Christian life. He makes a comment about these difficulties, saying that they are πρὸς πειρασμόν. The first word could mean “for the purpose of” or “resulting in,” and the second word could mean “testing” or “temptation.” There are a number of similarities of theme and verbiage between this passage of 1 Peter and the first part of James chapter 1. The interpretation of πειρασμόν in Jm 1:12 is also disputed, however. Probably Peter is, as he approaches the end of his epistle, reiterating some of the thoughts with which he began: in 1:6-7 he combined the ideas of present trials, genuine faith, and the coming revelation of Jesus Christ, all ideas that are important in this paragraph. Difficulties in the Christian life are tests, rather like that Abraham faced in Gen chapter 22.

4:13.1 *But to the extent that you participate in the sufferings of Christ:* As in 1:6, Peter does not assume that all Christians inevitably will face great trials, or that misery is the Christian’s constant companion. Yet Christians do face troubles because of their Christianity, and that on a sliding scale from relatively slight trouble to horrific pain.

As mentioned above (on 1:1), “Christ” is Greek for “messiah,” the one that God in OT times promised would come to deliver his people. This coming would entail glory, but also suffering (see esp. Isa 52:13-53:12).

4:13.2 *rejoice, in order that in his glory which is to be revealed you may rejoice with overwhelming joy:* As the level of pain increases, Christians can increase in their joy, for in doing so they anticipate the boundless joy that will be theirs at the second coming of Christ. Jesus’ great glory will be something they share, just as, in a sense, they share presently in the sufferings of Christ.

4:14.1 *If you are reviled in the name of Christ, “blessed”!*: If the believers of Asia Minor are libeled or ridiculed because they are followers of Jesus, then the statement of Jesus in Mat 5:11-12 are true in their case. Cf. the comments on 3:13.

4:14.2 *For the Spirit of God and of glory rests upon you—he who is ridiculed on the one hand by people, but glorified on the other hand by you*: Persevering under false accusation is evidence that the Holy Spirit has taken up residence within them. This is fitting, because the Spirit himself experiences the same dichotomy: unbelievers revile him, even as believers extol him (cf., e.g., Mat 12:22ff).

4:15 *For no one among you is supposed to suffer because he is a murderer, or a thief, or an evildoer, or a meddler*: Peter repeats the point (cf. esp. 2:20) that perseverance is not particularly praiseworthy if the suffering has been brought on by being an insufferable nuisance.³⁹

4:16 *but if [anyone suffers] because he is a Christian, he should not be ashamed, but glorify God in this destiny*: The shame involved in suffering as a Christian is apparent, not real. Peter speaks from personal experience when he talks about gladly bearing shame for the sake of Christ (Ac 5:41).

4:17 *For it is the time for the judgment to begin from the house of God, and if first from us, what will be the fate of those who disobey God’s gospel?*: Peter might have in mind Mat 25:31ff (or some similar sermon he had heard Jesus preach) in which Christ first judges the righteous, then judges the wicked (though Grudem [189-191] and Schreiner [227] point to Eze 9:6 and Mal 3:1ff). In any case, if even God’s own people face his searching examination, then those outside his people, whose sins are grievous, ought to tremble.

4:18 *And if the righteous is saved only with difficulty, where will the impious and the sinful be?*: Peter again makes use of a text in wide usage at the time, viz, the OG translation of Pr 11:31. While it is true that salvation is by grace, not works (Eph 2:8-9), precisely this lack of merit, combined with the myriad distractions and temptations of this world, makes it a narrow escape and a rare exception in the course of human history for a son or daughter of Adam to avoid death’s dogged pursuit. Davids (172; see further Jobes, 294) is right to point to such passages as Mk 13:19-20, and Lk 13:23-24. The wicked, meanwhile, having disregarded the summons of the gospel (1 Pet 4:17), are not the undeserving forgiven but the undisputedly guilty.

4:19 *Accordingly, those who specifically suffer according to God’s will should entrust their souls to him, as to a faithful creator, while doing what is right*: Peter sums up with a call to imitate the behavior of Christ as described in 2:23. God, the author of all things, can be trusted, even with suffering, and this trust forms a background against which the good works prepared for God’s people (cf. Eph 2:10) can be actualized.

5:1.1 *Elders*: Peter now addresses the ecclesiastical leaders in various congregations of Asia Minor. The instructions which will follow will make clear that Peter does not mean simply “those advanced in age” here. Rather, using a technical sense of “elder” (πρεσβυτερος) inherited from the OT (זקן), he refers to certain men (cf. 1 Tim 2:12) charged with acting as leaders within the church. Nowadays, there is considerable diversity in the meaning applied to “elder” in Christianity; likewise with the term “pastor.”

³⁹ The believers in Asia Minor listened well to Peter’s exhortations, for half a century later a governor of Pontus and Bithynia could find nothing objectionable in the conduct, except that they worshiped God alone (e.g., Pliny, *Letters* 10.90-97).

Since Peter does not specifically call on the elders to preach or teach, it could be supposed that their office is distinct from that which teaches the church. But this is a tenuous argument from silence, and the implication of v2 below that the elders of Asia Minor receive pay for their work argues against the idea that these elders are lay leaders. Moreover, the strong language of this paragraph in general suggests a full-time, high-stakes vocation. In light of passages like 1 Tim 3:1ff, I think it makes the best sense of the scriptural data to see NT elders as fulfilling the same role as.

5:1.2 *I urge, as a fellow elder and a witness of the sufferings of Christ and also a participant in the glory that is about to be revealed:* The apostle applies three labels to himself: (1) “fellow elder”; (2) “a witness of the sufferings of Christ”; and (3) “also a participant in the glory that is about to be revealed.” Evidently, Peter wishes for the elders in his audience to know that when he exhorts them, he does so as someone who has taken on the duties of eldership himself (at the Lord’s command—see Jn 21:15ff);⁴⁰ and to know that he, like they, has seen suffering, and will, with them, one day see God’s glory. Situating the elders’ work within the wider arc of God’s working in human history—again and again the OT prophets speak of times of intense trouble followed by times of great glory, with Christ as the hinge of history—Peter prompts elders to view their work in proper perspective. Christian leaders often bear a high degree of suffering for the faith, yet they must remember that God’s plans are not thereby being frustrated, and that the future splendor of the God’s kingdom on earth will make present trouble and toil worth the effort.

5:2.1 *shepherd the flock of God:* Peter gets into the substance of his exhortation to the elders. The elders are to “shepherd the flock.” This is an excellent metaphor for a number of reasons. Shepherding would have been a familiar, easily visualized concept for many in the ancient world. Furthermore, to be a shepherd is to blend the role of leader and provider. Finally, there are many biblical precedents for picturing leaders as shepherds, including God himself (Ps 23, Jn 10:11ff). Indeed, Peter will soon say (5:4.1) that Jesus is the chief shepherd, the elders of the Church being under-shepherds. The flock does not belong to the elders, but to God. Carelessness towards one’s own sheep would be bad, but carelessness towards God’s sheep would be worse—especially when it is recalled that this flock was purchased at the price of Christ’s blood (Ac 20:28).

5:2.2 *among you:* It is unclear to me whether this (ἐν ὑμῖν) means “among you,” that is, in your proximity; or “under your care.” Either way, there is not—or should not be—any distance between the elders and the flock. Pastoring cannot be done from a detached distance. Pastors to some extent need their books (cf. 2 Tim 4:13), but they should not live in an ivory tower.

5:2.3 *exercising oversight not under compulsion, but with eagerness:* Peter describes (starting here and continuing into v3) the attitude with which the elders are to oversee the flock with a series of three “not X, but Y” constructions. In the first place, elders are to serve “not under compulsion, but with eagerness.” The meaning is that external force must not be what impels the labor; if at times men might need some prodding (cf. Col 4:17), no one ought to force people to be elders. Paul affirms much the same thing (cf. 1 Tim 3:1).

5:2.4 *and not greedily, but zealously:* The motivation should not be monetary gain, but inward zeal. An assumption underlying this word of caution is that elders ought ordinarily to be paid (cf. 1 Tim 5:17). But

⁴⁰ This can be seen in Acts chapter 15 where Peter refrains from any appeal he might have made to his apostolic authority, instead allowing those gathered to consider the matter and coalesce around a solution.

Peter's main point here is that money—and arguably large amounts of money; but at all events money acquired through unethical means—should never be something elders are pursuing.

5:3 *not lording it over those under your charge, but acting as examples for the flock*: The men must not bludgeon their flock into submission, but rather make themselves living object lessons of humility. “The greatest among you will be your servant” (Mat 23:11). The word κληρος can bear a variety of senses, but the fact that it is plural here and that it is here parallel with “flock” shows that the meaning in context is “those [congregants] entrusted to you[r pastoral care].”

5:1-3 It is evident that Peter has set out principally to describe the attitude with which elders should approach their work. He has not set out fully to describe the functions of the eldership, though he has dropped broad hints in using the language of shepherding and of oversight. Curiously enough, there is a parallel approach to be found in 1 Timothy chapter 3 and in Titus chapter 1, for those passages sketch out the qualifications of the office, but offer no direct and sustained discussion of the duties of the office. From these and other passages (e.g., Ac 20:28) it is evident that spiritual leadership and instruction are key elements of pastoral work. But the NT does not reduce the duties of the office to any specific, quantifiable list; the implementation of pastoral oversight is in fact broad, flexible, and variegated. The diverse gifts and temperaments of the men involved and the needs and circumstances of the people under their care ideally will dictate the exact form that the elders' care takes.

5:4.1 *And when the chief shepherd is manifested*: Not only can the elders of Asia Minor count the apostle Peter as one of their number and sympathetic to their trials and temptations (5:1.2), but they can also look to Jesus Christ, who exercised leadership, gave instruction, and indeed gave himself for his flock; but of course, the elders do not look to Jesus as an *equal* in this respect, but as their leader, their “chief shepherd.” At present, Jesus is hidden from human eyes, waiting at the Father's side in heaven, but one day he will be fully visible and revealed in all his glory and power to the inhabitants of the earth.

5:4.2 *you will take hold of the unfading crown of glory*: When Jesus is revealed, the elders will be crowned. (Peter here, thinking the best, states matters with the assumption that his elder readers will in fact discharge their duties responsibly). Commonly in the Greco-Roman world successful athletes, and to a lesser extent victorious soldiers and other notable individuals, would publically be awarded a crown made of laurel leaves as a sign of acclaim. God will in a sense likewise publicly celebrate those among the elders who persevere through the hardships of their task, but with an “imperishable” crown. Jesus will never forget his pride in his children, and his warm approval will eternally be known. It is sometimes asked whether this reward is unique for pastors. Probably in a sense it is (cf. Rev 2:17), but it is also true that all believers will receive due recognition for their labors from God at the proper time (1 Pet 5:6).

5:5.1 *Similarly, you who are younger, submit to the elders*: Peter's term “you who are younger” is unexpected, but since he has just addressed elders, and since elsewhere he uses the term “similarly” (ομοιως) to pivot from one complementary group to another (cf. 3:1.1), the apostle surely means “you who are not pastors,” “the laity.” A reference to literal age is out of place for the reason that, as just mentioned, vv1-4 clearly describes pastors in particular, not older people in general. A reference to junior members of the clergy is still less likely: this would be the only passage in the NT indicating a distinction between senior and junior pastors,⁴¹ and it would be strange to shift more markedly (by

⁴¹ To see the grammatical singular in 1 Tim 3:1 as implying a single senior pastor to whom various junior pastors are accountable reads quite a bit into the passage, especially in the light of the plural in 1 Pet 5:2; similarly Rev 2:1 (especially given Ac 20:17).

means of ομοίως) between two subdivisions of the clergy, while shifting more subtly (by means of δε) from the clergy as such to the church as a whole in the last part of the verse (5:5.2). This circumlocution is not surprising: the emerging institution of the church cannot be expected to possess a fully worked-out terminology for its various elements. In short, Peter is calling on the various congregations of Asia Minor to submit to the leadership that the various elders provide.

5:5.2 *And all of you, submitting to one another, wrap yourselves in humility, since “God opposes the proud, but gives grace to the humble”*: Having just called on the “younger” to submit to the elders, Peter seemingly proceeds to contradict himself: all of his readers should submit to each other. But the contradiction is rhetorical, not real: to be sure, elders must lead, and congregants should follow; but Christians, whether clergy or laity, should be deferential to one another, considering others as more important (Phil 2:3). Surely there are times when it is good and appropriate for the leadership of a church to discard its collective opinion in favor of the definite wish of the congregation.

In any case, all believers, whatever their position in the church, must be known not for their authority, opinions, or stubbornness, but for their humility. Humility should cover and protect church members just as clothing covers and protects the human body. In support of this claim, Peter quotes what was surely a well-known text,⁴² viz. the OG rendering of Pr 3:34. The prideful work at cross-purposes with God; the humble receive his assistance. Christ came to serve (Mk 10:45), and so should Christians.

5:6 *Submit yourselves, then, under the mighty hand of God, so that he might exalt you at the proper time*: For humans, submission is not a natural act. So the apostle reminds his readers that submitting to one another in this way is really submitting to God, whose power is great (“hand” being a common Semitic and biblical idiom for capacity). Because his power is great, God can be trusted to vindicate his people. Even if submissive Christians find themselves for a time underappreciated, God will publicly declare their great value at the proper time. It will be worth the wait.

5:7 *Placing all your cares on him, because he cares about you*: Swallowing one’s pride tends to involve surrendering one’s autonomy and exposing one’s vulnerabilities. Peter’s readers should combine their humility toward one another with trust in God. In a play on words that thankfully works well in English, the apostle tells them to give⁴³ their “cares” to God, because God “cares” for them. God is not annoyed that his earthly children have needs and concerns; he is a heavenly Father who is aware, attentive, and affectionate (cf. Mat 6:25-34 for much the same train of thought).

5:8.1 *Be alert; be watchful. For your adversary, the devil, roars like a lion, seeking someone he can devour*: Peter repeats again (cf. 1:13.2, 4:7.2) the need for a sober mindset and a diligent attitude. This time he adds a new consideration: the devil continually seeks opportunity to wreak havoc.⁴⁴ This is certainly something Peter experienced firsthand (Lk 22:31), making this exhortation and poignant one.

5:9.1 *Resist him, firm in the faith*: Believers must resist the devil. Peter does not list any elaborate techniques of, e.g., identifying demonic strongholds and tearing them down through some strategem of

⁴² Quoted also in James 4:6, though whether the fame of the text is a cause or an effect of its use there is uncertain.

⁴³ The verb here is more stark in some translations, but cf. Montanari (787b).

⁴⁴ I speculate that “the devil” here might be shorthand for “the devil, or one of the evil angels who follow his lead”; in other words, not every Christian might attract the personal attention from the devil, but should be braced for attack from the devil’s hordes, even Satan himself. But certainly Satan, though not omnipresent, travels widely (Job 1:7); and in any case, Christians must take Peter’s words here quite seriously.

prayer, as is sometimes recommended these days. Rather, Peter calls on his readers to resist by being “firm in the faith.” Arguably, this could also be translated “firm in faith,” i.e. “exercising decisive faith,” but the presence of the Greek article, plus the reference to the global brotherhood—that is, Christian as such, wherever on the globe they find themselves—suggest that the meaning is “maintaining your Christian faith,” “resisting any pressure to abandon it and the allure of every other worldview.” Ultimately, Satan wants people to disbelieve Christ as to God’s eternal worth, but faith in the holy one must win out.

5:9.2 *knowing that the same sufferings are being fulfilled by your brotherhood in the [whole] world:* The believers of Asia Minor are not alone in the struggle. They can comfort themselves in the fact that this spiritual warfare is shared by the redeemed of the whole earth. God’s works are always much bigger than first meets the eye.

5:10 *And the God of all grace, who called you into his own eternal glory in Christ Jesus, will, after you have suffered a little while, personally restore your strength; he will steady, strengthen, establish [you]:* The ultimate grounding of the Anatolian believers’ confidence in their struggle against Satan is in God. God finishes what he starts (Phil 1:6), and, having called them to share in Christ’s eternal glory, he will protect them from satanic assault. At least in hindsight, every trial will seem brief; and God’s provision will far outweigh any privation experienced—Peter piles on verb after verb in his effusive labeling of God’s empowering intervention.

5:11 *To him be the glory and the strength for ever and ever. Amen!:* Another doxology (cf. 4:11.3). God, having shown his mighty arm, will be praised, and that forever. To this sentiment Peter adds his heart “amen!”

5:12.1 *Through Silvanus, the faithful brother (as I regard him):* Silvanus (another form of Silas, on whom see Ac 15:22ff) is the letter-carrier, not a coauthor (see Jobes, 320). Still, it is important that a mail carrier be trustworthy, when the integrity of the message—here, the words of an apostle spoken to God’s people—is important, so Peter assures his readers that he holds Silvanus (whom few, if any, of the churches in Anatolia are likely to have met previously) in the highest regard.

5:12.2 *I have briefly written to you, exhorting and testifying this to be the true grace of God in which you have taken your stand:* It takes quite a small investment of time to read Peter’s letter out loud. Indeed, to the extent that Peter intended his letter to be a kind of sermon, he was extremely brief (the author of Hebrews says [13:22] of a letter about three times as long as 1 Peter that (s)he has been brief). This apostle cannot be accused of not being respectful of people’s time.

Nor has Peter majored on the minors in his letter. The content of his letter, he says, is summed in the words “the true grace of God.” On “grace,” cf. on 1:2.5 and 1:10.2. This letter has outlined God’s undeserved kindness and what it looks like to be a participant in it.

5:13.1 *The one in Babylon who is likewise chosen greets you:* “The one in Babylon” is surely a fellow local church (the word for “church” in Greek [ἐκκλησία] is grammatically feminine, and the words here are feminine). Some specific locale seems to be meant (note the grammatical singular). “Babylon” in this instance has generally been taken as a reference to Rome. It is by no means impossible that the actual city of Babylon is meant (there was long a significant Jewish community there, and at some relatively early date Christian or pseudo-Christian movements were present in the area), but of all possible locations from which to pass on greetings, why mention that one? Given the rampant wickedness of the Roman empire and the status of Rome as its capital, it would not be too surprising for Peter to refer to it

this way, and Peter might well have spent considerable time there (Jobes, 33-36). Moreover, a non-literal “Babylon” here would fit well with the (mostly) non-literal sojourning motif in the epistle (see 1:1.3).

5:13.2 *as does Mark, my son*: Mark is not Peter’s literal son (cf. Ac 12:12, Col 4:10—these passages surely would have been worded differently otherwise), but a close, though younger, friend of his. Credible church tradition says that Mark wrote his gospel largely based on Peter’s recollections of his time with Jesus. Based on his specific mention here, it can be speculated that Mark served as Peter’s assistant in some important capacity—rather like Moses had Joshua and Paul had Timothy.

5:14.1 *Greet one another with love’s kiss*: Peter encourages warm greetings among his readers. The culture at that time permitted non-sexual kissing as a greeting, at least between individuals of the same gender. Churches situated in other cultures might express this principle differently (as with hugs, bows, or the like), but the underlying truth should not be missed: Christians should cultivate very warm relationships and greet one another with great affection.

5:14.2 *Peace be to you all in Christ Jesus. Amen!*: To all—men and women, old and young, rich and poor—Peter pronounces “peace,” something achieved “in Christ Jesus” (so also Rom 5:1). He imparts affirmation and warmth to this benediction with the time-honored Hebrew word of his youth and his old age: “Amen!”

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